

2026-2027

Student & Family Handbook

Updated Sep 9, 2026

Table of Contents

Table of Contents	2
Purpose of Student and Family Handbook	6
About UWC Costa Rica	8
Mission	8
Principles Embedded within Our UWC Costa Rica Mission	8
Our Values	9
Commitment to Sustainability	9
Sustainability Framework	10
Community Values in Action	10
Our Educational Model	13
Experiential Learning	14
Portrait of a Graduate	16
Statement of Accessibility	16
Academic Program	18
International Baccalaureate (IB) Mission and Diploma Programme	18
IB Learner Profile	19
IB Learner Profile within the UWC Framework	19
How an IB Diploma is Attained	20
Subject Selection	22
IB Registration	27
IB World Exams Administration and Results	27
Physical IB Diploma or Completed Certificates Receipt	30
Academic Integrity at UWC	31
Grades	35
Inclusive Access to Learning	44
Potential Need for Withdrawal	46
Library Services	47
Classroom Standards of Dress	50
Use of Classrooms After Hours	50
Future Pathways	50

Co-Curricular Program	60
Co-Curricular Initiatives	60
CAS Experiences	64
Community Action Through a Sustainable Lens	66
Funds for Co-Curricular Activities	67
Equipment for Student-Led Activities	68
Representing the College in External Events	68
Residential Life & Wellness Program	70
Residential Life and Wellness Program	71
Student Health	71
Residential Life	79
Living in Community	108
Community Meetings	108
Emergency Drills and Severe Weather Preparedness	109
Purpose of Drills	109
Types of Drills Practiced	109
College-Sponsored Excursions & Safety and Supervision	110
Emergency College Closing and Repatriation	110
Visitors and Volunteers	111
Students with Visiting Family Members	112
Safeguarding & Reporting	114
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	114
Attendance Policy	116
Importance of Attendance Beyond Academic Classes	116
Attendance Expectations	117
Authorized/Excused Absences	117
Unauthorized/Unexcused Absences	119
Attendance Roles and Responsibilities	120
Academic Absence Management	120
Unexcused Absences: Academics	120
Co-Curricular Absence Management	123
Participation Expectations	123

Unexcused Absences: Co-Curricular	124
Residential Life & Wellness Absence Management	125
Participation Expectations	125
Unexcused Absences: Residential Life & Wellness	126
Missing Scheduled Off-Campus Activities	126
Fees	127
Attendance & UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate	127
Completing the Educational Journey	129
Completion Certificate of UWC Costa Rica Experience	129
Academic Parameters	129
Attendance Parameters	130
Graduation	130
Awards and Honors	130
Graduation Holds	132
Graduation Exclusion	132
Financial Aid and Continuation of Enrollment	133
Family-Initiated Withdrawal from the College	133
Code of Conduct	136
General Expectations for Student Conduct	136
Standards of Dress & Grooming	137
Mobile Phones	138
Structure	138
Offenses	143
Examples of Restorative Actions	154
Host Country Laws & Disciplinary Processes	155
Adherence to Host Country Laws	155
Cooperation with Local Law Enforcement	156
Age of Majority and Right to File Charges	156
Legal Counsel and Financial Responsibility	156
Notification to Parents/Guardians	156
Separate Internal Investigation and Disciplinary Process	157

Disciplinary Outcomes	157
Support in Disciplinary Processes	157
Amnesty & Leniency	157
Other Supportive Measures	158
Due Process for Expulsion or Suspension	160
Timing	162
A Note on Dishonesty	162
Student Leadership	165
Who can apply for Student Leadership positions?	165
Student Council	165
StuCo Administration: Bridges	166
Residence Assistants (RA's)	168
Wellness Ambassadors	170
Student Publications	171
Guidelines for Student Publications	171
General Services	173
General Services	174
Campus Food Services & Guidelines	174
Meal Service Times and Options	174
Food Waste	175
Allergies, Diet Restrictions, or Needs	175
Responsibility to Return Plates and Utensils	176
Drinking Containers	176
Ordering Food Delivery or Groceries	176
Campus Gym	176
College Transportation: Provision and Use	177
Airport Shuttles	178
Immigration Office Travel and Visa Information	178
College Support and Responsibilities	178
Visas and Passports	179
Deadlines and Emergencies	179
Student Travel and Visa Cancellation at Graduation	180

Importance of Document Consistency: No Name Changes	180
Maintaining Consistency in Personal Documents	181
Guidelines for Students and Families	181
Security on Campus	182
Security Deposit	183
Communication	184
Communication	185
Students & Staff	185
Families/Guardians with Students	186
Costa Rica Customs Clearance (for your awareness)	186
Families/Guardians with Staff	187
UWC Costa Rica Management Team	187
Glossary of Terms	189
Citation	195

Purpose of Student and Family Handbook

The **Student and Family Handbook** aims to provide students, their families and guardians key information related to the student's journey, our educational model, academic requirements, conduct, community standards, rules and communication requirements to successfully navigate the UWC Costa Rica experience. It is meant to serve as a guide to understand the expectations placed upon students and the guidelines that steer student life. The Handbook includes our **Code of Conduct**, which encourages honesty, integrity, respect and fosters an atmosphere of mutual care. All UWC Costa Rica students are to abide by the expectations set forth.

About UWC Costa Rica

About UWC Costa Rica

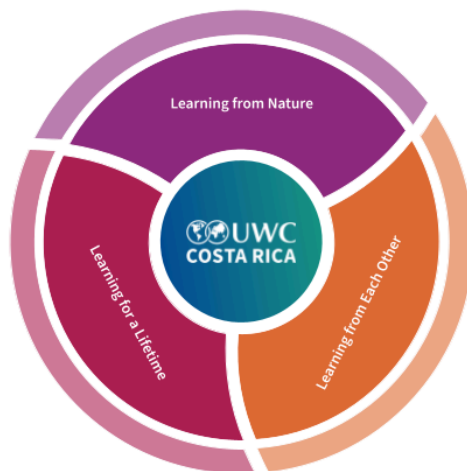
United World College (UWC) Costa Rica was founded in 2006, as part of the UWC global movement that seeks to make education a force to unite people, nations and cultures for peace and a sustainable future. Along with the other 17 UWC Colleges, our College strives to embody these ideals as students navigate their time on campus in Costa Rica and the important work they will do upon graduation.

For 60 years, the heart of the UWC's mission has been grounded in the belief that when people understand each other better and see each other as less "foreign" or different, they can work together to solve small challenges in the College community and apply those practices to working on larger problems in the wider world.

Mission

United World College Costa Rica is a non-profit foundation offering a two-year residential pre-university program grounded in an experiential learning model. Our mission is *to cultivate in young people the passion and ability to serve humanity and our planet—learning from nature and from each other for a lifetime.*

Principles Embedded within Our UWC Costa Rica Mission

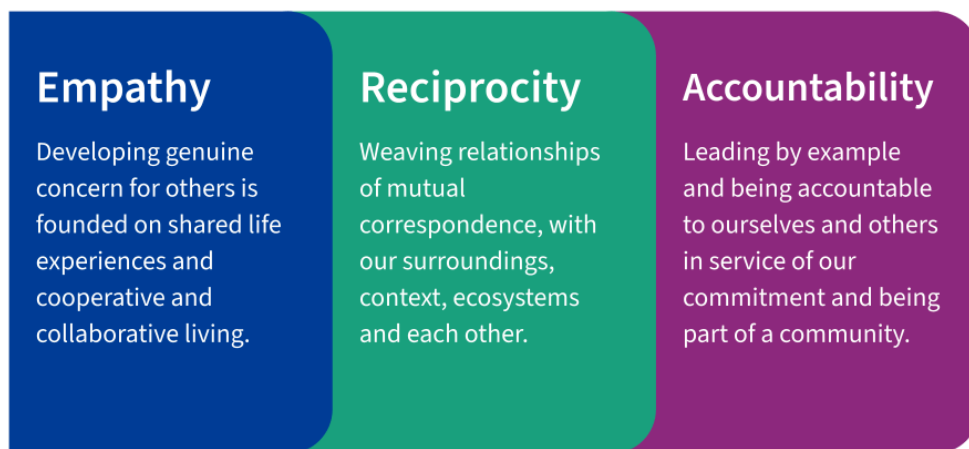


"Nature is our biggest teacher: experiencing it and learning from its processes leads us to understand ourselves as part of a community of life and to take responsibility for its care."

(UWC Costa Rica Sustainability Framework, p. 10)

Our Values

Our core principles shape the character of our organization and its people. These values serve as our moral compass, guiding both our thinking and actions. They define how we interact with the world and each other, influencing our behaviors and decisions. We aspire to place these core values at the center of all we say and do, reflecting our dedication to fostering an environment of mutual respect, compassion, and integrity. This commitment ensures we consistently strive to create a sustainable and peaceful future through education and leadership.



Commitment to Sustainability

UWC Costa Rica is committed to sustainability, integrating it into all aspects of our educational approach and organizational structure. Our core principles prioritize caring for people and the planet while fostering economic and social development. Through transformative education, we guide individuals towards a better, sustainable future. We value diversity, preserve wild nature, promote social justice, build community, and practice responsible resource use.

The following are examples of our sustainability principles:



Care



Nature



Education



Impact
& Economy



Reciprocity
& Continuity



Community
& Diversity



Social Justice
& Governance



Responsible Use
& Resources



Sustainability Framework

For more information and opportunities to engage, please refer to our "[Sustainability Framework](#)" and/or [Sustainability Framework Executive Summary](#) documents, which outline our comprehensive sustainability principles, strategies, and actions.

Community Values in Action

The UWC mission and values are to be put into action in our learning community. To do this, UWC Costa Rica believes in:

- Celebrating Diversity:** We celebrate differences both formally and informally through student-led cultural sessions, week-long events that showcase the music, art, dance, literature, food, and other cultural elements and traditions of different world regions, as well as affinity groups and religions. We also seek to educate our community through the work of Anti-Racism, Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion as well as students dedicated to understanding global issues and their impact. More importantly, we delight in the differences we discover as we live, learn, study, and grow in a close community of students, faculty, and staff from diverse backgrounds and worldviews.
- Personal Responsibility and Integrity:** As a community, we place a high value on personal responsibility and integrity. We seek community members who have a strong sense of right

and wrong, personal accountability, empathy, and respect for themselves and others. When mistakes are made, we expect the offender to take ownership and undertake restorative action to make amends or accept the stated consequences of their actions.

- **Mutual Responsibility and Respect:** We work and grow together best in our living and learning community when we trust, respect, and care for the well-being of one another. When we leave UWC Costa Rica, we can more easily work to tackle the biggest world challenges, together with new partners.
- **Compassion and Service:** Our students reach out to others because they feel a powerful desire to connect. So do our alums. The UWC mission only makes sense if students and alums go forward and spread the values and messages of our institution with their wider communities. Our mission comes alive as we form powerful communities that support and help one another.
- **Respect for the Environment and Space:** Our mission asks us to learn from and appreciate the environment we live in and to be good stewards of the resources we have. Costa Rica is one of the most interesting and beautiful places on planet Earth, with half a million species. While it takes up only 0.03% of the earth's surface, Costa Rica contains nearly 6% of the world's biodiversity. While at UWC Costa Rica, we learn to be good stewards of the water, soil, flora, fauna, and general ecosystems around us. We expect all community members to care for and conserve the physical and environmental resources available on campus.
- **A Sense of Idealism:** Our students are curious risk-takers who want to challenge themselves with a wider lens to explore who they are, their purpose, and how they can make a difference in ways they had not ever imagined. Aligned with the ideals of critical thinking, we invite students to constantly ask, "What if...?", test their idealism, and learn the power of resilience as they encounter roadblocks.
- **Personal Challenge:** It is challenging to ask difficult questions about one's own beliefs, to make friends with people who are not like you, who may have differing views of the world than you, and to do projects in rural or wilderness areas outside one's comfort zone. It is challenging to do this while taking on the rigors of a serious academic program. However, it is through these challenges that students learn the most about themselves and grow.

Our Educational Model

Our Educational Model

At UWC Costa Rica we have an educational model based on experiential learning and carried out through our **three main programs**, with **sustainability** as a cross-cutting theme:



Our holistic approach provides students with a powerful experience that exposes them to academic rigor, service-based projects, exercise, cultural exploration, community living and being part of a highly diverse group of people away from their home countries. Students gain leadership, intercultural, negotiation and analytical skills that prepare them for their next steps in life.

Academic Program: UWC Costa Rica follows the International Baccalaureate's (IB) Diploma Programme (DP) curriculum. It consists of 6 subject groups and the DP core, which includes Theory of Knowledge (TOK), Creativity, Activity and Service (CAS), and the Extended Essay (EE). These components allow students to reflect on the nature of knowledge, complete independent research, and undertake a project that involves community service.

Co-curricular Program: This pillar of our educational model, embodies our mission and values of reciprocity, respect and accountability, by providing experiential learning opportunities to our students that cultivate the passion to serve humanity and the planet. Activities include IB's CAS (Creativity, Activity and Service), Community Action Week, thematic weeks, community action days, getting to know Costa Rica outings, tournaments, Agents of Change trainings, Model United Nations, and other initiatives where students can connect to local communities and learn about the diversity of our student population.

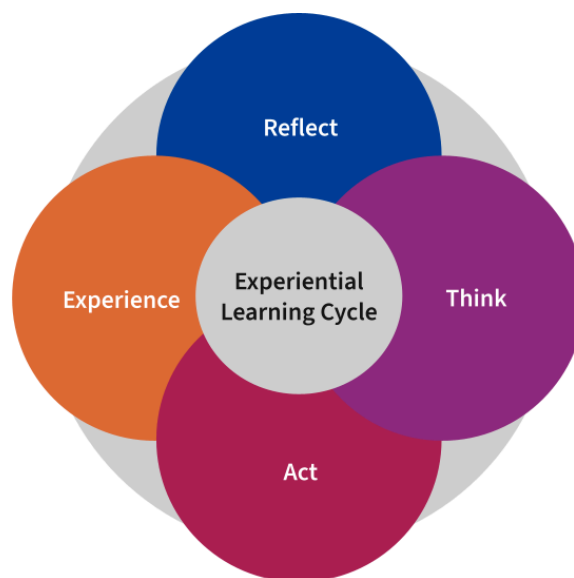
Residential Life & Wellness Program: Community living is central to the UWC Costa Rica experience as we learn from each other's cultures and worldviews. The Residential Life & Wellness Program includes Residence Coordinators, counselors, night coordinators, paramedics, nurses and other professionals who provide services and experiential learning activities to foment student wellness, safety, a healthy learning environment and balanced lifestyles. Activities include outings, camps, residence meetings, check-ins, dinners, movie nights, meditation, amongst others.

Sustainability: Sustainability is being embedded across all aspects of the College, including our educational model (pedagogical focus, curriculum, programs, and projects), promoting learning from nature, and new pedagogies for the future.

It is essential for students to actively participate in all of our educational model components in order to graduate from UWC Costa Rica and carry our mission forward.

Experiential Learning

Experiential education is a philosophy that asserts that students learn most effectively when engaged in activities that aim to make the abstract more concrete through direct experience and focused reflection. The “learn by doing” approach and experiential learning cycle, allow students to experience, reflect, think and act.



Our educational model has an experiential approach to learning where students participate in diverse activities including lectures, site visits, host family interactions, reflections, camps, discussions, community meetings, living in community, and project-based learning.

Reflection

Reflection is a key element of our educational approach, enabling students to actively engage with their learning process and set meaningful goals for improvement. Our teachers and educators select key learning opportunities pre-, peri-, and post-unit/activity for students to reflect upon their own learning and progress towards objectives. This reflection cycle is ongoing, encouraging students to evaluate their understanding and areas for growth continuously.

Through reflection, students deepen their understanding, enhance their metacognitive skills, and take ownership of their learning journey, aligning with our commitment to fostering personal responsibility, integrity, and academic excellence.

Forms of Reflection

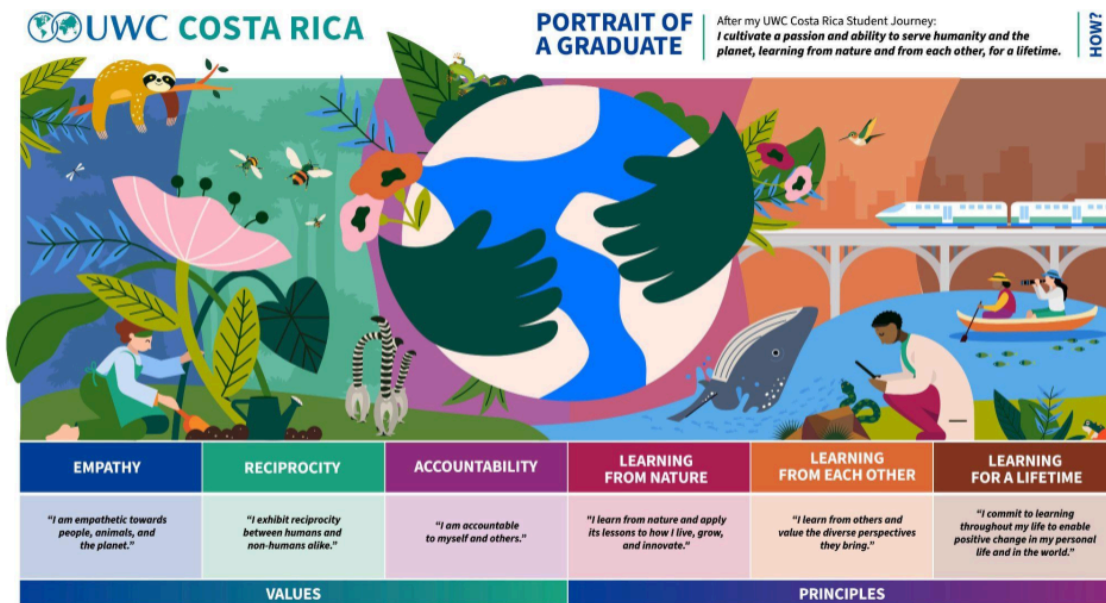
Reflection may take various forms, including, but not limited to:

- **Journal entries:** Students document their thoughts, insights, and challenges faced during the learning process.
- **Peer feedback:** Students provide constructive feedback to their peers and reflect on the feedback received.
- **Goal setting:** Students set short-term and long-term goals based on their reflections and track their progress over time.
- **Discussions:** Students engage in reflective discussions with their peers, educators and teachers, sharing their insights and learning experiences inside and outside the classroom.
- **Surveys and focus groups:** Students participate in these to think about the experiences they have participated in and their learning.
- **Portfolio assessments:** Students compile evidence of their learning and reflect on their achievements and areas for development.

Portrait of a Graduate

Our educational model and journey are designed so that once students complete it, they are better prepared to embark on the challenges and opportunities of their next phase in life after secondary school and in the future. UWC Costa Rica students will have acquired tools, skills and knowledge to live our values and ***cultivate a passion and ability to serve humanity and the planet, learning from nature, from others and for a lifetime.*** This framework serves as our compass for decision-making, teaching practices, and curriculum design.

The following image summarizes the “portrait of our graduates” and the values and principles they will carry.



Statement of Accessibility

UWC Costa Rica is committed to creating an inclusive and accessible environment for all students, their families/guardians, and staff. Efforts are made to facilitate participation in programs and activities, regardless of abilities or cultural and linguistic backgrounds. When necessary, adjustments will be made to foster greater inclusion and eliminate barriers, ensuring a welcoming and respectful community. Additionally, the College strives to adhere to Costa Rica's Law 7600, which mandates equal opportunities for individuals with disabilities to accommodate diverse needs.

Education Area:

Academic Program

Academic Program

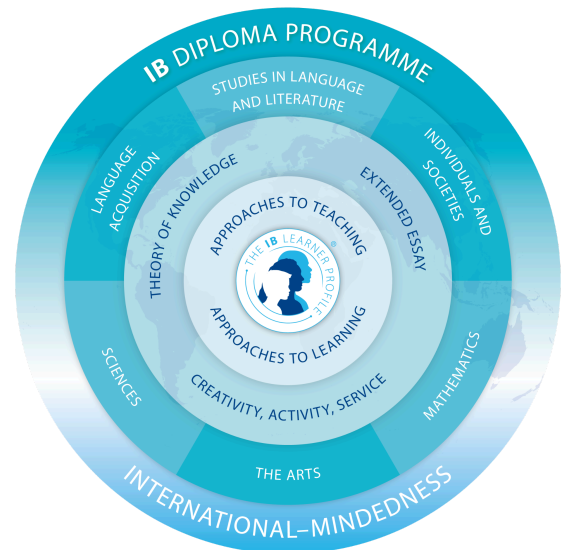
Our two-year, pre-university academic program is based on the International Baccalaureate Diploma Program (IBDP). The rigorous IB coursework is complemented by the co-curricular and residential life and wellness programming.

International Baccalaureate (IB) Mission and Diploma Programme

The International Baccalaureate® (IB) aims to develop inquiring, knowledgeable, and caring young people who help to create a better and more peaceful world through intercultural understanding and respect. The IB programs encourage students across the world to become active, compassionate and lifelong learners who understand that other people, with their differences, can also be right¹.

The **Diploma Programme (DP)** is a rigorous pre-university course of study designed for **students in the 16 to 19 age range**. It is a broad-based two-year program that aims to encourage students to be knowledgeable and inquiring but also caring and compassionate. There is a strong emphasis on encouraging students to develop intercultural understanding, open-mindedness, and the attitudes necessary for them to respect and be able to evaluate a range of points of view.

The DP is presented as six academic areas enclosing a central core (see accompanying graphic). It is this comprehensive range of subjects that makes the Diploma Programme a demanding course of study designed to prepare students effectively for university entrance. In each of the academic areas students have some flexibility to choose subjects that particularly interest them and that they may wish to study further at university².



¹ IBO. "Our Mission - International Baccalaureate®." *Our Mission*, ibo.org, 6 June 2023, www.ibo.org/about-the-ib/mission/.

² IBO. "Computer Science Subject Brief." https://www.ibo.org/globalassets/new-structure/university-admission/pdfs/dp_comps_subject-brief_may_2022_e.pdf, 1 May 2022, www.ibo.org/globalassets/new-structure/university-admission/pdfs/dp_comps_subject-brief_may_2022_e.pdf.

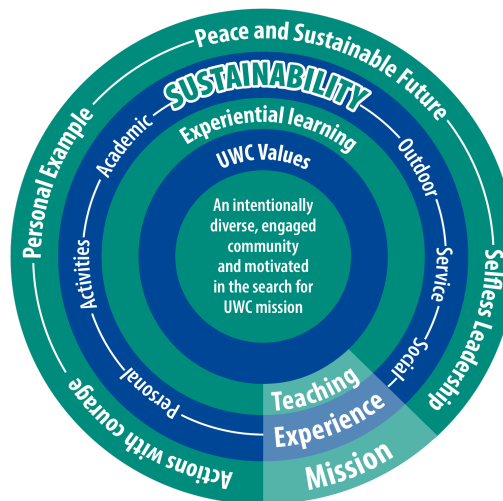
IB Learner Profile

The International Baccalaureate® (IB) learner profile describes a broad range of human capacities and responsibilities that go beyond academic success. They imply a commitment to help all members of the College community learn to respect themselves, others and the world around them. The profile aims to develop learners who are:



IB Learner Profile within the UWC Framework

The International Baccalaureate® (IB) learner profile seamlessly aligns with and enhances the key values upheld at UWC Costa Rica, including empathy, reciprocity, and accountability. The IB learner profile, with its **emphasis on inquirers, thinkers, communicators, and knowledgeable individuals, fosters a culture of international and intercultural understanding, echoing UWC's celebration of diversity.** Moreover, the IB's commitment to developing principled, caring, and open-minded learners resonates deeply with UWC's values of mutual responsibility and respect, as well as compassion and service.



Furthermore, the IB learner profile's focus on risk-taking, balance, and reflection harmonizes with UWC Costa Rica's emphasis on personal challenge and action. By encouraging students to embrace personal responsibility and integrity, the IB learner profile complements UWC's mission of nurturing happy, healthy, and committed individuals capable of fostering positive change. Together, these complementary frameworks cultivate students who are not only academically successful but also

empathetic, accountable, and equipped to contribute meaningfully to a more sustainable and peaceful world³.

How an IB Diploma is Attained

Being awarded the IB Diploma depends on the successful completion of specific internal and external assessments and examinations and additional components. Receiving the IB Diploma is NOT based on the internal report card grades that students receive during the two years. Students are notified of their scores on IB assessments by the International Baccalaureate Organisation in July, following their completion of World Exams in May.

Conditions for the Award of the Diploma

Students are assessed in six subjects, each graded on a scale of 1-7, with 7 being the highest grade. Students can earn up to 3 points from two core components (TOK, EE). To earn the IB Diploma, a student must receive **24 or more points** (for a maximum total of 45) and meet the following requirements:

- Numeric grades (as opposed to an “N” standing for “No grade”) have been awarded in all six subjects registered for the IB diploma.
- All CAS (Creativity, Activity, Service) requirements have been met (see CAS Section under Co-Curricular Program for more details).
- Grades A to E have been awarded for both Theory of Knowledge (TOK) and an Extended Essay (EE), with a grade of at least D for both. E does not pass (see matrix below).
- There is no grade 1 in any subject.
- There are no more than two grade 2’s awarded.
- There are no more than three grade 3’s or below awarded.
- At least 12 points have been gained on Higher Level subjects (see below for more information on HL and SL subjects).

³ United World College Costa Rica. “UWC Costa Rica Strategic Plan 2022 - 2027.” UWC Costa Rica, 2022.

- At least 9 points have been gained on Standard Level subjects⁴.

Attaining Further Distinction through an IB Bilingual Diploma

In addition to the usual diploma, a "bilingual diploma" can be awarded to a candidate who:

1. Completes two languages selected from group 1 with a grade 3 or higher in both.
2. Completes one of the subjects from group 3 or group 4 in a language that is not the same as the candidate's group 1 language. The candidate must get a grade 3 or higher in both the group 1 language and the subject from group 3 or 4⁵.

Assessment of Student Work and Point Requirements

For Theory of Knowledge (TOK) and the Extended Essay (EE), the **grades are on a scale of A to E**, with A being the highest. TOK is a seventh class that students take with components to complete, but there is no final exam. The EE is introduced in year one, worked on by students during the holiday between years 1 and 2, and then finished for submission in year 2. Each student is assigned a supervising teacher to guide them through the process, but they work independently and are challenged to complete this scholarly work in an area of interest beyond their regular classwork.

Final IB grades are a combination of Internal Assessments, marked by teachers and moderated by the IB, and External Assessments – exams and other work marked by IB-certified examiners. Between 20-30% of the marks in each subject are based on Internal Assessments.

Each subject counts for a maximum of 7 points, allowing for a total of 42 points. Theory of Knowledge and the Extended Essay, can add a total of 3 points more to the IB score, **bringing the maximum total to 45**. Apart from various failing conditions (described above), **a candidate needs 24 points to earn the IB Diploma**. Incomplete work in any subject, the Extended Essay, Theory of Knowledge, or Creativity-Activity-Service (CAS), makes the candidate ineligible for the IB Diploma.

Predicted Grades

The predicted grade is the teacher's prediction of the grade the candidate is expected to achieve in the subject at the end of the course, based on all the evidence of the student's work and the teacher's knowledge of IBDP course standards (called the 'Grade Descriptors'). Universities may often ask for

⁴ "Diploma Programme Assessment Procedures 2024." IBO, Sept. 2023.

⁵ "DP Passing Criteria - International Baccalaureate®." DP Passing Criteria, IBO, 13 May 2024, www.ibo.org/about-the-ib/what-it-means-to-be-an-ib-student/recognizing-student-achievement/about-assessment/dp-passing-criteria/.

predicted grades as part of the admissions process, and our Future Pathways Program counselors coordinate and disburse this information (see more information on Future Pathways section below). These predicted grades could potentially be adjusted through to April of the final year. Predicted grades are also submitted to the IB at the end of the two years.

IB Course Certificates

An IB Diploma candidate who is unsuccessful at satisfying the requirements for the award of an IB Diploma may be awarded one or more IB Course Certificates indicating the passing grades obtained in individual subjects, together with results in Theory of Knowledge (TOK), the Extended Essay (EE) and the completion of the CAS requirements. Students who do not pass the IB Diploma while at UWC Costa Rica can attempt to pass again at a later session by enrolling in another school in a convenient location for them. **UWC Costa Rica only pays for the May session. If a student needs to do exam retakes, the cost will be covered by the student and their family/guardians.**

Subject Selection

The College provides a comprehensive support system and personalized guidance to ensure students select the best possible pathway towards achieving an IB Diploma. The registration process begins with an online description of all course offerings, followed by an Academic Fair shortly after arrival, where students engage directly with subject teachers to explore course details and requirements. Then, diagnostic tests in languages and mathematics and individual mentoring sessions are designed to help students identify their interests, assess their aptitudes, and understand the full spectrum of offerings available to find the right courses which align with their interests and academic goals.

Teachers, Future Pathways counselors, the IB Diploma Programme Coordinator (IBDP Coordinator), and the Academic Director work closely with students as mentors to navigate the complexities of course selection. They ensure that each student's academic journey is tailored, to the greatest extent possible, to their unique needs and ambitions, fostering a sense of ownership and empowerment in their educational path.

IB's Academic Integrity Declaration

Students are required to read and sign the **IB's Academic Integrity Declaration**. Their signature confirms that they understand they should avoid academic misconduct, defined as *any action that results in them gaining an unfair advantage in any assessment components, or any action which*

disadvantages another student. The IB specifically states that academic misconduct can occur intentionally or inadvertently. Throughout their two years with us, students are reminded of instances when this could occur, and how to avoid it.

Academic Fair

The Academic Fair, held during orientation of arriving students (First Years), is an opportunity to learn about the different subjects offered and selection requirements. Prior to attending the Fair, students are strongly encouraged to read all the available course information on our [Academic Fair Portal](#). Students can then ask subject teachers questions to better understand the nature of the subject, the different components, and how the course will be conducted and assessed.

Course Registration

Once the Academic Fair, placement tests, and mentoring sessions have been held, each student will submit their final course choices and levels (standard or higher) for scheduling purposes. While the academic office endeavors to fulfill the student's choices, factors such as course availability, class size limitations, and placement test results are considered when making final schedules. Students will be called in for individual meetings with the IBDP Coordinator and Academic Director if there is any problem with the subjects selected.

While the academic office endeavors to fulfill the student's choices, factors such as course availability, class size limitations, and placement test results are considered when making final schedules.

Courses Offered

In the 2026-2027 academic year the following Standard Level (SL) and Higher Level (HL) courses are intended to be offered (if 7 or more students enroll):

Group 1 Studies in Language and Literature	English Literature (SL/HL)
	English Language and Literature (SL/HL)
	Spanish Language and Literature (SL/HL)
	School Supported Self-Taught Literature (SL)

	*In other languages apart from English and Spanish that are accepted by the IB. In case a language is not on the IB list, the school can make a special request to the IB for the language to be included.
Group 2 Language Acquisition	Spanish Ab Initio (SL) Spanish B (SL/HL) English B (SL/HL) French B (SL/HL)
Group 3 Individuals and Societies	Economics (SL/HL) Global Politics (SL/HL) Psychology (SL/HL) Historia (NM/NS) Anthropology (SL/HL) Environmental Systems and Societies (SL/HL)
Group 4 Experimental Sciences	Biology (SL/HL) Physics (SL/HL) Chemistry (SL/HL) Environmental Systems and Societies (SL/HL)
Group 5 Mathematics	Applications and Interpretations (SL) Aplicaciones e Interpretaciones (NM) Analysis and Approaches (SL/HL)
Group 6 The Arts	Visual Arts (SL/HL) Theater Arts (SL/HL)

HL = Higher Level/ SL= Standard Level

Higher and Standard Level Courses

At UWC Costa Rica, students must choose **three subjects at the Higher Level (HL) and three at the Standard Level (SL)**. The IB awards the same number of points (1-7) for HL and SL courses, reflecting the IB's belief in the importance of achievement across various academic disciplines.

HL and SL courses differ in scope but are assessed against the same “grade descriptors,” with HL candidates expected to demonstrate the various elements of the grade descriptors across a greater

body of knowledge, understanding and skills⁶. HL courses have three lessons per week and SL have two lessons. All lessons are 80 minutes long.

While in some subjects, HL and SL students have separate classes due to the more in-depth content and faster pace of the HL curriculum, in other subjects, both HL and SL students may learn together. However, there may be times when SL students finish classwork early and are dismissed from classes, or they may work independently on assigned tasks while the teacher introduces HL-specific material.

Subject Availability and Class Scheduling

Subject availability depends on a variety of factors, including the offerings from both the College and the IB, class size limitations (typically 16-18 students, depending upon the classroom size and balancing teachers' workloads), staff availability and credentials, as well as scheduling logistics for the teaching spaces. Additionally, 7 or more students must show interest in a course before the College will consider if it is a feasible offering given staff availability. While the College strives to accommodate everyone's preferred subject combination, students and their families should remember that class sizes and scheduling constraints may require flexibility. If a first-choice combination of courses is not possible, the team of mentors, counselors, and leaders will support the student in developing an alternative combination that aligns as closely as possible with their interests and goals.

Placement Tests: Languages & Mathematics

Placement tests for languages and mathematics are conducted during orientation to determine the appropriate course and level for each student. These tests help ensure that students are placed in classes that provide an appropriate level of challenge and support for their development. Decisions made in this regard are aligned with IB guidelines, which state:

"C1.4.3 Placement of students in language acquisition courses

It is extremely important that students be appropriately placed into DP language acquisition courses. Misplacement of a student into a language acquisition course would likely not allow the student an appropriate degree of challenge for development in that language and may provide the student with an unfair advantage over those who are appropriately placed into the course.

⁶ "Diploma Programme Assessment - International Baccalaureate®." Understanding DP Assessment, IBO, 4AD, www.ibo.org/programmes/diploma-programme/assessment-and-exams/understanding-ib-assessment/.

Intentional misplacement of a student into a DP language acquisition course that does not provide an appropriate degree of challenge for the student may be considered College maladministration according to the publication Academic integrity policy”.⁷

Students are expected to be academically honest when completing their language acquisition and mathematics placement tests and interviews in a way that will be true to their actual knowledge and experience.

Changes in Schedule/Courses

Once lessons commence, students have a **two-week trial period** to experience their selected subjects. No schedule changes are executed during this period.

Following this two-week trial period, there is an additional **four-week window** during which students may request changes to the courses they selected. Please note that changes during this period are subject to course availability and class size limits as well as the IB expectations related to standard and higher-level courses (SL/HL). Changes to languages and mathematics may be restricted due to placement test results.

After the four-week window, students are not allowed to request changes to their schedules. Exceptional changes will only be considered if initiated by teachers or Future Pathways counselors.

Teacher and Future Pathways Counselor Initiated Changes

While students may not initiate changes after the designated period, teachers actively monitor student progress and may suggest adjustments if deemed beneficial. Additionally, if a student realizes the need to take a course due to university admission requirements after the initial period, the student can consult with their Future Pathways counselor who may initiate a change request on the student’s behalf. Any changes must be supported by evidence and are subject to availability and class limits.

In language acquisition courses, students may be recommended by their teacher for a level change due to either rapid progress in their chosen course, the course not being challenging enough or being very demanding.

⁷ “Diploma Programme Assessment Procedures 2024.” IBO, Sept. 2023.

IB Registration

From October to November of their second year at UWC Costa Rica, students will undergo **official registration** with the International Baccalaureate (IB). It is imperative for students to meticulously review all provided details, including their full name, nationality, chosen subjects, language and levels. Ensuring accuracy in these details is vital as they should match College registration and university applications, which may also align with visa requirements, particularly if the student holds multiple passports. Upon registration, students will sign a declaration confirming the accuracy of their details, subjects, languages, and levels. Any discrepancies discovered after the registration deadline set by the IB, **typically November 15th**, will incur associated fees for changes, which students and their families are responsible for.

Furthermore, by mid-November of their second year, students will receive their **candidate code, session number, and personal identification number (PIN)** from the IBDP Coordinator. These credentials are paramount for accessing exam results online. To ensure easy access, it's advised to note this information in a calendar invitation, minimizing the risk of misplacement and potential delays. Moreover, students utilize their personal code on the cover sheets of their Internal Assessments (IAs), Extended Essay (EE), and Theory of Knowledge (TOK) Essay submissions, emphasizing the significance of these credentials throughout their IB experience.

Finally, in addition to registration, students will also reaffirm their commitment to academic integrity by signing the **Academic Integrity Declaration**, which governs all IB internal and external components, as well as exams. Students must understand that engaging in any form of academic malpractice on these key IB components goes beyond the College's internal Code of Conduct and its consequences. Even a first offense, if related to one of these key components or exams, can, and often does, impact a student's chances of completing the diploma successfully and/or on time.

IB World Exams Administration and Results

The International Baccalaureate Organization defines the dates and times for IB World Exams, typically starting at the end of April and concluding in the third week of May. The final results of the exams are usually released by the IB to the students in the first week of July and made available online.

Reporting IB Results to Universities

Results are released through a secure website to those universities using the IB's online service, starting at 12.00 noon on July 5th (provided that the IBDP Coordinator has submitted a request for the university results service). For universities that require results in paper form, these documents (transcripts of grades) are printed and sent out in the weeks after results are issued according to university deadlines.⁸

To facilitate this, during late April/early May, as university decisions are being finalized for many students, the IBDP Coordinator will share a spreadsheet with students to serve as a platform to input the information required for transmission to universities via the International Baccalaureate Information System (IBIS). Students do not enter the information on IBIS themselves. By mid-May, the IBDP Coordinator will ensure all necessary information is accurately entered. Not all universities require the transmission of results directly from the IB, so it is the students' responsibility to check if this is the case for them.

For students who miss the deadline for the College submission or have other reasons why they do not choose to declare at the time, they have the option to delay the process and then individually share their results with universities at a later date, as per their circumstances. Reasons a student might make this choice could include differing timelines and processes for admission in other countries, the intention to take a gap year, or not wanting to submit until they see the results for themselves. In such cases, it is essential for these students to remain proactive and stay informed about the deadlines and requirements of their chosen universities.

It is important to note that some universities will ONLY accept results directly from the IB. If our College's internal deadline for this is missed, then students can request their results via the IBO's official website.

Limitation of University Submissions

It is important to note that students are **limited by the IB to select no more than six universities worldwide to receive their results**. Further to that, out of these six universities, no more than three universities can be selected from Canada, and only one university from the USA. The IB charges a fee (currently US\$17) for each additional request that is submitted after the initial request, even if the

⁸ "Diploma Programme Assessment Procedures 2024." IBO, Sept. 2023.

initial request was for fewer than six universities. These restrictions aim to streamline the process and ensure efficient transmission of results to universities.

IB Exam Results Appeal Process

If, upon release of the scores and diploma results, a student wishes to challenge the accuracy in marking on one or more tests, or their scores were insufficient to meet the conditional acceptance of a university, options do exist. Even though results come over UWC Costa Rica's long holiday, either the Academic Office Assistant, IBDP Coordinator and Future Pathways Counselors, under the direction of the Academic Director, make themselves available to guide students and their families on options to have the chance to improve results or to advise on next steps with university admissions. The most common options and where to begin are as follows:

Requesting an Enquiry upon Results (EuR)

This is the re-mark of externally assessed material for an individual candidate. The IBDP Coordinator guides students through the procedure for making these requests (please note that the money must be cleared in the UWC bank account before the request to the IB is made, with the IB final deadline for requests being September 15th). It is important to note that the grade may go up, down, or remain the same. If the grade changes, the fee is refunded. **The fee is approximately US\$130 per candidate/subject** as set by the IB and not subject to negotiation (plus any additional service fees charged by the sending or receiving financial institution).

The current receiving fee in Costa Rica is **US\$45**. UWC scholarship funds are not available to cover these expenses which are the sole responsibility of the student and their family/guardian. Students requesting an Enquiry upon Result (EuR) should also be aware that the remark request will apply to all externally assessed components and exam papers for that course. It is not possible to request only a single component within a subject area to be remarked.

Retaking Exams

If students want to retake the exams, they must find another IB College/school for retakes, as UWC Costa Rica does not offer a November testing session. The IBDP Coordinator can advise on finding Colleges/schools and assist with communicating with them to ensure proper registration once the

student makes the first contact with their chosen IB school. Students and their families must cover associated costs for the retakes and any fees the hosting College/school may charge.

Results & Legalization of the Diploma

In some countries, the IB Diploma Programme Results and Diploma Program Course Results documents need to be legalized by the relevant embassy, and/or consulate to be valid for entrance to universities. The IB Diploma Program (IBDP) Coordinator is responsible for informing candidate(s) of this requirement, which is done by email to all students in March of their second year. The legalization service is managed by the Assessment Division, IB Global Centre, Cardiff, UK, after each examination session.

Note: There are two different IB documents:

- **IB Diploma Programme Results:** The IB legalizes the IB Diploma Programme Results document showing the results that the candidate obtained.
- **Diploma of the International Baccalaureate (IB Diploma):** shows the candidate's name and is legalized only in exceptional circumstances when specifically required by universities.

If required, the procedure will be explained to the student by the IBDP Coordinator, provided the student responds to the email that will be sent in March of the student's graduation year. The legalization of each document incurs a fee, which is currently **US\$ 170 per document**, plus bank fees. The process will not be initiated by the IBDP Coordinator until the fees are received by the College. The IBDP Coordinator must submit requests by June 15th. After this, the student can email the IBDP Coordinator to request assistance or enter their own request on the IB's public website.

Physical IB Diploma or Completed Certificates Receipt

Once the May exam results are released online in July, the IB begins to print IB Diplomas or earned course certificates (for those not receiving the full diploma) and mails them to the Colleges/schools. Those documents typically arrive at UWC Costa Rica between September and early October. In June, the Academic Office will reach out to students and ask them to select their preference for delivery. Options are as follows:

Option	Method	Cost	Estimated Timeline and Other Considerations
1	DHL International Shipping Service	\$70	1-2 weeks. The cost will be deducted from the student deposit.
2	Digital Copy (scanned upon arrival and then emailed if asked for when filling the form)	Free	1-3 weeks from the College's receipt. It is not certifiable or official.
3	Pick Up in Person	Free	Notified ready for pick-up within 1-2 weeks from the College's receipt.
4	Hand Delivery - Have a currently enrolled student bring it home with them next time they travel. An email from the student authorizing a current student will be needed.	Free	Likely received in December/January, or next May.

Academic Integrity at UWC

At UWC Costa Rica, academic integrity is fundamental to our mission of cultivating ethical, responsible individuals who contribute positively to our global community. Upholding integrity, honesty, and personal accountability in all academic endeavors is paramount to fostering a culture of trust, respect, and excellence. Students who engage in actions constituting academic dishonesty also referred to as academic malpractice, will be subject to consequences as outlined in the **Code of Conduct section**.

Students are expected to familiarize themselves with these expectations and examples of infractions. Consequences range from warning and corrective actions up to and including suspension and expulsion, depending upon the level of misconduct and the type of assessment.

What is Academic Integrity?

Academic integrity encompasses the adherence to ethical standards and principles in all aspects of learning, research, and academic pursuits. It involves the honest representation of one's original work, proper attribution of sources, and responsible use of information, ideas, and data.

Why Academic Integrity Matters

- **Fairness:** Maintaining fairness is essential to ensure that all students have equal opportunities for success. Fair assessments accurately reflect each student's achievements and prevent unfair advantages.
- **Trust and Credibility:** Trust in academic qualifications is foundational. Upholding academic integrity preserves the credibility of our institution and the validity of the assessment process, fostering trust within our academic community.
- **Respect for Others:** Respecting others' intellectual property is crucial. Students are encouraged to use the ideas or work of others ethically and to acknowledge sources appropriately, promoting respect and integrity. Students are expected to behave to not create an unfair advantage over their peers.

Student Responsibilities on Academic Integrity

Students play a pivotal role in upholding academic integrity. UWC Costa Rica students are expected to:

- **Adhere to Policies:** of the College and the IB on academic integrity, as outlined in the Code of Conduct.
- **Report:** any instances of academic misconduct or maladministration promptly.
- **Complete all assignments honestly:** and to the best of their abilities, meeting deadlines with integrity.
- **Properly acknowledge sources:** in all submitted work, avoiding plagiarism or unauthorized collaboration. Plagiarism is defined as the representation of another person's work as one's own, including writing in one's own voice and language of submission (not using translation applications to change content).
- **Ensure authenticity of their work:** Refrain from giving or receiving non-permitted assistance.

- **Demonstrate responsible use of the internet and associated artificial intelligence and social media platforms:** avoiding activities that could compromise academic integrity.
- **Communicate with their teachers:** and share draft versions of work in progress, using approved platforms and tools to allow authentication of the work in question.
- **Maintain individual accountability:** do their own work to ensure proper assessment by teachers. Any behavior that obscures or invalidates fair evaluation, such as academic misconduct, is unacceptable.
- **Onus on the Student:** the responsibility lies with the student to maintain integrity. Suspicious behavior, especially under examination circumstances, may be considered evidence of academic misconduct.
- **Avoid Collusion:** Defined as supporting misconduct by another student, including allowing one's work to be copied or submitted for assessment by another, or reviewing the work of a peer without authorization.
- **Not duplicate work:** Defined as presenting the same work for different assessment components, within the same subject or across subjects.
- **Refrain from other behaviors affecting assessment results:** Includes actions that grant unfair advantages to a student or affect another student's results, such as taking unauthorized material into an examination room, engaging in online chatter during assessments, talking during an assessment, or submitting false or corrupted files which allow a time disadvantage to complete the work.

Responsible Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)

The College recognizes the evolving role of AI in education and research. While AI offers exciting opportunities for learning and innovation, it is imperative to maintain academic integrity when utilizing these tools. Further information related to the use and documentation of artificial intelligence, including language translation and data simulation, can also be found in UWC Costa Rica Technology and Artificial Intelligence (AI) Guidelines.

Original Work

Students must refrain from using AI to generate, amend their work, or translate their written content from another language (for example, writing one's paper in their first language and then using a translation device to translate into the required language of submission). Submitting work created or translated by AI undermines integrity and violates principles of honesty. Students must also not engage in behaviors to deliberately evade detection of the use of AI in an academically dishonest way.

Citation Standards and Support

The academic program provides comprehensive support and resources to help students navigate academic integrity and the responsible use of AI. Workshops, guidance from teachers and other academic staff, and open communication channels facilitate a culture of ethical conduct and innovation, preparing students to engage responsibly with emerging technologies in their academic and professional pursuits.

UWC Costa Rica follows the **MLA 9th edition model for format and citation**, which guides expectations for documentation. **MLA 9th and APA** will be the standard used unless a particular subject instructs students to use an alternative format. Students can seek further information and support on citation from their teachers, the College Librarian, the IB Diploma Program Coordinator, or the Academic Director. The College's librarian will organize workshops on how to use both MLA and APA formats.

Authentication of Work Submitted to the IB

Students are responsible for guaranteeing the authenticity of their work and teachers must be satisfied that a student has produced their work and referenced it properly. Tools available to teachers and students to verify authenticity exist and teachers will set clear expectations about what format and where assignments need to be submitted.

For work submitted to the IB, students must complete both a first draft and a final draft as part of the authentication process. Teachers use several methods to check authenticity, including viewing the history of documents that students share with them when they commence a piece of work, interviews with students, and use of plagiarism-checking software. Students should work on Google docs or a software teachers can have access to at any time, as this will allow a smooth authentication process. When a teacher uploads a student's piece of work to the IB, they must guarantee that the student's

work is their own, to the best of their knowledge. If, under any circumstance, a teacher feels that they cannot authenticate the work, it will not be submitted. This means that the onus is on the student to prove beyond a reasonable doubt that the work is their own.

When a piece of required work is not submitted, then the student receiving the full IB Diploma is in serious jeopardy. Sometimes, and depending upon the IB deadlines to submit the work, a student may be permitted to make corrections and/or redo the work entirely. Circumstances may also exist whereby the deadline cannot be met, and the student would have to prepare the work to be submitted for the November IB administration of exams, meaning there would be a delay in the chance to complete the diploma and possibly impacting the timing of university admissions or meeting conditional offers already in place. In this case, the cost to submit in November should be covered by the student and their family. In all cases where academic malpractice is related to a mandatory IB component, it will be considered a major infraction of the Code of Conduct and could result in suspension or expulsion, depending upon the student's cumulative record of disciplinary infractions during the year.

Grades

At UWC Costa Rica, assessment is not just a measure of academic progress; it's a tool for fostering continuous learning, personal growth, and responsibility. We believe in providing constructive feedback and guiding students towards achieving their full potential.

Formative Assessments

Formative assessments and feedback are ongoing processes that facilitate an exchange of information between students and teachers. Teachers seek to gather evidence, analyzing, interpreting, and using it for the student's benefit. Formative assessments are integrated into the curriculum as a means to inform students about their progress towards learning objectives and guide teachers in tailoring instruction to meet students' needs and maximize learning.

- **Teacher feedback** may take the form of verbal corrections or commentary, notes to the class on general performance observations, written notes on individual work, grades/scores which indicate degree of mastery, symbols to indicate degree of success, and such.
- **Peer assessment and feedback** are valuable exercises in formative and critical feedback routinely required of students in verbal and written format, in groups and peer-to-peer.

- **Examples** of formative assessments may include quizzes or other grades indicating content mastery, peer assessments, self-assessments, reflection, labs, skills demonstrations, presentations, observations, checklists, simplified DP course rubrics, or practice versions of summative assessments among others.

Summative Assessments

Summative assessments of learning are recorded snapshots typically taken at the end of a unit or during key points in the course. Summative information is the primary consideration for reporting progress and determining the final grade in the course. Exam schedules will be shared at least one week in advance.

Summative assessments are:

- a tool used to define students' learning and progress at the conclusion of a significant structural period (e.g. end of semester). A summative is designed to provide information on the student's achievement level against required subject-specific objectives such as the published DP assessment criteria.
- criterion-related rather than norm-referenced, meaning that students' work is judged in relation to identified levels of attainment rather than in relation to the work of other students. The assessment criteria for each subject can be found in the DP Subject Guides which teachers share with students at the beginning of the academic year.
- to take place in class under teacher supervision or in exam-like conditions to ensure the greatest probability of academic honesty. Research papers and compositions, when possible, will be submitted through Turnitin.com or other plagiarism-checking applications.
- Exemplified through projects, presentations, performances, research papers, reports, responses to problems or scenarios, tests, essays and "mock examinations," which are past DP papers or exams modeled after them.

Collaborative Learning and Assessment

Collaborative learning and the communication of understanding are important aspects of the UWC Costa Rica experiential learning model. Teachers will set clear expectations surrounding whether or not collaborative projects will be graded on an individual student basis or if a group grade will be

awarded. No part of a student's summative grade may depend upon the performance of another student. Each student will be graded upon their independent mastery and demonstration of relevant skills as well as their application and communication of knowledge as defined by the curriculum. In formative learning experiences, group feedback may be common as students make progress toward learning objectives.

Grade Attainment Scale

Below is a compilation of grade descriptions for subject groups in the IB Diploma Programme. Grade descriptors consist of characteristics of performance at each grade. Official IB examiners use specific course grade descriptors when determining grade boundaries for examination papers and coursework components. Descriptors are also intended to help teachers explain the academic requirements of the IB Diploma Programme to students, undertake formative assessments, report progress, and predict candidates' grades. The UWC Costa Rica grading scale reflects students' achievement and performance as measured against the IB scale⁹.

Level of Achievement	DP Subjects' Grade Descriptor*
1	Demonstrates: rudimentary knowledge and/or understanding of works and tasks; presentation without clarity or relevance; use of language that is barely intelligible. A score of "1" is considered poor and not of a passing standard.
2	Demonstrates: basic knowledge and/or understanding of works and tasks; basic awareness of the elements of technique and style; basic structure of the presentation of ideas; use of language that is lacking in clarity, accuracy and/or coherence. A score of "2" is considered unsatisfactory and not of a passing standard.
3	Demonstrates: some knowledge but superficial understanding of works and tasks; some awareness of the elements of technique and style; some evidence of a relevant personal response to the works studied, where appropriate; some evidence of a focus but ideas are neither appropriately developed nor presented; use of language that is limited in clarity, accuracy, and/or fluency and appropriateness to tasks. A score of "3" demonstrates inconsistent work and minimal expectations of a passing standard.

⁹ "Diploma Programme Grade Descriptors." IBO, 2021.

4	Demonstrates: adequate knowledge and understanding of works and tasks; adequate awareness of the effects of technique and style; adequate evidence of a relevant personal response to the works studied, where appropriate; generally focused on satisfactory development/presentation of ideas or argument; use of language that is generally clear, accurate, fluent, and appropriate to tasks. A score of “4” demonstrates consistently satisfactory work of a passing standard.
5	Demonstrates: sound knowledge and understanding or works and tasks; good appreciation of the effects of technique and style; good evidence of a relevant personal response to the works studied, where appropriate; clearly focuses and effective presentation of idea or argument; use of language that is clear, concise, and appropriately adapted to tasks. A score of “5” demonstrates good work which consistently goes beyond the minimum passing standard.
6	Demonstrates: very good knowledge and understanding of works and tasks; strong and detailed appreciation of the effects of technique and style; strong evidence of a personal engagement with the works studied, where appropriate; clearly focused, well-developed and purposeful presentation of ideas or argument; use of language that is varied, clear, concise, and effectively adapted to tasks. A score of “6” demonstrates very good work & a consistently high passing standard.
7	Demonstrates: excellent knowledge and understanding of works and tasks; very strong and detailed appreciation of the effects of technique and style; very strong evidence of independent and/or original perspectives on the works studied, where appropriate; consistently focused, carefully developed and persuasive presentation of ideas or argument; use of language that is varied, clear, concise, precise and convincingly adapted to tasks. A score of “7” demonstrates the highest level of excellence and passing standard.

*The IBO makes specific distinctions between each subject group, but these descriptions generally indicate the requirements for each DP level.

Level of Achievement	Theory of Knowledge (TOK) and Extended Essay (EE) Grade Descriptors
A	Excellent
B	Very Good
C	Satisfactory
D	Mediocre; Minimally Passing
E	Poor; Not of a Minimal Passing Standard
N	No Grade; Incomplete or Not Submitted

Level of Achievement	Effort*
A	Excellent
B	Good
C	Satisfactory
D	Unsatisfactory
E	Poor

* Teachers consider attendance, punctuality, participation in class, commitment, and other aspects when awarding effort grades.

Rubrics and IB Mark Schemes

UWC Costa Rica believes in transparency and clarity in assessment. Each IB subject comes with its own set of rubrics and grade boundaries for the various required components, serving as guidelines for evaluating student work. Teachers use these criterion-based rubrics to assess assignments, projects, and exams both formatively and summatively, ensuring fairness and consistency in grading.

Teachers provide students with these rubrics at the beginning of every academic year, allowing them to understand the expectations for each subject. By familiarizing themselves with the IB rubrics and mark schemes, students can track their progress, identify areas for improvement, and strive for academic excellence. Having said this, students should be aware that the IB adjusts the grade boundaries slightly with every exam session, and teachers may adapt these accordingly in each subject.

Grading Periods and Progress Reports

Year	Report Timeline	Achievement grade (IB 1-7)	Effort grade (A-E)	Narrative Commentary
First Year (DP1)	Mid-semester 1 (late November/early December)	Too early to assess	✓	Short comment on how the student is settling
	Semester 1 (mid- to late-January)	✓	✓	Report if current performance is 3 or lower.
	Semester 2 (end of May)	✓	✓	✓
Second Years (DP2)	Mid-semester 3 (late October/early November)	✓	✓	Report if current performance is 3 or lower.
	Mid-semester 4 (late March to mid-April)	✓	✓	✓ Note, there are limited opportunities to improve grades after mid-semester 4 in DP2 due to the onset of World Exams.
	Semester 4 (end of May)	✓	✓	Report if current performance is 3 or lower.

Narrative Commentary on Progress Reports

Written narrative comments in progress reports offer personalized insights into a student's academic journey within each subject. They provide an overview of the student's performance, highlighting strengths and areas for improvement. Comments are meant to serve as tools for understanding academic strengths and areas needing attention, leveraging the insights provided to enhance the student's learning journey. This feedback can be used to engage in constructive dialogue with teachers, seeking clarification when needed and working together to create strategies for improvement.

First Year (DP1/IB1) students and their families/guardians can receive narrative comments after semesters 1 and 2 (see table above). For Second Year (DP2/IB2) students, comments will accompany the third-semester report and the midpoint of the fourth semester. However, if a Second Year (DP2/IB2) is achieving a 3 or lower at any point during the second year, additional written reports may be provided. It is important to note that final grades are typically achieved by the midpoint of the fourth semester, as the onset of IB World Exams close to these reports means there is limited opportunity for improvement before the final report card.

Incomplete Work or Insufficient Evidence

Missing or significantly incomplete work challenges teachers as it hinders the evidence collection needed to accurately measure a student's progress. Without complete and timely submissions, teachers may struggle to assess the student's understanding of the material, identify areas for improvement, and provide targeted support.

When a student is missing work or assessment pieces at a progress-reporting deadline, and there is an approved justifiable reason, they will be granted an extension. However, if there is no justifiable excuse, a zero will be recorded for the grade, which may harm the student's effort grade.

Moreover, incomplete submissions can hinder a teacher's ability to authenticate a student's work on International Baccalaureate (IB) components. Authenticity in student work is paramount in ensuring academic integrity and upholding the standards of the IB program. Without sufficient evidence of a student's efforts and understanding, teachers may face difficulties in accurately assessing the student's performance and providing meaningful feedback.

Appeals: Summative Grades & Moderation

At UWC Costa Rica, part of the commitment to academic excellence includes providing students with a transparent process for addressing summative assessment concerns. Teachers are trained in interpreting the International Baccalaureate Diploma Programme (DP) rubrics, ensuring expertise in assessment evaluation. With their guidance, students can navigate assessment challenges with confidence. Trusting faculty expertise and respecting the DP rubrics is integral to this process.

If a student does not believe that the summative grade fits the evidence presented, the student may initiate an appeals process by following the outlined steps below within one calendar week of receiving the graded assessment. Students can be assured of fairness in assessment outcomes, knowing their concerns will be addressed with professionalism and adherence to academic standards.

Preparing for Student-Teacher Conference

- **Review Assessment Criteria and Feedback:** Carefully review the assessment criteria and constructive feedback provided by the teacher to understand how the work was evaluated.
- **Self-Assess the Work:** Reflect on the assessment and compare it to the criteria provided. Identify any areas where it is believed the work may not have been accurately assessed.
- **Prepare Supporting Evidence:** Gather any relevant materials, such as class notes, textbooks, or additional research, to support the appeal. Be ready to articulate why there is a belief that the work deserves a different grade.
- **Schedule a Meeting:** Reach out to the teacher to schedule a meeting to discuss concerns. Approach the meeting with a respectful and open mindset, focusing on understanding the teacher's perspective as well.
- **Present the Case:** During the meeting, calmly and clearly present the case for why the grade should be reconsidered. Refer to the assessment criteria and provide specific examples to support the argument(s).
- **Listen to Feedback:** Listen attentively to any feedback or explanations provided by the teacher regarding their assessment of the work. Be open to constructive criticism and willing to consider alternative viewpoints. The process may end here with the teacher agreeing to a grade adjustment or the student finding satisfaction with the further justification.

Request Moderation

If, after completing steps 1-6, the student still disagrees with the assessment after a full discussion, then the student may respectfully request that the work be reviewed by a “blind moderator,” meaning another teacher of the subject or subject group leader who will not know the student’s identity or be able to see what the original grade or feedback was.

Accepting Possible Outcomes: Understand that the outcome of the moderation process may result in the assessment grade being adjusted upwards, downwards, or remaining the same. Regardless of the outcome, demonstrate personal responsibility and integrity by accepting the decision with grace and using the feedback to improve.

This moderation process is only available for internal summative assessments. Grade reports and university-predicted grades are not eligible for the moderation process, and under no circumstances are students permitted to attempt to persuade teachers to change these grades. Teachers put their utmost thought, professional judgment, consideration, and factual evidence into determining these grades. The grades are generated over long periods of time, reflecting on the totality of the work that a teacher has seen from a student thus far. If a serious concern exists, it should be discussed with the Academic Director.

Homework and Teacher Office Hours

Teachers are encouraged to set meaningful homework that will help students go deeper in the understanding of the class content and/or to improve their skills. Despite efforts to make sure homework is set in a balanced manner in the different subjects, students may be in a situation where different homework assignments are due on the same day. In these cases, students are encouraged to talk to their teachers directly to explain the situation. Each student has a different IB subject package, which makes it difficult at times to achieve a balance in the work set to be done outside of class.

Students are also encouraged to work independently and seek help from teachers during teachers’ office hours, which are commonly offered on a weekly basis.

Timely Submission and Provision of Feedback

Feedback is prioritized as a cornerstone of student development. Teachers strive to provide constructive feedback and grades for completed assignments on time, **typically within two working weeks of the assessment**. This timely response allows students to reflect on their work and identify

areas for growth before the next summative assessment. However, it's essential to emphasize that the system works most effectively when students submit their work promptly. Late submissions may result in delayed feedback or the loss of the opportunity for feedback altogether.

Additionally, regular work submission, even if incomplete, is crucial for demonstrating progress and understanding. This practice not only helps students stay on track but also enables teachers to authenticate the student's work, particularly on important IB mandatory components. By fostering a culture of timely submission and continuous feedback, we empower students to excel academically and personally, preparing them for success in and beyond the classroom.

Self-Advocacy & Open Communication

UWC Costa Rica fosters a culture of personal responsibility and integrity. While teachers provide guidance and support, students are empowered to take ownership of their academic journey and advocate for their learning needs. Adult family members and legal guardians play a crucial role in supporting their children by nurturing self-advocacy skills and fostering open communication about academic progress and feedback.

Students are encouraged to actively engage with their learning process by taking advantage of scheduled teacher office hours and seeking clarification from teachers when feedback is unclear or further guidance is needed. By fostering open dialogue and collaboration, students can deepen their understanding and make meaningful progress towards their academic goals.

Inclusive Access to Learning

The College recognizes the importance of equity in education and is committed to creating conditions that allow all students fair access to learning. Within this framework, the institution offers satellite support and academic guidance for students who may benefit from additional assistance with areas such as organization, study strategies, understanding tasks, and managing academic workload.

These support mechanisms are intended to strengthen students' ability to fully engage with the academic program. At the same time, given the nature and rigor of the program, it is essential that students develop and maintain a meaningful level of autonomy, responsibility, and independence in their learning, taking ownership by contacting the Learning support staff proactively.

Documentation: Students with learning needs must submit documentation. This includes the diagnosis (no older than 2 years), standardized testing results, and recommendations from the evaluating expert in Spanish, English or French. If students already have the documentation before arriving at UWC Costa Rica, they must submit these as part of the Admissions Process. New documentation attained after the admission process has to be provided to the Learning Support Coordinator and/or the Learning Support office.

Individual Education Plan (IEP): Whenever the College receives documentation regarding learning needs, an Individual Education Plan (IEP) is created by the College's experts. The IEP validates the recommendations from the assessments to match the available IB access and inclusion criteria and recommends the exam and classroom accommodations the student should have access to. From the moment the student is placed on the Special Education Needs (SEN) list, teachers will endeavor to provide the necessary accommodations.

Regarding the external exams, the IB Diploma Program (IBDP) Coordinator will apply to the IB for exam accommodations when the student is registered for their exams at the beginning of their second year. The IBDP Coordinator will use all available resources to gain the appropriate inclusive access arrangements for the student; however, it cannot be guaranteed that the IB will agree with the IEP recommendations.

Identifying Learning Needs

The College seeks to understand students' learning needs in order to support equitable access to the academic program. Students and families are encouraged to share relevant documentation, such as educational or psychological assessments, prior to arrival or early in the academic year. This information is reviewed by the Learning Support team in collaboration with relevant staff to determine appropriate strategies to support the student's access to learning.

In addition to this, our mentors and academic staff will in a case-by-case situations will request the:

Academic Temperature Check: After admissions, some students may be identified as possibly facing challenges in one or more subjects. The teacher will notify the Learning Counselor, who then disseminates a document known as an **"Academic Temperature Check"** to all the student's teachers, in close coordination with the Academic Director. Additionally, the Academic Director routinely checks students' grades after each progress report and informs the Learning Counselor and Wellness Counselor to discuss any cases needing follow-up. The student's mentor and Wellness Counselor gain

access to the Academic Temperature Check document and any pertinent information concerning their mentee. The Learning Counselor routinely updates a list of students with support in place for all teachers' awareness.

The Academic Temperature Check enables the Academic Director and the student's mentor to ascertain whether the difficulties are confined to a particular area or extend across multiple subjects. The Learning Support Counselor crafts an action plan tailored to the student's needs and progress is monitored.

Should concerns indicate the possibility of a special educational need, families/legal guardians are contacted. They are encouraged to seek further diagnostic assessments to ensure their child receives the necessary support. Students can also be assessed by experts here in Costa Rica, if necessary, in Spanish or English, but families may need to pay for the tests.

Undiagnosed learning needs: If students become aware that they may have an undiagnosed learning need, they can request assistance from the **Learning Support Counselor** to access the relevant testing and diagnosis. The College will assist them in every way possible according to the resources available. Families may be asked to cover the expenses of necessary diagnostic tests. At other times, the diagnostic test may not be available in Costa Rica, nor may a trained diagnostician be fluent in the student's first language. Therefore, it would be necessary for the test(s) to be performed in the student's home country and at the family's/guardian's expense.

For additional information, see [Mental Health and Wellness Provision](#) within the Residential Life & Wellness Program section. The Learning Support Counselor reports to the Academic Director, who coordinates their services with the Director of Residential Life and Wellness as needed.

Due to the scope of services available, the College does not provide highly specialized interventions or individualized assistive technologies, such as personal readers, color-coded keyboards, or similar specialized tools typically associated with more intensive learning support settings.

Families/guardians should consider these limitations when determining whether the College's support model is an appropriate fit for the student's needs.

Potential Need for Withdrawal

In cases where students persistently fail to meet academic standards across multiple subjects during their first year, after seeking different types of support, families/guardians may receive guidance to

assess if the student has potential to succeed, including whether or not the College is equipped to support the specific needs. Each student is provided with opportunities for growth and achievement, but sometimes we do not have the necessary tools and resources, and withdrawal must be considered. In all cases, students are encouraged to engage in open communication with teachers and support staff to ensure their needs are appropriately met.

Library Services

The Orosí Library, located in the center of campus, next to the cafeteria and between the Academic and Residential areas, exists as a **hub of academic support and cultural enrichment**, embodying the commitment to the mission and values of the institution as well as the IB Diploma Programme. Guided by the principles of international understanding, celebration of diversity, and personal responsibility, the library offers a range of services and resources to enhance the educational journey of students and foster a vibrant community of collaboration, curiosity, and learning development.

Operating Hours & Services

The Orosí Library has a main study space area and a small library where the collections are kept. The library welcomes visitors every day, providing ample opportunities for exploration, study, and collaboration. The following are its hours of operation:

Library operating hours 2026-2027

Main Library	
Monday-Sunday	6:00 AM to 12:00 midnight
Small Library	
Monday- Friday	9:00am- 6:00pm

*Schedules may vary, and students will be notified of changes.

Physical Book Collection: With a growing collection of approximately 4,000 books in both Spanish and English, as well as other languages, the library provides a diverse array of resources to support academic pursuits and pursue personal interests. The library has an online catalog of resources, and each student is provided information on how to access this as part of their campus orientation.

Digital Collections Access: The library uses several databases, such as EBSCOhost, a research platform with intuitive online search features preferred by top educational institutions worldwide. This allows students timely access to useful and reliable resources to satisfy their information needs. The library has Kindle devices that can be loaned to students and is constantly searching for more and better technological and academic resources that facilitate the teaching and learning process.

Reference and Circulation: The librarian facilitates the circulation of materials to community members and offers assistance with reference inquiries.

Study Spaces: The library offers a variety of spaces for reading, studying, and collaboration, including common reading areas, the main hall, and the library terrace, providing a refreshing environment for focused work.

Training and Support: The librarian provides sessions on academic integrity, including proper citation and avoiding plagiarism. Students can also seek guidance on documenting sources and research techniques.

World Corner: Explore the World Corner, which features travel guides and books in over 30 languages and promotes global awareness and intercultural understanding. Many resources are available for students to plan their free time in Costa Rica.

Spirituality Room: A dedicated space for meditation, prayer, and quiet reflection, providing community members with an opportunity for contemplation and personal well-being. The Spirituality Room may be reserved through the student intranet.

Community Hub for Culture and Recreation: The library collaborates with students and staff to identify and collect cultural materials of importance and promotes different activities such as lectures, TEDx, book discussions, and film showings. As a hub of community activity, the library also promotes balance and well-being by encouraging students to take part in recreational reading challenges, board games, and other activities that promote a healthy and positive use of leisure time.

Lost and Found Box: Students are responsible for their own belongings and should not leave items unattended, especially valuables like phones, laptops, watches, and jewelry. Rooms should be locked when not in use. To aid in the return of lost items, label belongings with names or initials. Unattended items are taken to the Orosi Library's Lost and Found box.

The librarian is not responsible for these items. For valuable or important lost items, students can work with their Resident Coordinator to post a “lookout” announcement to the community. In certain cases, College staff may assist with viewing surveillance footage. All students are expected to demonstrate personal integrity by not taking items that do not belong to them, aligning with UWC Costa Rica's values of personal responsibility and mutual respect.

Items will be kept in the Lost & Found Box until the end of the academic year. Any unclaimed items at that time will be donated.

Expectations for Use of the Library Spaces

The Orosi Library is intended to be a space where respect, collaboration, and responsibility converge to create an enriching environment for all. The library is more than just a collection of books—it's a community built on the values of empathy, reciprocity, and accountability.

The following outline conveys expectations and collective student action pledges to demonstrate these values:

- **Respect and Protection:** We cherish and respect everyone who steps into our library. We protect our peers, staff, and the natural environment.
- **Mindfulness and Conservation:** We use resources wisely, turn off lights and air conditioning when unnecessary, and practice mindful printing. We are dedicated to minimizing waste and caring for our planet.
- **Collaboration and Courtesy:** We foster a welcoming study environment through polite and considerate behavior. We keep noise to a minimum, use headphones when necessary, and set our cell phones to vibrate. Our space is communal—leaving personal items to reserve spaces is prohibited.
- **Cleanliness and Preventive Care:** We maintain cleanliness and order, ensuring that our shared space reflects our collective respect and pride. We use proper posture and care when using furniture. We prevent damage to books and other materials by keeping food away from our resources and handling all items carefully. No food is allowed inside the library. Our library is a vital space for learning, and we treat it as such.

Classroom Standards of Dress

At UWC Costa Rica, maintaining an academic environment that is respectful and conducive to learning is prioritized. In line with the Standards of Dress & Grooming (see section in Code of Conduct), students are expected to dress appropriately for an academic setting. This includes choosing attire that promotes a positive learning atmosphere and respects the diverse cultural norms present within the international community. While acknowledging the influence of a tropical environment on dress choices, it is important that clothing in academic spaces remains suitable and functional. Attire should modestly cover chests, midriffs, and backs. Undergarments should not be visible. Shorts and skirts should be of a modest length, conducive not only to comfort but also to the varied activities on an academic day.

Use of Classrooms After Hours

Classrooms can be used after lessons for studying purposes when not being used for co-curricular activities, meetings, etc. Teaching Assistants (TA's) are responsible for having keys of each classroom and students are to leave the classrooms in the same state they find them. Please be aware that classrooms are not open 24/7 to encourage students to maintain a healthy balance between work and rest periods. The College has the right to stop allowing the use of classrooms after school hours should the spaces not be treated respectfully.

Future Pathways

At UWC Costa Rica, Future Pathways is an extension of the Academic Program, dedicated to guiding students toward fulfilling and purposeful post-UWC journeys. The College firmly believes in student-driven decision-making, fostering a sense of ownership and empowerment. Through regular engagement, Future Pathways counselors assist students in gaining a deeper understanding of themselves and learning the skills necessary to navigate complex life transitions.

Aligned with the institution's mission and values, the program honors each student's unique personality, ambitions, and aspirations, facilitating a journey of self-discovery, university, and alternative pathways exploration. Open communication among stakeholders, including students, educators, families, and the counseling team, is emphasized to ensure each student's future pathway is personally fulfilling and values aligned. Students are encouraged to embark on a year-long journey of self-discovery, engaging in honest self-assessment, thoughtful research, and independent

decision-making. Students are urged to find their voice in the university process, exploring and challenging assumptions about themselves and potential universities or other pathways. Application processes demand equal attention, and success is found when students allow their insights and self-discoveries to guide them.

In essence, Future Pathways embodies the institution's commitment to supporting students as they transition to become agents of positive change and promoters of a more peaceful and sustainable world beyond the nurturing environment of UWC Costa Rica.

Timeline of Student-Counselor Interactions

The support for students in planning their future begins immediately upon their arrival at UWC Costa Rica. During an overview meeting in Orientation, the Future Pathways team lays out the process and timeline for the next two years. Though students are welcome to meet individually with counselors during the first semester and are encouraged to attend university visits and sessions on campus, active engagement is not required from every student until the second semester. This approach acknowledges the transition to UWC and allows students time to settle in academically, socially, and emotionally.

Most students' pathway planning work takes place from the second semester through the beginning of the fourth semester. During this period, students are required to attend both individual and group meetings, complete assigned tasks, and utilize a variety of resources. Throughout this time, each student must meet with their counselor at least three times to ensure they are on track to pursue their desired post-UWC opportunities. This structured and scaffolded approach ensures that students have the support and guidance they need to navigate their future pathways effectively.

Responsibilities of All Stakeholders

Embracing collaboration, the vital roles played by students, families/guardians, counselors, and faculty members are recognized as equally important parts of the whole. This collective effort emphasizes self-advocacy, support, and guidance. The following outlines the key responsibilities of students, families, counselors, and faculty members in contributing to a successful outcome for each student.

Students

- **Demonstrate Self-Advocacy and Initiative:** Take full ownership of the pathway search and application process. Recognize the importance of presenting one's best self to universities through dedicated effort.
- **Utilize Available Resources:** Use the resources provided by Future Pathways Counselors and Ambassadors to facilitate the pathway search and application process.
- **Invest Time and Energy:** Dedicate the necessary time and energy to the pathway search and application process to ensure thorough exploration and preparation.
- **Demonstrate Respect:** Treat the pathway search and application process with the same respect as an academic class. Engage fully in the process and treat all stakeholders respectfully, including university visitors, counselors, family, and peers.
- **Maintain Communication:** Take proactive measures to schedule meetings with the Counselor, conduct research, complete required forms, and meet deadlines.

Families / Guardians

- **Provide Support:** Offer unconditional support to the student throughout the pathway search and application process, focusing on strengths and talents independent of admission decisions or test scores.
- **Facilitate University/Program Exploration:** Assist the student in understanding various university options through visits, research, and meetings with College representatives. Listen attentively to the student's impressions and help gather relevant information.
- **Financial Aid Assistance:** If applicable, assist in completing financial aid forms and gathering necessary documents per each College's requirements. Speak openly and honestly with students about what resources are available for the family to provide and what the students will have to manage on their own regarding finances.
- **Encourage Independence:** Avoid taking over the process for the student. Instead, empower them to stand independently by allowing them to apply their learned lessons independently. Remain open and supportive to hearing new ideas and possibly letting go of preconceived pathways.

Please note: The College does not support using university agents or professional essay writers as these practices are not aligned with our values of personal integrity, responsibility, and accountability.

Future Pathways Counselors

- **Provide Guidance and Support:** Lead and support students throughout the university research and application process, offering suggestions, feedback, and problem-solving assistance to empower them to make informed decisions.
- **Facilitate University Engagement:** Coordinate presentations by university representatives and provide information on various topics relevant to the application process.
- **Write Recommendations:** Craft holistic recommendations highlighting the student's positive qualities as a member of the UWC community.
- **Manage Documentation:** Submit grades/transcripts, predicted IB scores, recommendations, and College documents to universities on time.
- **Advocate for Students:** Advocate for students' best interests and support planning for a gap year, if desired.

Teachers

- **Support Student Engagement:** Encourage students to actively participate in the pathway search and university visits. When possible, introduce interesting roles and career pathways related to the teacher's academic field of study.
- **Provide Academic Guidance:** In the role of mentor, offer guidance and support to students in balancing academic responsibilities with pathway planning activities.
- **Write Recommendations:** Work collaboratively with counselors to provide student recommendations to highlight their academic achievements and contributions to the College community.

University Application Process

Universities seek organized, self-motivated applicants. Therefore, in the university application process, it is expected that each student will assume full responsibility for their journey. While the Future

Pathways counselors offer guidance and represent students to universities, students must remain vigilant regarding all requirements and deadlines. Ultimately, students are accountable for researching universities, writing essays, completing applications, preparing for and taking placement or language proficiency tests, and managing due dates, and all other associated tasks.

Historically, many of our students apply to multiple countries as they seek to discover the breadth of options available to them. In the last several years alone, the Future Pathways Office has assisted students with applications in nearly 20 countries! Though we fully encourage this scope of applications, we also push students to understand the realities of attending universities in different places, especially around potential financial viability.

Gap Year Support

Each year, roughly 20% of our students choose to take a gap year. This typically means students will take a year between completing their IB at UWC Costa Rica and beginning their university studies. We fully support students who choose to take this path through programming, resources, and planning. We believe that to fully maximize this space in their educational journey, students should approach their gap year thoughtfully, ensuring that they leave themselves time and space to locate and apply for challenging, engaging opportunities like student teaching, biological research, Indigenous community activism, outdoor experience facilitating, and others that are examples of past gap year experiences.

Students receive the full support and dedication of time from the Future Pathways team for one full application cycle. If a student chooses to wait to apply to universities after a gap year, we will be fully available to them virtually to support that process with all of the resources we have, as well as individual meetings. If a student applies during their time at UWC Costa Rica, receives financially viable offers, and chooses to decline all options to take a gap year, the Future Pathways team will still support them where possible in future application processes, but the priority of the office is always students going through the application process for the first time.

For students who know that they plan to attend university or are considering attending university in the United States specifically and are not sure that they want to take a gap year, it is typically recommended to move ahead with applying. Most United States universities have a process by which students can request a one-year deferral. Outside of the United States, it is less common to offer deferrals.

Creating a Balanced University Application List

A balanced university list is crucial in the admissions process. It ideally includes 2-3 “likely Colleges” to which they believe they are well-suited and will meet or exceed admissions standards; 2-3 “target Colleges,” which are closely aligned to their aims and where they believe they will be a strongly competitive applicant; and finally, 2-3 “reach Colleges” which may be a well-aligned fit but have highly competitive admissions where the majority of applicants are equally strong. This balance ensures that students face a “dilemma of choice” in the spring semester, with multiple College acceptances to consider.

Financing Future Plans

Throughout planning the future, the Future Pathways team individually supports students in unraveling the complex process of understanding the financial realities of their next steps. The office also runs group sessions to explain the financial aid application process and provides resources to families to understand and discuss their financial circumstances.

Davis Foundation Need-Based Scholarship

The Davis Foundation provides a scholarship to assist UWC graduates who choose to study in the United States at any of 106 partner institutions: <http://www.davisuwcscholars.org/partners>. No separate application is required—if a student applies to a Davis partner College and submits their financial aid application, they will automatically be considered for their Davis funding.

Note: Davis funding is not guaranteed for UWC students. It is need-based and applied after a review of financial documents. As part of the partnership agreement between the Davis Foundation and the universities that receive funding, universities must meet the fully calculated needs of students they admit to receiving this funding.

1-19 enrolled students	= \$15,000 per year per student
20-39 enrolled students	= \$20,000 per year per student
40-59 enrolled students	= \$25,000 per year per student
60-79 enrolled students	= \$30,000 per year per student
80+ enrolled students	= \$40,000 per year per student

Supporting Individual Growth with Extracurricular Involvement and Leadership

An important expectation of a student's journey at UWC Costa Rica is extracurricular involvement and leadership, both through the co-curricular office and through a student's own initiative. Students are encouraged to identify areas outside of class in which they wish to grow and develop, then to progressively increase the involvement they have in activities they are passionate about over time. This is a priority for a student's individual goals in the future and can each play a significant role in university/program/internship admission. Students are encouraged to actively participate in co-curricular and community service activities as well as take initiative to take on leadership roles for short- and long-term projects and/or put themselves forward as a candidate for various elected leadership positions.

The UWC Costa Rica Transcript

The transcript is a pivotal document in the College application process. It provides insights into a student's academic journey, including course selections, rigor, and performance. Additionally, courses in progress during senior year are noted on the transcript sent to universities. Second year grades are not sent until the end of the first semester in December/January. Most universities require a final transcript, which includes attainment grades from all four semesters.

Standardized Testing for University Admissions

Standardized testing arrangements are managed directly by students with support from the Future Pathways Office. While the office assists in planning testing calendars, students are responsible for registering, attending, and reporting scores to universities. Many U.S. universities no longer require the SAT or ACT for admission, but students are encouraged to research and consider their testing options thoroughly.

Before the pandemic, many higher education institutions were moving away from the SAT/ACT. With the advent of COVID, all of that was significantly accelerated, and few Davis Partner universities require the SAT (i.e. Georgetown, Florida, MIT, Dartmouth, Yale, Brown). Given this, across the whole UWC Movement, there has been a decrease in students taking the SAT/ACT. Our recommendation would be for students curious about testing to take a free practice test online and then compare their scores with some of the averages at universities currently on their list. This will allow them to gauge how much effort it might take to meet those average SAT scores and whether or not that is worth their time, especially given that their IB grades will be the most important part of consideration for university

admission. Students do not need to begin their standardized testing journey before the second semester of their time at UWC Costa Rica.

Testing Center, Transportation, and Fee Support

UWC Costa Rica is not an SAT testing center, nor is there a testing center for the ACT in Costa Rica. We encourage students to register for the SAT at the British College of Costa Rica located nearby and with whom we have a close professional relationship. The College will provide transportation and support for several testing dates but not for all (Future Pathways counselors can provide students with these dates). We have a limited capacity to assist with transportation to the testing center during the College year, and priority is given to students on significant scholarships. For students receiving a full scholarship, they may be eligible to receive a testing fee waiver from the College Board via their counselor.

Language Proficiency Testing

Students planning to study in countries where the language of instruction is different from that of their passport country will likely need to prove proficiency in that language for the admission process. Students can speak to their counselor individually about this process.

Most of our students plan to study English for university, and the three most common English Proficiency tests are the TOEFL, IELTS, and Duolingo. The Future Pathways team recommends the Duolingo English Test where possible because it costs less and can be taken on a student's personal computer at their convenience. There are test centers for the TOEFL and IELTS in Costa Rica, though these tests must be scheduled in advance and cost multiple hundred USD dollars.

Recommendation Letters

All students will be required to submit multiple questionnaires to their Future Pathways Counselor, which will serve as a basis for a counselor letter of recommendation. Most United States universities require this recommendation, which can be very helpful as a comprehensive letter for any program, either during their time at UWC or after. Students will also request specific letters of recommendation from their teachers in the second semester. All these recommendation letters serve as confidential communications between UWC Costa Rica and universities. Universities prefer confidentiality, which enhances the effectiveness and integrity of these communications. Neither teachers nor counselors will share their letters with students during or after the application process.

Limitations of University Application List

UWC Costa Rica enforces a **ten-university application limit** to encourage thoughtful consideration in the application process. This limit underscores the importance of carefully curated applications, which are communicated to universities through the College profile and interactions with admissions representatives. The College believes that it is important for universities to know that our students have been selective in making their applications and consider the university a “good fit” for themselves. This assures universities that they, too, have a higher chance of making an offer to a student who will accept. We also know that the application process is taxing on students amidst the stressors of life at UWC Costa Rica and hope to help them appropriately manage their time and expectations. This limitation also attempts to balance the workload of our counseling team and ensure that equal time and focus can be given to each student’s application.

Future Pathways Ambassadors

The Future Pathways Ambassador positions are a team of 3-4 students that provide insights to the Future Pathways Office (FPO) on how to best meet the needs of the generations while also serving as a resource for their peers during times when the FPO is closed. These students meet regularly with the Future Pathways counselors to ensure consistency of messaging, adjust resources, and seek new ways to improve the Future Pathways process.

Education Area:

Co-Curricular Program

Co-Curricular Program

The Co-Curricular Program at UWC Costa Rica is one of the crucial pillars of our holistic educational model, together with Academics and Residential Life & Wellness. The various initiatives within this program play a crucial role in helping students achieve a balanced lifestyle by providing opportunities of place-based education, pursuing interests, passions, and service initiatives. Through co-curricular experiences, students connect on a deeper level with their peers and the broader Costa Rican community, fostering personal growth and intercultural understanding.

Our Co-Curricular program also includes **Creativity, Activity and Service (CAS)**, which is one of the three essential elements students must complete as part of the IB Diploma Programme. CAS is primarily student-led and aims to leverage the diverse socio-cultural backgrounds and skills of our students through peer learning. It encourages creativity, physical activity, and community service, allowing students to take initiative and demonstrate personal commitment to their chosen activities.

The co-curricular experiences are designed to complement or be threaded with both the academic and residential life & wellness curriculum, ensuring that students engage in experiential learning that aligns with the mission to educate individuals capable of fostering positive change. By participating in these activities, students develop leadership skills, cultivate a sense of responsibility and respect, better understand Costa Rican culture, and embrace the values of compassion, service, and stewardship for the environment.

Students engage in these experiences through **4 core themes** that are aligned with our Sustainability Framework:

- 1. Exploring regenerative food systems**
- 2. Fostering environmental conservation**
- 3. Learning from local knowledge**
- 4. Building equitable communities**

Co-Curricular Initiatives

Co-curricular experiences at UWC Costa Rica encompass a broad range of initiatives that enhance students' experiential learning journey. They are designed to support students in maintaining their physical and emotional well-being while providing meaningful opportunities to engage with and

contribute to various communities in Costa Rica. Throughout their co-curricular journey, students work toward achieving specific learning outcomes, documenting their growth through reflections and evidence in their **Co-Curricular Portfolio**. Individual interviews and portfolio reviews provide opportunities for students to reflect on their experiences and learning. To graduate, students are required to complete and submit their Co-Curricular Portfolio.

The following are the program's main initiatives:

Conociendo Costa Rica (CCR)

Conociendo Costa Rica (Getting to Know Costa Rica) is designed to immerse students in the rich cultural and natural heritage of Costa Rica, their host country. Aligned with our mission, vision and values to foster international and intercultural understanding, this initiative offers visits to various provinces, allowing students to engage deeply with the socio-cultural context and national reality of Costa Rica. Throughout the academic year, several trips are organized to key landmarks and diverse communities across Costa Rica.

All students are required to participate in the Conociendo Costa Rica (CCR) experience during Orientation Week and in **at least one additional CCR experience during their two years at UWC Costa Rica**, subject to space availability. These experiences provide valuable opportunities for cultural exchange, allowing students to engage directly with local communities and gain firsthand insight into Costa Rican culture, traditions, history, and gastronomy.

Community Action Week (CAW)

Community Action Week is an off-campus, service learning, project-based experience where first- and second-year students and staff engage with local and national organizations and diverse communities, delivering meaningful social impact. Each project belongs to any of the four core themes of the Co-curricular Program and fosters a deeper understanding and appreciation of their host country. By serving others, students learn invaluable lessons about empathy, responsibility, reciprocity, and the transformative power of community engagement. It is important to note that these are **work-intensive weeks for students and not a “group vacation.”** While students can prioritize their choices of projects and have fun together during their time away, each student is expected to fully engage and contribute to the project to which they are assigned.

During CAW students will have limited access to their phones and technology, and they are expected to be present. During certain hours of the day, students will need to leave their phones in boxes and not have access to them.

Community Action Days (CADs)

Community Action Days (CADs) allow students to participate in one-day trips, engaging with local or Community Action Week (CAW) project communities. UWC Costa Rica is housed in Santa Ana, San José and the new campus will be located in San Isidro, Heredia. Working with these communities puts into action our sustainability core value of reciprocity. These service days provide cultural exchange experiences and enhance sustainability projects from CAW. Through these initiatives, students extend their learning beyond the campus, fostering a deeper connection to its host country and communities. It is required for every student to participate in the Community Action Day held during orientation week. Students are welcome to join more of these outings after orientation.

Model United Nations (MUN)

Model United Nations (MUN) is an educational simulation of the United Nations that develops students' critical thinking, negotiation, and debate skills. Through MUN, students gain a deeper understanding of international relations, global issues, the complexities of diplomacy and develop a sense of global citizenship and responsibility. **All first-year students must participate in the annual on-campus event**, where they engage in discussions, draft resolutions, and work collaboratively to address global challenges. Students who are unable to attend the event during their first year due to approved absences, such as medical reasons, or other authorized circumstances, may opt to participate in MUN during their second year.

Second-year students are invited to return as organizers, taking on various leadership and training roles to guide and mentor the first-year participants. This opportunity helps them develop advanced skills in leadership, organization, and peer training. Additionally, the College has a competitive MUN CAS and Committee members make part of a team that attends conferences hosted by other schools in Costa Rica, providing students with further opportunities to refine their skills and represent the College in a broader context.

Agents of Change (AoC)

The Agents of Change (AoC) initiative is a scaffolded two-year hands-on training program consisting of a series of learning experiences designed to inspire and support students in transforming their ideas into action. By working collaboratively, students drive positive social impact while developing essential skills such as empathy, leadership, collaboration, and innovation.

All first-year students are expected to participate in the AoC program, including the AoC camp, which serves as a foundational experience for the initiative. Students who are unable to attend the camp during their first year due to approved absences, such as medical reasons, or other authorized circumstances, will be required to complete the camp during their second year. This ensures that all students can fully participate in and benefit from the complete AoC experience as part of the College's educational program.

The AoC initiative divides experiences into three possible paths:

1. Social Entrepreneurship,
2. Activism/Incidence, and
3. STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics)

These paths are tailored to align with students' interests and profiles and utilizing design thinking methodologies and experiential education frameworks.

While all students receive initial training, only a small number complete all the steps and manage to bring a project to fruition during their time on campus. However, the training equips all participants with the skills needed to bring their ideas to life beyond their UWC experience to tackle pressing challenges. The specific themes and topics addressed within each pathway may vary from year to year, reflecting emerging global trends, evolving societal challenges, and the interests of the student body.

Thematic Weeks

These weeks focus on celebrating the diverse regional student families and significant affinity groups within the community, ensuring every student can **help organize or participate in at least one thematic week during their two years on campus.**

During Thematic Weeks, regional groups showcase their unique cultural heritage through performance arts, culinary experiences, and informative sessions covering various aspects such as culture, politics,

and religion. This vibrant exchange of traditions and ideas provides a platform for students to share elements of their backgrounds, foster mutual understanding and appreciate diversity.

Student family and group leaders collaborate with the Co-Curricular team to plan and execute the week's activities, ensuring all logistical aspects are carefully managed. These immersive experiences allow students to bond more deeply, recognizing the many similarities that connect them while also appreciating the rich diversity that each individual brings to the community.

In years when a regional family is not scheduled to host a Thematic Week, they may still share their culture, perspectives, and current regional issues with the community through a presentation during a UWC Costa Rica Community Meeting. Additionally, regional families and affinity groups may organize Thematic Days throughout the year, providing further opportunities to celebrate cultural traditions, raise awareness of important topics, and engage the community in meaningful learning and dialogue.

CAS Experiences

CAS (Creativity, Activity, Service) is a core component of the IB Diploma Programme that encourages students to grow through meaningful experiences, collaboration, and community engagement. Students can propose and execute CAS experiences to complement their academic studies. The process encourages students to develop leadership skills, engage with the community, and achieve personal growth. Students are expected to participate in at least three CAS experiences during their two years, ideally engaging in one experience from each CAS strand. The following summary outlines the steps, timeline, and responsibilities involved in proposing and executing a CAS project.

Process and Timeline

CAS Fair During Orientation	Proposal Submission	Sign Up
General introduction to CAS. Second-year students share experiences with first-year students to showcase the different types of CAS opportunities available.	After the CAS Fair: All students receive a form to propose a CAS experience. Proposals must align with the 7 IB CAS learning outcomes and the 8 Sustainability Principles.	CAS offerings are officially published, including descriptions, schedules, and available spaces. Students sign up in CAS experiences through an established process.

	Approved proposals move to the next stage, where the proposing students become CAS Experience Leaders.	
--	--	--

CAS Experience Leaders

CAS Experience Leaders are students that have an active role in the development of CAS experiences. They are expected to:

- **Attend mandatory meetings.**
- **Actively communicate** with the CAS Facilitator.
- **Track Attendance** of the CAS participants.
- **Collect and upload evidence**, such as pictures and videos, to a shared online folder.
- **Lead and organize** their CAS sessions.

CAS Supervising Adult: Supervising adults play an important role in ensuring the success of CAS experiences. They are responsible for overseeing assigned CAS experiences, ensuring the CAS Experience Leaders are prepared to execute their responsibilities. They also encourage students to reflect and grow from their experiences, and support them in navigating challenges, and verifying activities occur as scheduled. CAS supervising adults are assigned as needed.

Our educational approach emphasizes the development of student agency. By balancing supervision with autonomy, we create a safe environment where students can make decisions, take responsibility for their actions, and learn from each other. Families and guardians can be assured that our model supports students' growth, not by controlling them but by providing the guidance and space needed to navigate their own learning journeys and become capable, self-reliant individuals.

CAS Limitations

While proposing and leading a CAS activity can be a distinguishing part of a student's journey, it is important to note that opportunities are limited. Not every proposal can be followed through due to constraints such as scheduling, transportation, budget, availability of adult supervision, and the level of interest from other students. Therefore, students are encouraged to put forward well-thought-out and feasible proposals but should understand that not all can be executed.

CAS Community Sharing Event

The CAS Community Sharing event is held at the end of each semester. It provides a platform for students to present their CAS experiences and outcomes to the UWC Costa Rica community. The event usually includes presentations, videos, and a fair showcasing crafts and tangible products.

Attendance is mandatory for CAS community sharing. These fairs foster accountability and celebrate the impact of student initiatives on the broader UWC Costa Rica community.

Community Action Through a Sustainable Lens

UWC Costa Rica is dedicated to delivering positive social impact by engaging students in projects that address specific needs within communities. The term "Community Action" is intentionally chosen and reflects the College's commitment to social responsibility, emphasizing that a crucial component of sustainability is active participation with and learning from local organizations and communities.

The objective of Community Action activities is to foster meaningful and lasting change through sustainable projects with nearby local communities, and across Costa Rica and Central America. These activities offer students opportunities for cultural immersion in the host country and region and promote the values of inclusion and cultural understanding, while also unpacking important themes such as decolonization.

UWC students have engaged in thousands of hours of positive social impact volunteering in diverse Costa Rican communities — a critical space to develop and foster alliances with external communities and organizations. By learning about the impact of global issues in a local context, students embody the mission and values of UWC Costa Rica. This approach ensures that students not only learn about global and local issues but also actively contribute to building a more sustainable and equitable world.

Guiding Principles

Activities are designed under the five principles of Community Action¹⁰ and the Community and Diversity principle from the UWC Costa Rica Sustainability Framework:

1. **Reflecting before engaging** in a community service experience to make sure it is not about self-fulfillment.

¹⁰ Based on "Unpacking Voluntourism". Weave News, St. Lawrence University Grassroot journalism for social justice

2. **Understanding the community's complexity and** then reflecting on how to support them with what they need, not what the volunteering group may think they need.
3. **Educating ourselves** is key –using community spaces on campus to talk about privileges and therefore, responsibility in relation to the community being supported.
4. Making sure the support being offered contributes to **long-term sustainable solutions**.
5. Recognizing our **UWC Costa Rica community** as the primary space to practice personal and collective responsibility in support of creating a solid collaboration system.

Funds for Co-Curricular Activities

The Co-Curricular Program manages a complex budget across all initiatives, which includes transportation, meals/snacks, accommodations, entrance fees, requisite supplies and equipment, external provider fees, and the like. Activities are planned for up to one year in advance, and certain funds are set aside for recurring CAS and student leadership groups such as MUN. Student leaders must work with their adult supervisors to be responsible stewards of any funds set aside for them and to plan as far in advance as possible to ensure there are spaces, supervision, and funds available. Funds for last-minute and unplanned activities are limited.

Process for Applying for Funding:



Equipment for Student-Led Activities

To request equipment and materials, such as sporting gear, decorative items, or audio/visual equipment, students **must complete a form**, which can be accessed with the support of the Co-Curricular team. The form requires the names of the responsible person(s) and details of the equipment or materials being requested.

Once the form is submitted, the request will be processed by the relevant area. Students are responsible for ensuring the equipment is returned promptly and in good condition. Students needing assistance with the set-up or operation of the equipment should seek additional instructions to ensure proper use.

Any equipment or materials damaged due to negligence or not returned, will incur a charge to cover the repair or replacement cost.

Representing the College in External Events

Eligibility to represent UWC Costa Rica in external events is determined by several factors, including (a) the nature of the activity, (b) the student's commitment, (c) academic standing, and (d) adherence to the College's values and educational standards. This ensures that participants are well-prepared and represent the College positively.

Academic Commitments and Participation Eligibility: Academic success is a priority for personal growth and overall achievement. Students must meet their academic commitments to maintain eligibility for external events. If academic standing is in jeopardy, students may be temporarily removed from participation until their performance improves. Concerns can be raised by teachers to the Academic and/or Co-Curricular Directors, who will consult with supervising adults to make a final decision regarding eligibility.

Upholding College Values and Code of Conduct: Students representing UWC Costa Rica in external events or in the presence of outside guests or participants must uphold the College's values and adhere to the Code of Conduct. Their behavior should consistently reflect integrity, respect, and responsibility. Failure to act as positive role models may result in the loss of eligibility for future events and the corresponding disciplinary process, as stated in the Code of Conduct. By adhering to these

guidelines, students can fully embrace the opportunities to represent the College, develop their leadership skills, and contribute to its positive reputation.

Education Area:

Residential Life & Wellness Program

Residential Life and Wellness Program

The Residential Life and Wellness program is another key pillar of our UWC Costa Rica educational model. Residential Life is truly the heart of our community where our 200 plus students live in shared residences with peers from over 70 nationalities. Our model invites students to reflect on how they live and relate with others as part of their personal development. These experiences allow students to develop essential life skills like independence, responsibility, mediation and conflict resolution that will be very useful after graduation.

Our educational model also takes wellness very seriously. Every student is encouraged to check in daily with their Residence Coordinator (an adult that lives on campus known as the RC) to build trust and connection. If additional support is needed, our wellness team offers counseling sessions, group and transition support for students adjusting to life away from home during different moments of the year. We also have structured programs to promote balance, resilience, and wellbeing and more specific activities that serve as vital transitional steps as students adjust to life on campus and prepare for their future beyond UWC.

These immersive experiences blend education, cultural exchange, personal, and emotional growth in a nurturing environment. Through a variety of activities like team-building exercises, outdoor adventures, workshops, cultural immersion experiences, and time for meaningful reflection, students acquire essential life skills such as leadership, problem-solving, and adaptability, also cultivating resiliency and a sense of global citizenship. This intentional environment is designed to foster cross-cultural understanding, empathy, and collaboration — essential values of the UWC movement.

Student Health

The following section provides information about on and off campus health services that our students have available to ensure their physical wellbeing.

On-campus Healthcare

- **Location:** Medical Services are in the **Poás Building**, situated at the end of the campus's main road, next to the residential area and the outdoor gym.
- **Medical Reception Desk:** There is a medical reception with a person on-call at all times. If a person is not present, students must follow instructions on the door sign. If it is an emergency, they must use the intercom on the wall outside of the medical area to call the guard at extension 132 for immediate assistance.

Hours of Operation

Monday to Friday	
Nurses	On duty from 5:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m. and from 5:00 p.m. to 11:00 p.m.
Doctor	Available three or four days a week between 2:00 -5:00 p.m.
Paramedics	On site overnight between 9:30pm to 5:00 a.m.
Saturday & Sunday	
Paramedics	Available 24 hours throughout the weekend.

*Schedules are subject to change.

Healthcare Providers and Qualifications: All medical professionals serving the student body are licensed within Costa Rica and meet the country’s regulatory standards. The College employs a part-time physician who is always available for phone consultation to support the on-duty nurses and paramedics. The doctor is present on campus four days a week to conduct student appointments as needed, which are coordinated through the nursing staff.

The **day-to-day operations** of the medical area are managed by **two full-time registered nurses** responsible for maintaining medical records, monitoring student health, and communicating with the physician and families/guardians when concerns arise. When nurses are not on duty, **paramedics** are on campus to oversee student health and respond to any emergencies.

Additionally, the College has an agreement with a **local ambulance service** that can dispatch a **doctor to campus** to assess medical concerns or emergency situations when necessary.

Off-campus Healthcare and External Providers

Ambulance Services: An Emergency Care service is available for any situation that puts health at risk within our campus.

Their services range from telemedicine consultations where staff can speak directly with a doctor about a student’s condition, to **on-site emergency response and advanced medical** care during emergencies. Should a transfer to a medical facility be required, it is coordinated by College staff with the approval of the **on-call director**. Students are transported either to **private healthcare providers**

the College has partnerships with or to the **appropriate public hospital**, depending on the nature of the case.

Preferred Medical Facilities: The College partners with private hospitals that collectively offer over 80 specialty services, including emergency and intensive care, ensuring comprehensive medical coverage for nearly any need.

For medical concerns requiring in-depth evaluation beyond the general care provided by the College doctor, appointments are arranged with specialists at the affiliated hospital clinics. A staff member accompanies students to these appointments to provide support and guidance.

Whenever possible, efforts are made to provide a bilingual English-speaking escort for students who are not fluent in Spanish, to have fluent communication throughout the visit.

[Additional Healthcare Information](#)

Fees: The student's College-sponsored insurance policy covers a percentage of medical expenses. Families/guardians will have to pay the remaining percentage, or the amount not covered by the insurance, as well as any services or equipment that the insurance does not cover. The percentage details may vary from year to year, so please check the insurance information you received upon enrollment. Expenses that are less than \$500 USD, will be deducted from the student's initial deposit, if applicable, and major costs will be billed to families/guardians by the UWC Costa Rica Finance team. To find more information about College insurance, [please click here](#) and see the section called Student Insurance Coverage below.

In Case of Illness or Injury: If a student feels ill or is injured, they must go to the Poás medical area on campus, where the nurse, paramedic or staff on-duty will secure immediate care. Medical professionals apply their clinical judgment and public health expertise to promptly identify health concerns, assess risks and protective factors, and deliver early interventions to prevent complications. After the initial evaluation, the medical professional will determine whether the student needs to be referred to the College's doctor. The doctor will decide the appropriate course of action. The nurses will then manage follow-up care or arrange specialist consultations as needed.

Specialized Care: If the College doctor determines that a student requires immediate care from a medical specialist—such as a dermatologist, orthopedist, endocrinologist, or others—the nurses will coordinate the appointments with experienced professionals at our affiliated hospital clinics. A staff member will accompany the student to ensure proper support and follow-up care. **NOTE:** specialized

care will only be coordinated if the insurance includes the service, otherwise the families/guardians will have to cover the full cost.

In Case of Emergency: If a student experiences an illness or injury that prevents them from going to the Poás medical area, they should immediately ask the nearest adult or peer to notify the medical professional on duty. Students may seek help from their Residence Coordinator who will activate medical protocols. In most cases, students can quickly reach out using their personal phone. Alternatively, any student can go directly to the Poás medical area on behalf of another sick/injured student or use the **intercom located on the exterior wall** that connects directly to security by dialing extension 132.

Non-emergency Healthcare: For most other routine, non-emergency healthcare check-ups, such as optometry appointments, we recommend that these be scheduled during the students' June/July or other holiday leaves, when students return home. If these non-emergency appointments need to take place during the academic year, these can be discussed with the student's Residence Coordinator and leave permissions can be arranged. College staff is limited, and the College cannot typically assign staff to accompany students to these types of appointments.

Mental Health and Wellness Provision

The purpose of the UWC Costa Rica wellness programming is to promote a culture of proactive care, emotional resilience, and community support among students. Grounded in the College's holistic educational model, the program aims to nurture student well-being through preventive, developmentally appropriate educational initiatives that support the social, emotional, and mental health needs of adolescents in a residential, multicultural setting. The wellness programming empowers students to develop healthy coping strategies, build self-awareness, and cultivate meaningful relationships — laying the foundation for responsible and independent living beyond the College.

The scope of the programming is broad and collaborative. The Residential Life & Wellness team works closely with student Wellness and Fitness Ambassadors to design and implement comprehensive well-being spaces across campus life. Through residence meetings, educational workshops, teacher mentor groups, and special activities, students learn about areas vital to mental health and personal development.

These topics include:

Sleep	Consent education	Self-care
Healthy lifestyles	Emotional support	Sleep
Time management	Sexuality	Nutrition
Intercultural communication	Healthy relationships	Personal values
Conflict transformation	Contraception and sexual health	Identity development
Social and emotional skills	Study habits	Addressing microaggressions

These themes are explored through a variety of tools such as mentorship opportunities, focused discussions, purposeful outings, bonding activities, optional workshops, guest lectures, and other creative methods aimed at fostering holistic student development.

The Wellness team includes essential first-line support by licensed psychologists. But it might not be able to offer long-term clinical treatment or manage ongoing, complex, or previously untreated mental health challenges. Its goal is to identify emerging concerns early and guide students toward appropriate care. When student needs exceed the scope of internal services, referrals are made to trusted external professionals with expertise in adolescent mental health in cooperation with families/guardians. In this context, transparency and cooperation from families or guardians regarding their child's mental health history are paramount to ensure informed decision-making and allow the school to be as prepared and responsive as possible. The internal wellness team is thus both a supportive presence in daily life and a structured pathway to additional care when needed, operating within clearly defined boundaries of practice.

Check-Ins

As an additional measure of care, Residence Coordinators conduct daily check-ins with students in the residences Monday through Friday, typically between 5:00 p.m. and 9:00 p.m. Over the weekends, faculty or staff members on duty conduct these face-to-face check-ins, typically between 5:00 p.m. and 9:00 p.m. in the cafeteria or the residential area. During check-ins students can address any areas of need, and the adult in charge will help guide them to the best suited person. Students may also use this space to discuss requests for leave and confirm permissions with their Residence Coordinator.

Attendance: A record of attendance is maintained for the daily check-ins, and Residence Coordinators may impose restrictions on off-campus permissions when students miss check-ins or with an accumulation of these, receive a minor offense to the Code of Conduct (See Code of Conduct section). If a student does not show up for check-in and has no approved leave, the Residence Coordinator or weekend staff on duty must locate the student to ensure their safety. In these situations, campus security and the administrator on duty and Director on-call may be involved.

Families/guardians may also be contacted and asked to help reach the student by phone or location apps they may use, such as *Find My Friends*, *Life 360*, *FamiSafe Family Tracker*, and *Glympse Location Share*. If the missed check-in was unjustified due to forgetfulness or negligence, for instance, this can lead to further consequences as addressed in the Code of Conduct. Once a student has missed two check-ins during a week or four check-ins without a valid excuse within one month, it will result in a referral for minor misconduct.

External Specialists

To ensure students' emotional needs are adequately met, wellness counselors maintain a list of qualified external specialists in mental health. These professionals each have considerable experience in supporting the mental health of children and adolescents, as well as being familiar with the College's educational model. The external providers offer a variety of high-quality services in keeping with the College's institutional standards of care. Some examples are therapeutic approaches based on Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT), psychiatric care focused on integral approaches alongside psychotherapists, and alternative treatments with practitioners who specialize in a holistic methodology.

Students or concerned family members or guardians who desire external support beyond what the College provides may email the student's internal wellness counselor directly or send a request to the general account: wellness@uwccostarica.org.

Fees for External Support

In specific cases and with no prior mental health history, students may be eligible to use the College insurance for external mental health services.

Families are responsible for paying the remaining percentage not covered by the insurance and will be billed by the Finance team.

If a student is not eligible for this benefit, UWC Costa Rica will recommend trusted external professionals. In such cases, the full cost of services must be covered by the family.

Identification and Support for Undiagnosed Learning Needs

A Learning Support Counselor is available to provide holistic support for students with identified learning needs and organize diagnostic assessments when necessary. This position reports to the Academic Director who works closely with the Residential Life & Wellness Director and the teaching team to plan and execute the proper support for students that require academic adjustments. Any costs associated with diagnostic testing may be required to be paid by the family up front, in full.

Please see [Inclusive Access to Learning](#) within the Academic section.

Insurance Coverage

Medical insurance for all students is included in the fees paid to attend UWC Costa Rica. The coverage is 24 hours a day, during the academic year. For more information see the [Collective Health Insurance Sheet](#).

The insurance covers a percentage of the expenses, and the remainder is billed to the families by the College. For some high-cost procedures or treatments, the hospital may require pre-payment of a percentage of the cost, or in the case of services not approved by the insurance*, the full amount may be required prior to treatment or before the student is released. The College will make every effort to inform families of these matters as soon as they are known, so that payment can be arranged.

****Some examples not covered by insurance are:*** pre-existing conditions (for instance, previous orthopedic injury); dentistry; ophthalmology; pregnancy; any illness or injury presumed to be the result of the use of drugs, alcohol, or other chemical substances; instances of self-harm or attempts at such; treatment for mental illnesses or psychiatric disorders (see exclusions section in Collective Health Insurance Sheet).

Private insurance: If the family chooses to use private insurance for medical procedures on their students, it is their responsibility and not UWC Costa Rica, to communicate with the medical doctors in Costa Rica to receive receipts and any documentation asked for by the private provider.

Medication

All **prescription medication** a student takes should be listed on the medical registration form as part of the admissions process. Students are responsible for bringing their own medication. To ensure the safety of our students, all medications should be given to the Residence Coordinator and students can keep a small amount determined by the doctor. It is considered a major infraction in the Code of Conduct to share and to keep prescription drugs and this would bear the same consequences as illegal drug usage, both for the user and the sharer.

IMPORTANT: Failure to provide the prescribed medication to the Residence Coordinator constitutes a violation of the established safety measures and represents a breach of the Student Code of Conduct.

Families are encouraged to fill prescriptions at home and send the medication with students. It is a good idea to check with the medical staff on the availability of prescribed medications and associated costs ahead of time to make a well-informed decision regarding student care. In some cases, it may be necessary for the student to consult with the College doctor, or for the nurses or wellness counselor to support the student to establish themselves as a patient with a local healthcare provider. This will be necessary to update a prescription or have an alternative equivalent medication prescribed in Costa Rica.

IMPORTANT: Sharing non-prescription medications with others is considered a moderate infraction under the College's Code of Conduct. If a fellow student is feeling unwell, students can offer support by guiding them to the medical team.

If there is **concern regarding the misuse or abuse of any medication**, the **Residence Coordinator** may require the student to **store all medications** with the medical team for monitoring. Additionally, the student may be referred to the College doctor or a wellness counselor for further evaluation and support.

Immunization Requirements

At UWC Costa Rica, the health and well-being of our entire community is a top priority. To support a safe and healthy environment for all students and staff, **certain immunizations are mandatory** before arriving in Costa Rica.

We recognize that vaccine availability and standard immunization schedules may vary across the **more than 70 countries** represented in our student body. However, as part of our **shared responsibility for community health**, the following vaccinations are **required for all students**:

Hepatitis B	Measles, Mumps, and Rubella (MMR/SRP)
Diphtheria, Tetanus, and Pertussis (DTaP/Tdap)	Varicella (Chickenpox)

Students and families **must ensure** these immunizations are **fully up to date prior to arrival**. If there are any challenges—such as incomplete vaccine series or lack of access to certain vaccines—**families should contact the College’s medical team as early as possible** to discuss options and ensure a plan is in place.

NOTE: Please note that **students who do not meet the immunization requirements may be delayed from entering Costa Rica or participating in College activities**. Students **should not travel** to campus without having received all required vaccines unless **prior approval has been granted** by the medical team and a **clear plan for completion upon arrival** has been established. Families/guardians are responsible for paying for all vaccines.

Residential Life

At UWC Costa Rica, our 200 plus students live in shared residences with peers from over 70 nationalities. Some adult staff members and their families also live on campus to promote communication, trust, safety and exchange. This intentional environment is designed to foster cross-cultural understanding, empathy, and collaboration — essential values of the UWC movement.

Some characteristics of our student residences are:

- They are single gender and mixed gender,

- Each residence has between 25-30 students,
- Each room can have from 2 to 5 students,
- Every student has their own bed and personal storage space,
- There have shared bathrooms, common hang out areas, laundry and kitchen,
- They are named after Costa Rican beaches.

Residences are more than just a place to sleep, they are spaces for learning, connection, sharing and growth. Community living includes cooking, washing clothes, negotiating chores, learning about each other's cultures and habits and it also includes residence meetings, wellness spaces and community events.

Our model invites students to reflect on how they live and relate with others as part of their personal development. The Residential Life pillar teaches the importance of fostering a community grounded in mutual respect, understanding, and peace. Mediation plays a crucial role in addressing conflicts that arise within such a diverse community, providing a structured and collaborative process for resolving or transforming disputes. These experiences allow students to develop essential life skills like independence, responsibility, mediation and conflict resolution that will be very useful once you graduate.

Each residence has a **Residence Coordinator (RC)**, an adult staff member who lives on campus and supports, guides, and mentors students while promoting their safety and well-being.

Residence Coordinators (RCs)

Residence Coordinators (RCs) play a crucial role in ensuring students' well-being, fostering a supportive community, and managing the practical aspects of residence life. Rooted in the College's mission and values, they prioritize students' health, growth, and seamless transition into campus life. Residence Coordinators are dedicated to ensuring that every student's experience is, to the greatest extent possible, enriching, empowering, and transformative. Their role is key to creating a vibrant and inclusive living and learning environment for all.

Some key RC responsibilities related to the student experience include:

- **Student Support and Well-Being**
 - Serve as the primary point of contact for students and families/guardians, offering guidance and support to address any personal or emotional concerns.

- Conduct regular check-ins with students to promote well-being, providing resources and assistance as needed.
- Conduct formal individual meetings with each student each semester to strengthen connections with students and address any issues promptly and effectively. Extraordinary meetings can be called upon as needed.
- Conduct formal residence room meetings once each semester to promote and support harmonious relationships among roommates.
- Use necessary measures to ensure the adequate adaptation of students to the institution and the country, offering guidance and support as necessary.
- Communicate with students' teachers and mentors to check on their progress and any identified needs.
- **Community Development and Student Engagement**
 - Facilitate community-building activities that promote collaboration, intercultural understanding, and a sense of belonging among residents.
 - Encourage student leadership and initiatives in residence projects, outings and community engagement, fostering a culture of responsibility and social impact.
- **Sustainability & Maintenance**
 - Ensure compliance with sustainability standards and efforts, including proper waste management (recycling and composting), efficient and conscious use of resources (electricity and water), and support for additional environmentally forward initiatives proposed by the College or by students.
 - Ensure the maintenance of the residence, reporting any repairs or improvements that are needed (as reported by students).
 - Oversee the assignment of shared student duties related to routine residence cleaning and upkeep.
- **Family Partnership**
 - Serve as a liaison between students, families, guardians and the College, maintaining open communication channels to address concerns.
 - Provide information to families/guardians to help them support their students' success and well-being while they are away from home.
- **Safety**
 - Educate students regarding expectations of the Code of Conduct and apply it equitably.

- Prepare disciplinary infraction reports in accordance with the Code of Conduct and then document and oversee restorative actions and any assigned consequences sent to families over email and recorded on Reach Student Life Management platform.
- Review and grant leave requests for students, as needed on Reach platform.
- Accompany the students under their charge in health emergencies or any external medical consultation, as necessary.

Residential Life Student Leadership Roles

In the Residential Life & Wellness program student leadership roles such as Wellness Ambassadors, Fitness Ambassadors and student Residence Assistants (RAs) are integral to fostering a supportive and inclusive community. These roles exist to empower students to take an active role in shaping their living environment, promoting well-being, and fostering a sense of belonging. All these leadership roles go through a selection process and receive training.

By serving as advocates for wellness and mentors for their peers, Wellness Ambassadors channel community needs to support meaningful preventive interventions and facilitate engaging activities to deliver the Residential Life & Wellness educational curriculum. Student Residence Assistants, on the other hand, act as connectors and communicators, fostering a positive and supportive atmosphere within their residences and helping students acclimate to life at UWC Costa Rica, especially when students are facing challenges. Through their dedication to service, personal integrity, and collaborative spirit, these student leaders exemplify the College's commitment to developing compassionate and responsible individuals capable of effecting positive change in their communities and beyond.

For more information about these roles, responsibilities and selection process, please see the Handbook section on Student Leadership.

Guidelines for Residential Life

To ensure a harmonious living environment, upholding the values of respect, responsibility, cleanliness, safety, inclusivity, and cultural sensitivity within our community, students must familiarize themselves with the following guidelines and expectations:

Residence and Roommate Assignments

Residences and rooms are assigned considering factors such as regional diversity and a balance of first- and second-year students. The Residential Life and Wellness team are in charge of room

allocations. The residential life educational program seeks to have students learn about conflict transformation, intercultural communication, empathy, and cultural understanding. Students may only be placed in non-binary/mixed-gender residences with parental/legal guardian approval.

By following these guidelines, the College aims to foster a respectful, responsible, and safe living environment that accommodates diverse backgrounds and cultural sensitivities as well as to create a learning environment based on experiential learning. Conflicts should be viewed as opportunities for growth and positive change, contributing to the UWC mission of a more peaceful and sustainable future. Cooperation is key to maintaining a harmonious and respectful living space. We expect all of our students to have the willingness to learn negotiation skills, how to set boundaries, and how to express needs.

Residence Meetings and Individual Meetings with RCs

Residence Coordinators (RCs) host a residence meeting every other week. They also host at least one meeting between roommates per semester to monitor the well-being and coexistence of students in the same room. Meetings aim to establish limits, ensure Code of Conduct adherence, as well as address hygiene, friendships, healthy lifestyle, self-care, nutrition, and other issues. During these meetings, topics from our Residential Life & Wellness educational curriculum are addressed to ensure that students learn from living in community and from each other, as one of the best opportunities to practice our UWC values.

Residence Coordinators also regularly check the emotional, physical, and mental well-being of students in their residences and conduct at least one formal, individual meeting per semester. In addition to personal check-ins, students are encouraged to reach out to their RC with any residential or interpersonal matters where they would like assistance or advice with handling situations of concern.

Roommate Agreements: Diplomacy in Shared Living Spaces

Living in a diverse community presents unique opportunities to practice diplomacy and conflict transformation on a small scale, preparing students for future interactions in a global society. Roommate agreements are essential to maintaining a harmonious living environment.

Students are expected to document, sign, and prominently display the agreements reached during roommate meetings for easy reference. These guidelines aim to foster a respectful and pleasant living

environment in the residence, while recognizing that conflicts and challenges are opportunities to practice becoming future peacemakers.

Room and Residence Cleanliness

Maintaining a clean-living space is essential to promoting a hygienic and harmonious environment, conducive to student well-being. To achieve this, the following specific expectations have been established for individual room and residence cleanliness and safety, which collectively contribute to the overall sustainability of our living community:

- Students must always clean up after themselves, ensuring that their personal spaces remain tidy and organized.
- Roommates are expected to organize cleaning days and establish cleaning agreements amongst themselves to collectively maintain cleanliness.
- Cleaning responsibilities will be defined by each residence and RC, including areas such as the kitchen, living room, hallways, rooms, bathrooms, adjacent outdoor spaces, composting food waste and recycling.
- When visiting other residences, students are expected to respect the established rules of the residence, especially regarding cleaning and behavior.
- Roommates are expected to clean common areas and the room floor.
- Any repairs needed within the room should be promptly reported to the Residence Coordinator (RC) for timely resolution. If broken on purpose, the repair and/or replacement cost will be deducted from the deposit or billed directly to the family.
- Residents should be cautious about placing heavy, unsecured items up high on bookshelves to avoid safety hazards, especially in the event of an earthquake.
- Students are not allowed to take any Residence equipment and furniture, from a residence that is not their own, (blender, toaster, food, etc) nor any student property (clothes, food, phones, etc) without asking for permission to do so.

Supervision and Inspections

The Residence Coordinator will set a cleaning schedule for the residence, reserving the right to inspect individual rooms from time to time to ensure standards of cleanliness are being met, that prohibited

items are not present, and room rules and agreements are respected. Students should always open the door of their rooms when asked by staff and follow the staff instructions related to supervision or safety. Sexual intimacy is not allowed at any space in our campus.

More information about room searches can be found in the **Code of Conduct section of this handbook.**

Prohibited Items in Rooms

For safety reasons, no items requiring fire/open flame are allowed in rooms (for example: candles, incense, lighters and lanterns). The Code of Conduct includes a more extensive list and description of prohibited items which would also have disciplinary consequences.

The RC may prohibit and/or confiscate any item deemed to be unsafe, in opposition to sustainability measures, or a nuisance to other residents. Some examples might include small decorative lights which the student leaves on while not in the room, wasting electricity and creating a risk for overheating; strong smelling air fresheners; and furniture or decorative items which are broken or unable to be cleaned.

No room decor may reference or visually depict alcohol, smoking, tobacco, drugs of any kind (legal or illegal), firearms or weapons of any kind. While not expressly prohibited, students are encouraged to consider matters of cultural sensitivity when decorating with national emblems or religious symbols. Each student may display their country's national flag in the designated common area of the residence, keeping in mind that it should be of medium size (not larger than approx. 1x2 meters) for there to be room for all to be displayed.

Use of Common Areas in Residences

Students should turn off lights and televisions when not in use to conserve energy. External doors should remain closed to prevent pests from entering. It is courteous to remove muddy shoes before entering a residence. Students should not use the living area/common room space nor prepare food in a residence which is not their own, unless they are accompanied by at least one of the residents.

Laundry Facilities

Students are responsible for their own laundry. Laundry facilities are provided within each residence as a convenience to all students. To sustain College equipment and provide equitable access, the following should be considered:

- **Scheduling and Availability:** Each residence establishes a schedule to allocate specific times for laundry use, ensuring fair access and the responsible use of campus equipment.
- **Use liquid detergent:** To extend the lifespan of the laundry machines and avoid clogging, use liquid detergent instead of powdered soap.
- **Hand-washing Area:** A large hand-washing sink is included in residence bathrooms. Students should avoid leaving clothes hanging in the hand-washing areas or leaving anything in these sinks as they are also used by the cleaning and maintenance staff for routine tasks such as cleaning common areas of the residences.
- **Drip-drying Indoor Area:** Clothes lines are strung above the kitchen area, accessed from the second-floor hallway, in each residence. This is the preferred drying area for students to use.
- **Outdoor Drying Considerations:** Students who choose to dry laundry outside may do so.

Security of Rooms and Personal Belongings

The College is not responsible for students' personal belongings and valuables and recommends they are not left unattended. Students are responsible for securing their belongings in their closets/rooms and according to their roommates' agreement for locking the room when away. It is not recommended to bring items of significant value such as jewelry or sentimental value which might be considered irreplaceable. Important items such as passports and spending money may be stored in the safe box of the RC's house.

Quiet Zones and Silence Hours

The College understands the importance of balancing the desire for a vibrant community spirit with individual needs. To foster a conducive environment for studying and rest, we observe silence hours on campus from 10:00 p.m. to 7:00 a.m. During silence time, the entire campus, from the security gate to the residential area, becomes a designated quiet zone, including common areas like the social center and library.

Silence hours on campus are from 10:00 p.m. to 7:00 a.m.

Cooperation is key in respecting these hours to allow fellow students and residential staff to focus on their studies and rest without disruption. As the College is in a neighborhood area of Santa Ana, there are also local noise ordinances and Costa Rican laws, which require these silence hours to be in place. Students are expected to refrain from behaviors that disturb the tranquility, such as loud conversations, music with speakers, sports participation/bouncing balls, or other noisy activities. Students must also be mindful of the families who reside on campus, some with young children and senior citizens, and family members with different working hours, and try to be respectful of their needs.

Understanding and mindfulness of the needs of neighbors, both on and off campus, are greatly appreciated. By observing silence hours, everyone contributes to a harmonious and balanced environment where each person has the chance to thrive academically and enjoy restful nights.

Sustainability in Residential Life

UWC Costa Rica is committed to creating a sustainable future by promoting a whole-College sustainability approach that includes eco-friendly practices, and both recycling and composting are essential components of this commitment. The College believes that these actions align with community values of reciprocity and accountability and as part of a global society which emphasizes environmental responsibility. By embracing recycling and composting best practices, students will be actively participating in building a better future for the planet as well as promoting community values. Recycling and composting guidelines are provided for all staff and students.

Recycling

Recycling is more than just a task; it's a collective effort to reduce each person's environmental footprint and promote healthier communities. It is also about creating awareness around habits of consumption. Recycling not only contributes to conserving valuable resources but also reduces the energy and greenhouse gas emissions associated with the production of new materials. This aligns with the UWC movement's mission to create a more sustainable world, one step at a time.

Recyclables typically include paper, cardboard, glass, plastic, aluminum and Resin8. Signage is posted in residences and key common spaces around campus which give more precise guidelines and examples. By recycling these materials, our community will be actively participating in the circular economy, ensuring that resources are used efficiently and with minimal waste.

Composting

Composting is a simple yet impactful way to reduce food waste and promote soil health. When disposed of properly and composting organic matter, waste is diverted from landfills and creates nutrient-rich soil amendments for gardening and agriculture. Students use the compost produced on campus for greenhouse projects.

Compostable items include fruit and vegetable scraps, coffee grounds, eggshells, food leftovers and other organic matter. Instructions are posted around composting bins to understand what can and should be added to the bin. For more information please see [UWC Costa Rica Recycling and Composting Guidelines](#)

Guidelines for Conservation of Resources

Conservation of resources, particularly electricity and water, plays a crucial role in efforts to minimize environmental impact. Collective actions regarding electricity and water usage significantly impact campus consumption and the College's carbon footprint.

UWC Costa Rica students are expected to contribute to the following:

Electricity Conservation

- Turn off lights, fans, ACs, electrical appliances, and chargers when not in use. Each switch-off is a step toward reducing unnecessary energy consumption.
- Disconnect chargers from the outlet when not actively charging devices. This small step can make a big difference in curbing standby power usage.

Water Conservation

- Do not leave water running when not in use, especially when brushing teeth or shaving. Every drop counts.
- Keep showers to a maximum of 10 minutes. This helps conserve water and energy used for heat.
- When washing dishes, avoid leaving the water running continuously for rinsing. Instead, use a basin or plug the sink to reduce water wastage.
- Use the laundry machine for full loads only. This ensures maximized efficiency of each wash cycle and reduces water and energy consumption.

- If a leak in a faucet, shower, or toilet is noticed, report it to the Residence Coordinator or adult in charge of the area as soon as possible. Timely repairs are crucial to prevent water wastage.

By adhering to these guidelines, everyone actively contributes to the sustainability framework and the values our community holds dear. Every action counts, and collectively, a substantial impact is achievable by conserving resources and creating a more environmentally responsible and sustainable future.

Wildlife, Pest Control & Living in the Tropics

Maintaining a clean and comfortable environment in residences, classrooms, and common spaces around campus is a priority. The Costa Rican tropical environment offers opportunities to appreciate biodiversity and wildlife such as birds, iguanas, raccoons, and squirrels while respecting their habitat and keeping them separate from human areas. The rainy season spans about half of the year, from May to October, making nature lush and beautiful but it also can bring some challenges.

It is essential for everyone to do their part to maintain a safe environment and avoid drawing wildlife such as raccoons and snakes and/or pests like ants, termites, flies, and cockroaches into human spaces.

Expectations

To protect personal belongings and maintain a safe, pest free living environment, expectations and practices for all community members are as follows:

- **Proper Food Storage:** Store food in sealed containers in designated spaces in the kitchen or common areas to prevent attracting pests. Avoid storing food in closets, drawers, or under beds in rooms.
- **Do Not Feed Wildlife:** Never feed wildlife on campus by hand, as there is a risk of being bitten. This is also against wildlife protection laws in the country. Do not leave food scraps in open garbage bins.
- **Return Plates and Utensils to the Cafeteria:** for proper sanitizing and disposal of food waste in designated areas.
- **Regular Garbage Removal:** Ensure that trash is regularly taken out from rooms and common areas. Use provided trash containers and follow the established garbage collection schedule and guidelines.

- **Door Closure at Night:** Keep doors closed at night, especially external residence doors, to prevent pests from entering living spaces.
- **Encountering Wildlife:** In some instances, wildlife like snakes, tarantulas, scorpions, iguanas, raccoons, and other animals may enter or encroach upon human spaces. **Please do not feed them.** Keep your distance and seek assistance from the nearest adult. Our security staff are trained to remove wildlife or will contact external service providers for safe removal and relocation.
- **Cleanliness:** Maintain the cleanliness of individual rooms and common spaces. Wipe up spills immediately, avoid leaving dirty dishes lying around, and ensure laundry does not pile up.
- **Furniture Maintenance/Removal:** Remove damaged or unused furniture to prevent it from becoming a haven for pests. Report any damage or infestation to the Residence Coordinator.
- **Mold and Mildew Prevention:** Humidity and rain can lead to mold and mildew. Keep belongings clean and dry by using moisture-absorbing products, like silica gel packs or dehumidifiers, in storage areas. Regularly air out items and consider using moisture-resistant storage solutions.
- **Food and Drink Management:** To mitigate the risk of attracting insects and other pests, especially ants, ensure that food and beverages are properly covered when not being consumed. Wipe up spills promptly, and do not leave uneaten food or dirty dishes out. Secure food in sealed containers to prevent pests from gaining access.
- **Personal Electronics:** High humidity and rain can pose a risk to personal electronics. Avoid leaving computers, phones, calculators, or any other electronic devices outside or in potentially very damp spaces. Store them in dry, moisture-free areas to prevent potential damage. Small ants are also drawn to the heat emitted by personal electronics and may nest inside, potentially rendering expensive electronics useless. To prevent this, store electronics in sealed, airtight containers or storage bags when not in use. Additionally, inspect and clean electronic devices regularly to discourage infestations and potential damage from small ants.
- **Termites:** Termites can be more active during rainy weather. To avoid infestations, inspect living spaces for signs of termite activity, such as tiny holes in wood or small piles of sawdust. If termite presence is suspected, promptly notify the Residence Coordinator (RC) so maintenance can address the issue.

- **Flies and Mosquitos:** Residence rooms are equipped with protective screens on windows to allow for airflow while also reducing the flies and mosquitoes indoors. Students should promptly report any tears in screens to their Residence Coordinator to arrange for repairs.

Adhering to these guidelines helps maintain a clean and safe living environment, in harmony with wildlife present in our area. Students encountering any pest-related concerns should promptly report them to their Residence Coordinator for resolution.

Student Rooms

The College ensures that each student's living space is equipped with essential furnishings and amenities for their comfort and convenience. These include:

- Bed with basic bed sheets, a lightweight blanket, and one pillow (Note that while the residences are not air-conditioned, nighttime temperatures can be cool at certain points during the year. The College does not provide a comforter, duvet, or quilt and leaves it to a student's personal preference to bring or purchase what is needed.)
- Nightstand
- Desk with a chair
- Bookshelf
- Closet (aka "Wardrobe" cabinet)
- At least, one fan per room
- Curtains for room windows

Common Rooms: In addition to individual room furnishings, each residence offers basic equipped communal kitchen and living room areas which include:

- Refrigerator with freezer
- Microwave
- Shared cupboards assigned to students for food storage
- Couches

- At least one dining table
- TV
- Washer and drying machine (students provide their own soap, fabric softener, etc.)
- Cleaning supplies (for dusting, sweeping, mopping, windows and sinks)

Packing List: Required and Suggested Items

While the College provides many essentials, students are responsible for bringing their own electronic items as well as items to personalize their living space and meet their individual needs for comfort.

The College highly recommends that all items of value be labeled with the student's name or initials.

Required Items

Students are required to bring their own:

- **Clothing and shoes** (see separate list below for suggestions)
- **Laptop computer** (and optionally, a tablet). The College recommends a laptop model of no more than two years, RAM memory of at least 8GB, with a solid-state drive (SSD). We recommend paying for a guarantee with global support that can be claimed in Costa Rica.
- **Toiletries and personal hygiene products** (such as shampoo, soap/body wash, deodorant, feminine hygiene supplies, etc. at least enough for the first few weeks until students are able to go off campus and purchase what is needed)
- **Necessary medication**, including prescription pain and psychiatric medications which must be turned in upon arrival to their Residence Coordinator.
- **Personal grooming products** (brush, comb, hair ties, blow dryer or other styling products as desired)
- **Graphing calculator for Math** - TiNspire is preferred (a limited quantity exists for loan with priority going to full scholarship students).

- **Cell phone with Wi-Fi connectivity** (consider if the student will want to purchase a local data plan for connectivity and safety when off campus or away from a Wi-Fi signal).
- **Electronic equipment** such as adaptors, chargers, headphones, etc. Costa Rica uses Type A and Type B electrical plugs with 110-120 volts AC. (See illustration)



- **College bag/backpack and stationery** such as notebooks, pens and pencils, highlighters, etc. (a basic package of supplies is provided for full scholarship students; some additional supplies are available in limited quantities and upon request from the Academic office for partial scholarship students).
- **Travel documents:** passport, IDs.

Optional Items

Students may also wish to bring, or purchase at some point after arrival:

- Decorations to personalize their living space (keeping in mind that these should not be contrary to UWC values or Code of Conduct, for instance, nothing depicting alcohol, tobacco, illicit substances or advocating violence).
- Bedding such as additional bed pillows, a spare sheet set, preferred blanket or bed covering.
- Desk lamp or bedside lamp.
- Personal sleeping bag for outings (the College does have some to loan).
- Personal yoga mat for exercise, as a ground covering to sit on for outdoor gatherings, or as a pad under a sleeping bag.
- Small flashlight or battery-operated light.
- Familiar over-the-counter medications for allergies (especially if sensitive to mold/mildew during the rainy season), head and body aches, itch relief cream for bug bites (See additional information under Medication: Prescription and Nonprescription earlier in this section.).

- Sunscreen.
- Insect-repellant.
- Reusable water bottle/sports bottle to carry on field trips and to sporting practices/events (a personalized reusable cup is provided for each student for use at mealtimes).
- Umbrella and/or rain poncho.
- Waterproof bag for electronics, dry-bag for phone while on hikes or beach trips.
- Cooking spices or favorite sealed snack foods from home.

Suggested Clothing and Accessories Packing List

Please note that the following clothing packing list serves as a comprehensive guide to assist students and families in preparing for an extended time away from home and facing a variety of experiences. It is important to understand that not every item listed will apply to every student, gender, or personal/cultural preference. Instead, this list is intended to provide a framework from which students and families can make informed decisions based on their individual needs, experiences, and comfort levels. It is intended that each student will adapt and customize the list to suit their specific requirements and preferences. The College aims to ensure that each student feels comfortable, prepared, and empowered to thrive in our tropical climate and diverse community.

Lightweight Clothing, Breathable Fabrics	Lightweight Layers
• T-shirts • Tank tops • Shorts/Skorts • Pants and skirts • Dresses	• Lightweight long-sleeve shirts (for sun and insect protection) • Thin cardigans or sweaters (for cooler evenings or mountain outings) • Lightweight windbreaker jacket
Essential Undergarments	Rain Gear and Quick-Dry Clothing
• Underwear (for one-week daily wear) • Bras (regular and sports bras) • Socks (mix of regular and athletic) • Yoga pants, leggings, tights (as preferred)	• Lightweight, packable rain jacket or poncho • Quick-dry athletic wear (for outdoor activities and hikes and humid days) • Quick-dry underwear and socks

Sun and Insect Protection	Warm Layers
• Wide-brimmed hat or cap • Sunglasses with UV protection • Sunscreen • Lightweight, long-sleeve shirts and pants (for evenings or forest outings) • Insect repellent (DEET-free options recommended for sensitive skin)	• Fleece jacket, sweater, and/or hoodie (for cooler evenings or mountain outings) • Lightweight down or synthetic insulated jacket (for colder nights) • Jeans
Formal Attire for Social Events	Themed Costume Clothing
• Formal dresses or suits (for formal dances like Prom) • Accessories (ties, vests, belts, hair, etc.)	• Costumes or themed attire for various theme days and holidays • Accessories to complement costumes (hats, props, etc.)
Cultural Representation	Specialized Sport or Performance Gear
• Traditional clothing representing national culture • Flag from home country (for cultural events or international celebrations; note 1x2 meters is the preferred approximate size for display)	• Musical instruments (beware of how humidity might impact care and upkeep) • Soccer cleats (if expecting to play competitively) • Running shoes • Any other specialized gear relevant to extracurricular activities or hobbies
Professional Attire	Footwear
These items are needed for MUN, dinners with board members and donors, and other special events hosted by the College or its partners. It is recommended that you have at least 1-2 professional outfits to mix and match. • Dress shirts/blouses • Dress pants/skirts • Blazer or professional jacket and tie	• Sturdy sandals or flip-flops (for beach outings and showering) • Closed-toe shoes with good gripping capacity (suitable for hiking and walking) • Lightweight sneakers or walking shoes • Dress shoes such as pumps/loafers to go with professional/formal attire (MUN, graduation, scholarship dinners, etc.)

In situations where it is essential for students to obtain specific items, we encourage families to discuss local options for purchase or acquisition with their students. Consulting with the Residence Coordinator can provide valuable guidance and assistance in identifying suitable local resources.

Please do not send packages by mail. It is not necessary as students can buy many items in the country (for more information see Handbook section on Communication).

Money Management

Managing finances while studying abroad is an essential aspect of students growing in personal responsibility during their journey through UWC Costa Rica. This section provides guidance and recommendations regarding money management, banking services, and currency exchange for students and families.

Bank Cards: Preferred Option for Student Access to Personal Funds

The College strongly recommends utilizing bank cards for financial transactions whenever possible. International cards that are compatible with ATMs in Costa Rica provide convenient access to funds without the need for carrying large amounts of cash. There are numerous ATM machines at local banks and in grocery stores close to campus.

Recommended cards with more frequent acceptance: **Visa/Plus, Mastercard/Cirrus, and less so, American Express.**

Currency Exchange

If cash needs to be sent with the student, they can exchange cash for local currency upon arrival at the airport. This process requires that the student present their passport. In some cases, a student under the age of 18 may need to ask a peer of legal age to make the exchange for them. Uncommon (non-touristic) currencies and funds coming from countries where Costa Rica has imposed international banking restrictions may not be accepted for exchange. It may be necessary to secure US Dollars or Euros ahead of time to exchange.

Safe Storage of Cash

To minimize the risk of theft or loss, each Residence Coordinator has the capability to lock excess cash in a secure safe. This enables students to arrange to access funds as needed while safeguarding their money.

Banking Services and Wire Transfers

Please note that minors are unable to receive wire transfers, and **no bank accounts may be opened for them in Costa Rica.**

If families/guardians come with the student to drop them off at UWC Costa Rica, please do not open a bank account, since if anything happens (for example, losing their PIN, changes to passwords that have to be done in person) their legal guardian must go with them (this means our Head or Deputy Head of School).

Students 18 years of age and above, and with a Dimex card (Costa Rican residence identification card for foreign nationals), may open their own account; nevertheless, the College is unable to provide support for this process.

Please note that minors are unable to receive wire transfers, and bank accounts may NOT be opened for them in Costa Rica.

Scholarship Student Disbursements

Some students, as part of their scholarship allotment, receive a modest monthly stipend to cover expenses for essential items. These payments are dispersed by the Finance Office every month. Students eligible for the disbursement will be notified with additional information.

Campus Leave

This section highlights various types of campus leaves, their approval processes, and expectations to ensure student safety, our utmost priority at UWC Costa Rica. The College believes that empowering students with the responsibility of making choices aligned with their values and our community's principles is an essential aspect of their personal growth. The Residential Life & Wellness program plays a vital role in achieving a balance between supervision and granting students increased freedoms and decision-making opportunities.

Residence Coordinators (RCs) foster an environment where students can make informed decisions while experiencing the diverse and enriching UWC experience as well as journeying beyond the campus gates to explore the richness and diversity of this beautiful host country. Campus leave is an important aspect of balancing freedom with responsibility, earning and maintaining trust. RCs will coordinate with families and guardians to analyze granting some of these leave permissions.

It is important to note that students are expected to fulfill all their Co-Curricular, Academic, and Residential responsibilities to have leave requests approved by RCs.

Types of Leaves of Absence from Campus

1. **Family Emergency or Bereavement:** A parent/guardian should contact the **Education Director** directly. The Education Director will coordinate communication with the academic, co-curricular, and residential life and wellness areas and assist in planning for the student's departure.
2. **Medical Leave:** Due to medical or health reasons, including those of a psychological nature, it may be decided that a student must return home for essential care. A Medical Leave Agreement will be composed, outlining the reason for absence, date of review of conditions/progress, treatment expectations, and conditions necessary to support a healthy return.
 - Note that in rare cases involving threats, actions of self-harm, and risky behaviors, or in other circumstances requiring supervision or support beyond the College's normal contractual provision or the capacity of staff, the College may require the leave of absence until which time it is determined if it is appropriate to return or not. In these cases, the Medical Leave agreement will contain these stipulations. Note that it may also be deemed necessary, for safety reasons, that a parent/legal guardian or their adult designee travel to Costa Rica to escort the student home.
 - The **Residential Life & Wellness Director** oversees the details of medical leaves in coordination with the student's assigned wellness counselor and with the input of the Academic and Co-Curricular Directors. The **Education Director** provides final approval and assists in coordination as needed.
3. **Exceptional Circumstances:** In exceptional circumstances, a short Leave of Absence may be granted for a student due to a unique growth opportunity that aligns with the UWC experience.
 - The student must send an email to the Education Director, copying the Academic, Co-Curricular, Residential Life & Wellness Directors and the Student Affairs Coordinator. Examples of approved leave of this type could be selection to represent one's country or indigenous culture on international panels pertaining to

environmental concerns or promoting peaceful practices; selection to present one's College-related project on the international stage; or being invited for recognition of one's contributions by a Head of State or organization of international importance.

- Note that university visits, employment opportunities, and social events such as family milestone birthdays or anniversaries do not qualify as exceptional opportunities. In these cases, students and families are encouraged to explore online avenues of engagement or schedule around the College calendar.
- Families should make every effort to adhere to the published [institutional calendar](#) with student arrival and departure dates, including official holiday travel dates during the College year.
 - Summer camps, internships, or courses are not an acceptable reason to miss any part of the mandatory orientation period.
 - Tickets for travel should be purchased well in advance to take advantage of the best possible fares. The cost of travel is not an acceptable excuse for a late arrival or early departure, nor will it be a justified reason for the student to miss exams or mandatory course experiences such as the group 4 sciences project.
 - Unjustified absences may result in additional consequences or restorative actions as defined by attendance practices, including taking a zero on a mandatory assignment or exam.

The **Education Director** oversees the details of miscellaneous leaves, late arrivals and early holidays with the input of the Directors of Residential Life & Wellness, Academics and Co-Curricular.

4. **Routine Daily, Weekend and Overnight Leaves:** For tracking the day-to-day off-campus leaves of students as well as holiday periods throughout the academic year, the College uses the platform **REACH Student Life Management** and its associated applications.

The information on routine leave provided below is a general outline according to current practices, and information is subject to change. The College may change the schedule or requirements due to special events or circumstances, typically announced to students through email or in their residence meetings.

Type of Leave	Days of Week	Hours	Request Timeline	Minimum # of Partners	Additional Notes
Day	Every day	6:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m.	Submit Request - Automatically Approved	Two (2) (Add partner's name in the notes section of request).	Approved once by parents/guardians upon admission.
Evenings-College Weeknights	Sunday to Thursday	6:00 p.m. to 8:00 p.m.	Students submit requests for approval to residential staff	Three (3) (Add 2 partners' names in the notes section of request).	Limited to no more than 2 times per week. May be denied for missing mandatory meetings or neglecting residential duties. May be restricted if having moderate or major offenses to the Code of Conduct.
Evenings - Weekend	Friday and Saturday	6:00 p.m. to 10:00 p.m.	Students submit requests for approval to residential staff.	Three (3) (Add 2 partners' names in the notes section of request).	May be denied for missing mandatory meetings or neglecting residential duties. May be restricted if having moderate or major offenses to the Code of Conduct.
Overnight*	Friday and Saturday; Long Weekends such as Natl. Holidays	6:00 a.m. departure to 8:00 p.m. or 10:00 p.m. return (latest return	Students submit requests for approval to residential staff.		Not allowed during College weeknights. May be denied or receive a reduction in the number of eligible days due to moderate or major offenses to the Code of Conduct.

	(8-night cumulative limit / academic year)	time depends on day of the week) NOTE: Exceptions may be made with advance approval according to bus route availability.			Solo overnights with extended family, friends, and former UWC peers are not allowed. NOTE: “Immediate family,” for the purpose of overnight stays, shall be defined as parent, legal guardian, sibling over the age of 18, first degree uncle/aunt or grandparents only.
--	--	--	--	--	--

*Overnight- Additional Notes

- **Total overnights:** Students are permitted to sleep off-campus up to **8 (eight) nights** per academic year, but eligible days may be denied or reduced in number due to moderate or major offenses to the Code of Conduct.
- **When:** Overnights are only permitted where there are no classes or required activities the next day. Residence Coordinators must check the Educational Calendar before approving leaves.
- **Not overnights:** Extended vacation periods listed on the Institutional Calendar such as “October Recharge” or “Semana Santa” (Easter/Holy Week) in March/April, as well as the December/January holidays, and staying with host families, does not count toward the cumulative total of 8.
- **Approval:** Parents/guardians must approve each outing before RC’s approval.
- **Safety & Context:** Before the RC gives final approval for the overnight permissions, they will check location and booking details uploaded to REACH and consider the Costa Rican context and any recent travel alerts (weather or safety related) to ensure students’ safety. The College, or individual RCs under the direction of the Director of Residential Life & Wellness, may decline to grant permission for safety reasons. Because of this, these **permissions have to be**

requested on the working schedules of Residence Coordinators, weekdays from 2:00-9:00pm, (permissions cannot be granted on weekends), otherwise there will not be time to make a safety review. Last-minute requests will not be granted.

- **Leave denial:** If the student has not met Residential, Co-Curricular, or Academic attendance or mandatory task requirements, the RCs may also deny leave permission.
- **Travel in groups:** Students must travel in a minimum group of three, and their travel partners must be named ahead of time in the permission request for security guards to grant exit. Students add this information in the “Notes” section of their request. Students are expected to always remain together during the period of approved leave, departing and returning to campus with the same approved travel group members.
- **Family/Guardians and travel partners:** When immediate family members or guardians visit Costa Rica and want to take students off campus overnight, the travel partners rule may be excluded. If this is the case:
 - The student must inform their RC, and their families should email the RC to state the date(s) and time(s).
 - The family member must pick the student up at the gate. The student may not travel independently to meet the family elsewhere as the College will release only to the parent/guardian’s care. If the family member cannot pick-up the student, they need to fill in a **special permission form**, where they assume the safety responsibility for the student to leave on their own.
 - If the family wishes to also host a friend(s) of the student, the hosting family should include the names of the guest students in the email and state that they are aware that they assume responsibility for the additional students if they take them out (for dinner, beach, or any place). The guest student(s) must also secure permission from their families ahead of time.
 - **All curfew times must be respected when on leave with family members:** no tardiness (being late) will be justified, and consequences will be applied according to the Code of Conduct. Evening curfew rules apply to everyone. If there is a delay, the student(s) are expected to communicate with the staff on duty and/or director on call, letting them know of the delay.

***Immediate family definition.** For overnight stays, immediate family includes parents, legal guardians, siblings over the age of 18, first degree uncle/aunt or grandparents only. All must be over the age of 18.

Other Leave Permissions

The College recognizes that not all reasons for permission can be anticipated, and there may be circumstances which arise that do not fit any of the categories already specified. When students or families believe this to be true, leave should be requested from the RC as far in advance as possible, with parent approval. Examples of other leave permissions have included:

- **Medical Appointment Off-Campus:** When a student makes an appointment with a medical professional not requested by the medical team (dentist, orthodontist, optometrist, psychiatrist, etc.), they should attempt to find another student to accompany them and schedule the appointment to be able to return before 6:00 p.m. When this is not possible, the student should contact their RC, at least one week before the appointment.
- **Host Family Outing:** Students are allowed to go out with their assigned host families with the same schedule as regular day, evening, and overnight leaves. Host families are required to pick up and drop off students at the campus gate with the ID of the responsible adult. Students may not travel on their own to meet their host family elsewhere.

In some cases, the educational team Director(s), the Education Director, the Student Affairs Coordinator or the Director on-call may also be involved in granting special permission for extenuating circumstances not listed above. **Please remember that solo leave is highly discouraged and unlikely to be approved.** For all types of special requests, it is necessary to provide information on who will be responsible for the student's care while away from campus and include information regarding who will pick up and return the student to campus.

Leave Restrictions

Medical and Health Related Leaves: Students treated for illness on the day of a requested leave or those who are justified in missing classes due to illness or mental health will have their evening or overnight leave revoked that day. This also includes not leaving campus to participate in a co-curricular or service activity.

During this time, students are expected to **remain on campus to rest and recover**, with access to **medical support** as needed. This policy ensures that students prioritize their well-being and have the appropriate care available while they recover.

Planning for Leave

Careful planning is essential when requesting a leave of absence from campus. The College recommends students, and their families consider the following:

- **Distance & Options:** Distance and transportation options to the destination of choice.
- **Availability of Public Transportation:** Availability of public transportation to return on time. Try to book ahead online. Not all bus routes in Costa Rica allow for pre-purchase/reserved tickets and lines for buses on those routes can form hours in advance. Try to book in advance to ensure a seat on a bus or shuttle. Some destinations only have 1 or 2 return trips to San Jose per day.
- **Traffic:** For far-away trips, be aware that traffic jams on major roads are common on weekends, especially during long weekends and public holidays. As such, it is advisable to buy tickets in advance and leave a few hours earlier than usual. Use apps such as Google Maps or Waze to check the estimated arrival time based on the planned departure time, then add an hour to account for further delays.
- **Viability:** Before finalizing plans, students should check with their RC, to ensure the trip is viable, taking into consideration the season, types of transportation, and possible national alerts like floods or landslides.
- **Evidence:** Keep evidence of planning, such as photos of purchased tickets and notification messages.

Help with Leave Request Mistakes

Residence Coordinators and Residence Assistants will spend time each year in orientation and beyond training students how and when to access and use the College's student life management system (REACH) to request leaves. When mistakes occur, there will be adults on duty on campus, as well as a Director on Call who can assist students if their RC is unavailable. Students receive a weekly email letting them know who is on call so they can seek help when needed.

Host Family Program

The Host Family Program at UWC Costa Rica embodies the commitment to fostering cultural exchange, community engagement, and emotional support for students. Rooted in the mission to educate individuals for positive change, this program facilitates connections between our diverse student body and local or international families residing in Costa Rica who the College has properly vetted. Many host families enjoy a long-standing relationship with the College and often return as hosts. Through this initiative, students and their hosts can share and understand customs, values, and experiences, enriching their educational journey and contributing to a more interconnected world.

Student Eligibility and Application Process

To participate in the Host Family Program, students must apply voluntarily, recognizing that the program's capacity is limited. Priority is given to students with full scholarships and those facing challenges returning home during the longer breaks.

The application process begins with students filling out a form provided by the Host Family Coordinator. Selected students are typically notified and introduced to their host families during a specially hosted event. Before the first meeting, students and their parents or legal guardians, along with the host family, must sign an agreement which outlines everyone's roles, responsibilities, and commitments. Regular communication and coordination between students, parents, host families, and the residential staff ensure smooth interactions and support.

Student-Family-Host Family Agreement

The success of the Host Family Program relies on mutual respect, understanding, and adherence to established agreements. Students are responsible for communicating needs, respecting family rules, and actively participating in family activities. Host families, in turn, commit to providing support, clarifying expectations, and ensuring student safety and well-being. Clear guidelines govern communication, behavior, expenses, and emergency procedures, fostering a positive and inclusive environment for all parties involved. By upholding these agreements, students, families, and host families contribute to a meaningful and enriching experience that aligns with College values.

Campus Closure

The campus has two moments in the year when it closes: December holidays and between academic years (May-August). Our staff work around the clock, and we need time to disconnect from work to remain engaged and effective.

December Break: During December, there are two official departure dates for students. Once these dates pass, the campus remains open for 1 to 2 weeks until December Holidays (Please check the [Institutional Calendar](#) and see below). If your student wishes to remain on campus between the official departure date and the campus closure date for December Holidays, there is a daily fee of \$30 USD.

Campus Closures:

- December 19, 2026- January 6, 2027.** If students decide to stay in Costa Rica for the December Holidays, the College cannot provide them with lodging, since there are no working adults on campus. If students are facing visa issues or exceptional circumstances related to conflict in their home countries or travel bans, the College may support students in finding accommodations with host families or other types of lodging. In general terms, the College is not responsible for housing during this time.

December

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
29	30	1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16	17	18	19
20	21	22	23	24	25	26
27	28	29	30	31	1	2
3	4	5	6	7	8	9

- 1 Holiday (No Classes)
- 2-4 Caribbean Week
- 8 Last Day of Classes
- 9-10 Student Departures
- 19-31 Campus Closure

January

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
27	28	29	30	31	1	2
3	4	5	6	7	8	9
10	11	12	13	14	15	16
17	18	19	20	21	22	23
24	25	26	27	28	29	30
31	1	2	3	4	5	6

- 1-6 Campus Closure
- 7-8 Student Arrivals
- 11 First Day of Classes (after December break)
- 18-22 Black History Week

- May 22, 2027 until the start of next academic year.** The Academic year end break begins the day after graduation, and the campus closes at 2:00pm. Students cannot remain on campus and the College is not responsible for finding lodging for those students who wish to remain in Costa Rica for this extended period of time.

May

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
25	26	27	28	29	30	1
2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22
23	24	25	26	27	28	29
30	31	1	2	3	4	5

- 3-7 IB1s Final Exams
- 3-19 IB Official Exams
- 20 Graduation Ceremony
- 20-21 Student Departures
- 22-31 Campus Closure

Living in Community

Living in Community

Living in community is a key aspect of the UWC Costa Rica experience. The community includes students, staff, faculty, RCs, educators, general services staff and others that join us at different points in the academic year. Most information provided in this Handbook can be separated into specific areas within the College, but some information clearly applies to two or more programs and has, therefore, been included in the section below.

Community Meetings

Community meetings are held throughout the academic year and require the entire community's presence (students and staff). These meetings, co-led and organized by students and staff (Student Affairs Coordinator), who manage agendas and presentation requests. The community meetings serve several key purposes aligned with UWC Costa Rica's mission and values:

- **Foster Inclusivity:** By celebrating diversity and ensuring a variety of voices are heard, these meetings help create a sense of belonging and support within the community.
- **Enhance Communication:** They provide a platform for the sharing of important information as well as open dialogue, allowing shared perspectives, concerns, and ideas to be voiced, fostering trust and understanding.
- **Promote Personal Growth:** Through discussions, workshops, and shared experiences, community meetings cultivate empathy and personal development, preparing students for a globally interconnected world.

The Anti-Racism, Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (ARDEI) CAS is meant to ensure that the principles of diversity, equity, and inclusion are upheld during these meetings. Additionally, topics on Costa Rican and global issues may be addressed during community meetings and other educational spaces through guest speakers and lead sessions, encouraging active participation and leadership among students. Student family and affinity groups will also have assigned space for “Thematic Weeks”, for educating and interacting with the community to broaden perspectives and better understand each other's lived experiences.

Students are expected to attend these meetings since by participating, every member of our community contributes to a dynamic and inclusive environment where education unites people, nations, and cultures for peace and a sustainable future.

Emergency Drills and Severe Weather Preparedness

Under the direction of the College Safety Coordinator, who collaborates with the Education and Operations teams, UWC Costa Rica has established various emergency drills and severe weather response protocols. These measures ensure that all community members feel confident and prepared in case of an emergency. The College's policies, Costa Rican law, and the standards of international accrediting organizations guide the College's work in this area. By regularly practicing these drills, the community is well-prepared to handle emergencies effectively and maintain a safe environment for everyone.

Purpose of Drills

Practicing emergency drills routinely throughout the year is crucial for several reasons:

- **Preparedness:** Regular drills ensure that everyone knows what to do during an emergency, minimizing confusion and response time.
- **Safety:** Drills help identify and address potential safety issues in procedures and infrastructure.
- **Confidence:** Practicing these drills helps build confidence among students and staff, ensuring a calm and efficient response in real emergencies.

Types of Drills Practiced

Examples of drills that may be practiced include, but are not limited to:

- **Fire Drills:** Evacuation procedures in case of a fire.
- **Earthquake Drills:** Safety protocols to follow during and after an earthquake.

College-Sponsored Excursions & Safety and Supervision

UWC Costa Rica is committed to providing a secure and supportive environment for students during College-sponsored excursions, ensuring that these trips are safe and enjoyable learning experiences. To achieve this, the following measures have been implemented:

- **Established Process:** A procedure has been designed for staff, including teachers and Residence Coordinators, to request authorization for College-sponsored excursions and off-campus extracurricular activities, ensuring compliance with institutional safety regulations.
- **Risk Assessments:** Conduct comprehensive risk assessments of the chosen locations for excursions to identify and mitigate potential hazards.
- **Supervision:** Ensure that the number of supervising adults meets the requirements based on the nature of the activity and the level of identified risk.
- **Staff training:** provide staff training in first aid and ensure that the majority are also trained in psychological first aid.
- **Emergency plans:** Develop plans to activate the nearest and/or most reputable medical emergency response for each off-campus trip.
- **Lifeguards and Paramedics:** Employ lifeguards for water sports and activities such as pool days or beach trips, and paramedics or medical team members to accompany groups when the activity's risks necessitate it.

Emergency College Closing and Repatriation

In the event of a severe act of nature or health threat, UWC Costa Rica has a comprehensive plan for emergency College closing and student repatriation. This plan ensures the safety and well-being of all students and staff. Families/guardians may rest assured that all necessary information and instructions will be promptly and clearly communicated to all stakeholders in the event of this sort of emergency. The safety and security of the community remain a top priority.

Visitors and Volunteers

All visitors and volunteers on campus must be pre-approved and hosted by a staff member, including alums. Any visitor or volunteer who may be left unsupervised with students will be fully vetted and approved by the Human Resources office, following rigorous safety background checks. Each visitor receives a lanyard and badge to wear while on campus, with color-coded passes indicating zones of accessibility.

- **Red Badge ("stop"):** Grants access to the immediate vicinity of the gate, social center, soccer field, with parking lot #1 serving as the boundary of access.
- **Yellow Badge ("proceed with caution"):** Extends access to include academic classrooms, offices, cafeteria, library, with the amphitheater area marking the boundary of access, up to Poas building.
- **Green Badge ("go" almost anywhere):** Allows access to most campus public spaces, including residential and medical areas. Even with a green badge, no visitor or volunteer is permitted in private student residences or counseling spaces without pre-approval and supervision by a staff member.

Exceptions to these boundaries and the wearing of visitor badges are:

- Guests from invited Colleges who are chaperoned and are never allowed beyond the red or yellow zone according to their purpose on campus.
- Personal guests or visiting family members of staff who reside on campus. They may visit staff in the residential area, but they are not meant to interact with students unless accompanied by the College staff hosting them.
- When the College hosts special events on campus such as graduation weekend, professional development conferences, science fairs, and the like, the organizers will work with the Safety Coordinator and Education Director in their role as Designated Safeguarding Lead, to determine appropriate allowances and restrictions to ensure a safe and meaningful event.

NOTE: UWC Costa Rica reserves the right to determine who can enter the campus (Santa Ana/San Isidro) or participate in College activities.

Students with Visiting Family Members

When one or more family members intend to visit Costa Rica and wish to spend time with their student on campus, the visit must be organized ahead of time with the Residence Coordinator and the Student Affairs Office.

Campus tours or visits: Visits on campus are coordinated as a supervised tour of typically no more than one hour, **Monday-Friday between 9:30am and 4:30pm**. If there is a need to meet with one of the members of the leadership team, a counselor, or other staff members, these appointments must also be arranged and confirmed before the visit.

Otherwise, the student should request a leave to visit with family off-campus according to established protocols and curfews (more information can be found in **Campus Leave** as part of the Residential Life section). Families are advised not to make travel arrangements before confirming leave approvals and the availability of the student. During the graduation weekend, family members have more opportunities to explore campus with their students and interact with their friends and College staff, but families may still expect some restrictions according to our safeguarding practices.

For scheduling a campus visit please contact: student.affairs@uwccostarica.org.

Safeguarding & Reporting

Safeguarding & Reporting

UWC Costa Rica is dedicated to safeguarding and protecting all students from all types of harm. We understand this term as the actions taken to promote the welfare of individuals and protect them as far as possible from harm, which includes implementing training, policies and fostering a community culture of safeguarding. We aim to protect children from physical, emotional, neglectful, and sexual abuse, including online, safeguarding their physical and mental health, and providing early support to meet their needs, thereby promoting their well-being in both physical and digital environments.

Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)

The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) is responsible for overseeing the implementation and enforcement of the College's safeguarding policies and procedures. At UWC Costa Rica, this responsibility falls to the Education Director of the College, assisted by the Residential Life & Wellness Director. It is the responsibility of every member of the College Community—students, staff, families, and our extended host family members—to prevent instances of physical abuse, neglect, or sexual assault and if suspected, to report the concern immediately.

Students and family members are encouraged to report directly to the Education Director as the DSL. However, they may reach out to a trusted adult staff member and seek their support in making a report to the DSL. The DSL will instigate the required protocols to document and address the concern according to the College's Safeguarding Policy and Costa Rican law. The Director of Residential Life & Wellness serves as the Deputy DSL.

UWC Costa Rica has a Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy and a Student Procedure for Reporting Safeguarding cases that can be accessed in the links below:

- [Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy](#)
- [Student Procedure for Reporting Safeguarding Cases](#)

You may also contact our Safeguarding Lead & Deputy Safeguarding Lead at:

Katy de la Garza (She/Her)

Education Director & Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)

katy.delagarza@uwccostarica.org
/dsl@uwccostarica.org

Leila Mata (She/Her)

Residential Life & Wellness Director & Deputy Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)

leila.mata@uwccostarica.org

San José, Costa Rica | uwccostarica.org

Attendance Policy

At UWC Costa Rica, attendance to classes and activities from our three educational programs (Academics, Co-Curricular & Residential Life & Wellness) and our community is fundamental for academic success, holistic development, integration and obtaining the UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate. This section outlines expectations and consequences for absences, emphasizing the need for authorized absences to be validated by proper documentation.

In a UWC environment, presence is not just logistical; it is philosophical. Our model is built on the idea that education happens through community. The classroom is not simply a site of content delivery; it is a space of dialogue, disagreement, shared inquiry, and mutual transformation.

When a student is absent, they are not just missing information. They are absent from the collective experience of learning. Their voice is missing from the conversation. Their perspective, shaped by their unique cultural and personal background, is not present to challenge or enrich others. (Zeenat Ansari, 2026)

Importance of Attendance Beyond Academic Classes

Active participation across all educational programs—from academic classes, mentor meetings, and future pathways counseling sessions, to co-curricular activities and residential life meetings, wellness and wellbeing sessions, community meetings and transitional activities—is essential for meaningful interactions and personal growth. Regular attendance fosters personal responsibility, integrity, and personal challenge, demonstrating reliability and commitment. It strengthens bonds and deepens the collective experience, reflecting the values of international understanding, celebration of diversity, mutual respect, compassion, and environmental respect.

Unauthorized absences will trigger a series of interventions, escalating from meetings with mentors, residence coordinators, families/guardians, wellness counselors, and Directors, to potential suspension or expulsion based on the severity and frequency of absences. This framework ensures that students remain engaged and accountable, supporting their holistic development in alignment with institutional values and educational goals. Students are encouraged to speak with their mentor, RC, or wellness counselor to work through any challenges.

Attendance Expectations

As part of our educational model, students are expected to balance the rigors of academic life with residential life, wellness, and co-curricular activities (this includes orientation). In the following section, you will learn about our attendance rules and guidelines and the associated consequences for failure to attend. We include detailed information on what constitutes an “authorized or excused absence” and what is an “unauthorized or unexcused absence”. Furthermore, we include the roles and responsibilities of students, staff and families and guardians when absences occur to make sure we support our students.

Authorized/Excused Absences

Justifications for absences to classes, outings and College sponsored activities must be affirmed by a medical or wellness team staff member or approved by a Director of the relevant educational program. Below is a list of the most common types of authorized (excused) absences.

- **Medical Absences:** Absences due to illness or medical conditions, verified by the on-campus medical staff or a note from an approved external healthcare provider.
***Note:** Students must visit the medical team before the class or activity begins to get an excused absence. In case that the student is too ill, they can ask another student to support them and/or call the medical team to visit them.*
- **Extended Medical Leave:** An extended medical leave may be granted to a student to return home for serious illness or medical condition, injury requiring sustained intensive care and/or follow-up, or mental health concerns. This type of leave is arranged in coordination with the College’s medical or wellness staff as supervised by the Director of Residential Life & Wellness, with input from the academic and co-curricular areas stating the commitments while on leave. Legal guardians must sign an agreement of conditions of leave and return before the student departs campus.
- **Wellness Absences:** Absences for mental health reasons, supported by documentation from College wellness or medical personnel.
- **Residential Absences:** Absences for serious interpersonal situations that happen in the residences’ (where a student was present or impacted) that are validated by the Wellness Coordinator.

- **College Recognized Events:** Absences due to having to participate in events or activities officially recognized and scheduled by the College, such as field trips, sports competitions, or cultural exchanges.
- **University Interviews or Essential Commitments:** Pre-planned absences for critical appointments, including university interviews or other significant commitments that impact the student's future academic or professional career. Recognition ceremonies or representing one's country at the national or international level may also be considered if aligned with the UWC mission. Advance notice and documentation should be provided to the Academic Director when making a request.
- **Personal Periods:** Teachers have the liberty to assign students in good standing one "personal period" (PP) per semester at their discretion that is an excused absence. Students should approach the teacher at least 2 days in advance and request this directly (See more information in the Personal Periods section below).
- **Menstruating Students:** Supporting students' physical and mental health is a vital part of fostering a positive learning environment, and we recognize the pain and discomfort that menstrual cycles can cause. A total of 4 excused absences per month for menstruating students can be granted. These absences can be utilized as needed by the student, with prior evaluation by the school's nursing staff to ensure proper support and documentation.
- **Religious Holidays:** A student may request a justified absence to observe a significant religious event, which will be dealt with on a case-by-case basis. UWC Costa Rica recognizes the importance of spiritual life and the diversity of religious observances amongst our student body. Students may request excused absences for significant religious holidays that are not otherwise observed by the campus community.

Requests should be submitted to the Education Director at least two weeks in advance and must include documentation or a brief description of the religious significance. The Education Director will consider the educational impact of the absence before granting approval, and if granted, approval will be extended to co-curricular and residential activities that day as well. It is not appropriate for a student to request academic absence due to religious observance but then attend other campus activities on the same day.

Please note that absences for religious holidays are not granted during IB World Exams since students must be present for all scheduled examinations.

- **Family Emergencies:** Absences due to serious family situations, such as a death or significant illness of an immediate family member, requiring communication with the Education Director for verification and agreement of duration. Immediate family is defined as parents, grandparents, and siblings.

***Note:** special family events such as milestone birthdays or anniversaries, weddings, births, or family/friends visiting Costa Rica are not considered authorized excuses for missing classes.*

Comprehensive information regarding types of leave, their duration, and the request and approval processes can be found under the heading “Campus Leave” in the Residential Life & Wellness section.

High number of excused absences: Students at UWC Costa Rica are expected to attend 85% of classes. This percentage includes excused and unexcused absences. If students are having a high number of excused absences, the College will contact the student’s parents or guardians to determine if our educational model and environment is the most suitable for the physical, mental health or family situation students are experiencing and determine next steps.

Unauthorized/Unexcused Absences

Any absence not pre-approved or lacking justification from the authorized absences list above is considered unauthorized (unexcused).

Note on non-Costa Rican National Holidays: While the College honors the cultural diversity and religious practices of our students, it is not a practice to recognize the national holidays of other countries as a reason for excused absences from education related obligations. National holidays of Costa Rica, our host country, are observed and celebrated on campus.

Clarification on absences: a student can be marked absent even when they are physically in class if the student is doing something not related to the lesson. In this case, the teacher would warn the student that this might happen. If the student continues not paying attention and is involved in non-subject related tasks, they will be marked absent.

Attendance Roles and Responsibilities

- **Students:** Must notify teachers, Residence Coordinators, Wellness and Co-curricular teams in advance of planned absences, manage communication during illness, and follow up on missed work.
- **Teachers/Educators/RCs:** Manage excused absences for events or trips, and offer support for catching up on missed lessons, tests, quizzes, activities and exams when the absence was excused.
- **Mentors:** Monitor attendance, facilitate the intervention plans and stages, and communicate with the Education program Directors and/or the Deputy Head, as applicable, about attendance issues.
- **Families/Legal Guardian(s):** Monitor their child's attendance and academic performance, encouraging responsibility and accountability from home, especially to prevent their child from progressing to unexcused absences stages that have disciplinary consequences.

Academic Absence Management

To ensure the success of our intentional learning community at UWC Costa Rica and robust academic outcomes, students must attend at least 85% of classes. Missing more than 15% of the academic commitments (including mentor and community meetings), with excused or unexcused absences, will put the student at risk of receiving the completion certificate from UWC Costa Rica.

Unexcused Absences: Academics

The accumulation of unexcused academic absences over the course of one semester across all enrolled classes, community meetings, academic activities, and meetings related to mentor groups will lead to interventions at various stages.

Each missed class, activity, or meeting counts as one absence.

Academic Unexcused Absence Management

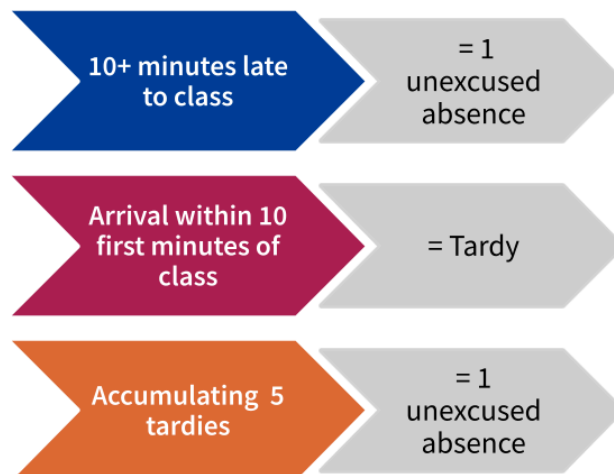
Stage	Consequence
Stage 1 (6 absences)	The student meets with the mentor and a first official notification is sent via email.
Stage 2 (12 absences)	Once stage 2 is confirmed, the mentor informs the Academic Director, who in turn informs the families/guardians of the concern. • The mentor and student meet to discuss an improvement plan. • The student is restricted to campus during a specified weekend (typically 2:15 p.m. Friday through 1:25 p.m. Monday). • The student must carry a Class Attendance Card with them for two weeks, monitored by the mentor. • Students must meet with a Wellness Counselor.
Stage 3 (18 absences)	Once stage 3 is confirmed, the mentor informs the Academic Director. The student's cumulative disciplinary record will be checked to see if there are other major offenses. • A disciplinary meeting, according to Code of Conduct guidelines, will be led by the Education Director or their designee with the student, mentor, and Academic Director to review the attendance record and previous improvement plans. • A student advocate or legal guardian(s) may also attend as described in the Code of Conduct. • A typical consequence is suspension, meaning a campus restriction of up to 9 days. • The Education Director will inform the student, parents, national committee, and Education Team Directors of the outcomes of the meeting.
Stage 4 (26 absences)	Once stage 4 is confirmed, the mentor will notify the Academic Director and Education Director. • The Education Director will start expulsion proceedings following the Code of Conduct for Major Infractions. • Note that reaching this stage of attendance concern may present severe consequences for participation in IB exams and successful completion of the UWC experience for university admissions purposes.

- The student will not receive the UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate required for graduation.

*NOTE: Number of absences are per semester and re-start the next semester.

Class Tardy Management

It is important to be respectful to teachers and peers and arrive to class on time, prepared for the day's lessons. Students who arrive late may miss important information already shared, interrupt activities already in progress, and generally distract from the learning environment. Consequently, the following rules are set in place:



Personal Periods

Teachers have the liberty to assign students in good standing one “personal period” (PP) per semester at their discretion that will not result in an unexcused absence. Students should approach the teacher at least 2 days in advance and request this directly. Teachers will record this as a personal period (PP).

NOTE: A Personal Period cannot be requested to go for “an overnight”, earlier than a Friday at 1:30 pm, or to come back later than Sunday at 8 pm. A personal period cannot be requested either for the last day before the holidays or the first day back from the holidays.

Co-Curricular Absence Management

The Co-Curricular Program allows students to develop their global awareness and leadership skills, stretch their creativity, engage in physical/athletic activities, find ways to identify and address challenges in the host country of Costa Rica, as well as give their time and talents to others through service endeavors. Activities are scheduled throughout the week between lunch and dinner, and additional opportunities to learn and participate also take place on Saturdays.

Participation Expectations

CAS: Students are expected to participate in Creativity, Activity and Service (CAS) experiences to successfully obtain the IB Diploma. Consequently they are expected to:

- Actively participate in at least 3 CAS experiences per semester, 1 per CAS strand, during their 2-year enrollment.
- Attend at least 80% of the CAS sessions they signed up for.
- Participate in the CAS Community Sharing event, once per year.
- Complete the CAS portfolio.

Co-Curricular Initiatives: Moreover, students are expected to participate in the following 5 co-curricular initiatives to obtain the UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate to participate in graduation:

1. **Conociendo Costa Rica (CCR):** Each year, participate in **at least one** *Conociendo Costa Rica* (Getting to Know Costa Rica cultural exploration trip), besides the one offered during Orientation.
2. **Community Action Day (CAD):** During their 2-year enrollment, participate in **at least one** Community Action Day.
3. **Community Action Week (CAW):** Each year, participate in the scheduled and assigned Community Action Week project.
4. **Model United Nations (MUN):** During their **first year, participate in MUN events**. During their second year, students can optionally participate as leaders and organizers.

5. **Agents of Change (AoC):** During their **first year, participate in the AoC camp.** During the second year, students can apply to participate as facilitators.

***Note:** if students miss AoC or MUN in year one due to approved absences, such as medical reasons, or other authorized circumstances, they will be required to complete this initiative during their second year.

Unexcused Absences: Co-Curricular

The accumulation of unexcused absences in the 5 initiatives mentioned above (non-CAS related) over the course of one year, will trigger interventions at various stages. Each missed activity counts as one absence.

Co-Curricular Unexcused Absence Management

Stage	Consequence
Stage 1 (1 absence /year)	The Co-Curricular team informs the Co-Curricular Director, who in turn informs the families/guardians of the concern. • The Co-curricular Director and student meet to discuss a make-up plan. • The student is restricted to campus (cannot leave campus) during the specific day, week or weekend that the activity takes place. • The student will pay the fees (See below Fees for Missing a Scheduled Off-Campus Excursions).
Stage 2 (2 absences /year)	The Co-Curricular team informs the Co-Curricular Director, who in turn informs the families/guardians and Education Director of the concern. • A disciplinary meeting, according to Code of Conduct guidelines, will be led by the Education Director, or their designee, with the student, and Co-Curricular Director to review the attendance record. • A student advocate or legal guardian(s) may also attend as described in the Code of Conduct. • The typical consequence is a suspension (a restriction to not leave campus for up to 9 days). • The Education Director will inform the student, parents, national committee, and all Education Team Directors of the outcomes of the meeting. • The student will pay the fees (See below Fees for Missing a Scheduled Off-Campus Excursions).

Stage 3 (3 absences /year)	The Co-Curricular Director informs the Education Director, who in turn informs the families/guardians of the next steps. • The student will not receive the UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate and will not be able to attend Graduation. • The student will pay the fees (See below Fees for Missing a Scheduled Off-Campus Excursions).
--------------------------------------	---

***NOTE:** Number of absences are per year and do not accumulate.

Residential Life & Wellness Absence Management

As a residential College, students living in our campus are expected to participate in the Residential Life and Wellness programming as part of their holistic development. Activities are frequently scheduled in the evenings, and additional opportunities for bonding, fostering life skills, character and community building may also take place on weekends.

Participation Expectations

Students are expected to participate in the following Residential Life and Wellness Program activities to obtain the UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate and participate in graduation:

- **Daily Check-Ins:** Students are required to attend daily check-ins with their RC or designated staff, to ensure they are well, and provide resources and assistance as needed.
- **Residential Meetings:** Every other week, RCs hold important meetings in their residences where all students of that residence are to participate.
- **Residence & Wellness Outings:** During the year, the Residential Life and Wellness program organizes community building days, over-night residence outings, dinners and other activities that students are required to attend.
- **Life Skills and Leadership sessions:** These spaces provide students with tools, experiences, and opportunities to develop life skills, well-being, reflection, and purposeful leadership, enabling them to face the challenges of the present and the future, and to navigate with resilience, empathy, and responsibility in a diverse, interdependent, and constantly changing world.

Unexcused Absences: Residential Life & Wellness

The accumulation of unexcused absences will trigger interventions that are explained in the Code of Conduct. Below is a summary of the possible consequences of unexcused absences.

Residential Life & Wellness Unexcused Absence Management

Stage	Consequence
Check-Ins	Once a student has missed 2 check-ins during a week or 4 check-ins in one month, without a valid excuse, this will result in a minor infraction to the Code of Conduct. Please revise the Code of Conduct and how continuing this behavior could escalate the offense to a major.
Residential Meetings, Residence & Wellness Outings	• Extra cleaning duties will be assigned and the privilege to leave campus can be revoked at the discretion of the RC. • The student will pay the fees (See below Fees for Missing a Scheduled Off-Campus Excursions).

Missing Scheduled Off-Campus Activities

Throughout the academic year, UWC Costa Rica schedules a variety of activities, excursions, special experiential or community engagement opportunities across academic, co-curricular, and residential life and wellness areas. These activities provide unique learning experiences outside the traditional classroom setting. Commitment to attend these off-campus activities is crucial. Each excursion results from extensive planning and collaboration by numerous staff members across multiple teams and with local partner organizations. To instill accountability, personal responsibility and honor the dedication and efforts of the staff and community partners involved, students will be held accountable to their commitments and are expected to engage enthusiastically in these valuable learning and service opportunities.

Many scheduled off-campus activities have limited participation numbers, and students must register in advance. Once notified of selection, it is expected that the student attends. Local community members, organizations and UWC staff spend a lot of time and effort creating these experiences and **last-minute cancellations should only happen due to health reasons and exceptional circumstances.** The costs associated with these outings are often non-refundable, and an unjustified

absence can result in significant financial implications and attendance consequences, as mentioned above.

Fees

- o Failure to attend off-campus excursions and activities without an excused absence will incur a **minimum \$50 USD fee** to cover any lost costs due to transportation, tickets, meals, facilitation costs, accommodations, etc.
- o Missing overnight trips, distant day trips and Community Action Week (5 days of activities) may incur charges **up to \$300USD**.
- o All the charges should be paid during the semester of the missed activity. If they are not, they will be deducted from the student's initial deposit.

Students with unexcused absences for off-campus excursions will have to pay fees ranging from \$50-\$300 USD.

Attendance & UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate

To receive a UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate, students are not required to have passed all the IB subjects but there has to be evidence that learning has occurred and students have participated. If a student has reached **Stage 4** in the Academic Program or **Stage 3** in the Co-Curricular Program, they will not receive the completion certificate.

Completing the Educational Journey

Completing the Educational Journey

Completion Certificate of UWC Costa Rica Experience

While the educational model, programs, and initiatives of UWC Costa Rica are accredited through the Council of International Schools (CIS), the College cannot offer a traditional “high school diploma.” Some students will have achieved this distinction elsewhere before enrolling in UWC, and that diploma will serve as a foundational document for university application. Other students must rely upon attaining an International Baccalaureate Diploma, which the College is authorized to offer.

All students accepted into UWC Costa Rica are considered to have the requisite knowledge, skills, and potential to achieve the full IB Diploma, and the dedicated pursuit of such is an expectation. However, the UWC journey offers more than academic achievements and focuses on holistic development and active participation in activities to realize the College’s mission to learn from nature and one another for a lifetime, as well as strengthen common values and ways of living with each other peacefully and sustainably in a global society.

This section will broadly define **minimum expectations** students are to meet to successfully complete the UWC Costa Rica experience, earn the privilege of a Completion Certificate and participate in graduation.

Academic Parameters

- o Attempting the IB Full Diploma and all requisite components (Theory of Knowledge -TOK, Extended Essay -EE, Creativity, Activity and Service- CAS).
- o In some cases, an alternative pathway is determined necessary due to extenuating circumstances. When an alternative path is considered, the student, their family, the Future Pathways office, the IB Coordinator, and the Academic Director meet to analyze the options.
- o Students who do not pass all IB subjects may still receive the UWC Costa Rica Completion Certificate, provided they have sat at least four IB final examinations.

Attendance Parameters

- o Maintaining satisfactory attendance and not exceeding the maximum number of unauthorized absences (Stage 4 in the Academic Program and Stage 3 in the Co-Curricular Program). For more information see Attendance Policy.

IMPORTANT: *Students that do not receive the Completion Certificate from UWC Costa Rica are not considered alums.*

Graduation

At the end of the two-year journey and upon completion of the IB World Exams administration, the College hosts a Graduation Ceremony. All students enrolled in UWC Costa Rica who have met the successful completion requirements as stated above, or are working towards them on an approved plan, are eligible to participate in the ceremony. Those who may be working towards an approved plan will receive the certificate folder and all associated gifts; however, the certificate will be held until the completion of all elements. Students on medical leave, with their approved plans, will be recognized during the live-streamed ceremony, and they, too, will have the opportunity to receive the certificate once they successfully complete all elements according to their approved plan.

Awards and Honors

During the graduation ceremony, the College celebrates a select few students whose exceptional efforts and/or contributions over their two-year journey at UWC Costa Rica have stood out amongst their peers.

Outstanding Leadership Awards (OLAs)

The College presents these distinguished awards to students who exemplify UWC values and represent them through their actions, attitudes, and relationships. Minimum requirements do not limit these students; but instead, they demonstrate passion and persistence in the pursuit of excellence. The College honors these students as true Agents of Change in the community who inspire others to live the UWC values wherever life leads them.

In the **Academic Program**, recipients may be recognized for their outstanding leadership as class representatives, their exemplary commitment to learning, or outstanding attendance. They may also be recognized by their teachers as consistently promoting a positive attitude and classroom culture and/or being exceptionally supportive classmates.

In the **Co-Curricular Program**, students have led co-curricular experiences and/or a project that positively impacted the co-curricular area and wider community. They likely participated with demonstrated commitment and enthusiasm to both their Community Action Week project and additional service opportunities or Community Action Weekends. These are students who model taking initiative and following through with their commitments.

In the **Residential Life & Wellness Program**, this honor is reserved for students who demonstrate exceptional dedication to fostering a welcoming and inclusive living environment for their peers. These students may demonstrate outstanding efforts in nurturing the community, offering support, and ensuring the well-being of their fellow residents. They may also play a pivotal role in promoting physical, emotional, and mental well-being within the community. Through initiatives such as mindfulness workshops and advocating healthy habits, these students enhance the holistic growth of the entire community.

In 2025, we introduced a new **OLA Sustainability** award that recognizes those students for their outstanding leadership in environmental consciousness and action towards more sustainable living within our community

The ERA Award

This top distinction is reserved for and will only be given in years where a student is determined to demonstrate and truly embody the UWC Costa Rica core values of Empathy, Reciprocity, and Accountability across all programs of the Educational Area: Academic, Co-Curricular, and Residential Life.

The student receiving this award will likely have excelled in leadership and surpassed all expectations to foster an inclusive and collaborative College culture. They will most likely have demonstrated a remarkable commitment to personal growth, guided by the principles of learning from nature and one another for a lifetime. The student selected embodies the Spirit of UWC Costa Rica.

Graduation Holds

If a student's family/guardians have an outstanding financial balance with the College as of March 31 of the student's second year, the family/guardian will be contacted and reminded that all outstanding payments are due, including those covered by approved installment arrangements. The College does not notify students directly about family/guardian financial matters and trusts families to have any necessary conversations with their students in the way they consider most appropriate. The holds put in place will be in immediate effect until the balance is paid in full and are as follows:

- The student may participate in the completion ceremony, but the certificate of completion will be withheld.
- The IBDP Coordinator will be instructed to place a hold on the student's IB account, meaning that exam scores will not be released to the student or their designated universities until the College clears the hold.
- The Academic Director will be instructed to place a hold on releasing the student's final grade report.
- The Future Pathways office will be instructed to not release final transcripts or any other grade information to universities.

Holds will be released when all outstanding financial obligations are paid in full and upon verification to the Education Director by the Finance team. Note that international transfers can take 7-10 days to clear the banks, and the hold will not be cleared until the funds reach the College's account. Payments made in the week preceding graduation may not be able to be fully processed in time to change holds in place for the ceremony.

Graduation Exclusion

Major infractions to the Code of Conduct, resulting in suspension or expulsion proceedings, may result in exclusion of the student from the graduation ceremony. An expulsion, as explained more fully within the Code of Conduct, would also be communicated to universities and could impact current offers in place.

Financial Aid and Continuation of Enrollment

UWC students have a unique educational opportunity and have been selected from a vast number of highly motivated global candidates. A significant number of students receive scholarships or financial aid. Continued enrollment or financial aid in the second year depends on their satisfactory participation, performance, and engagement during the first year. Students' families/guardians are expected to adhere to their established financial payment plan, while students are expected to:

- demonstrate a commitment to respect the community and the UWC values,
- maintain satisfactory attendance in their classes and at other activities as described above in the Attendance Policy, and
- meet minimum academic performance criteria or measurable signs of progress toward meeting those standards.

Not meeting one or more of these expectations may result in the loss of a scholarship, financial aid, or even a non-renewal of the Educational Services Contract in their second year. This decision will be made at the discretion of the Head of College or their designate, in consultation with Educational Team leaders and the Director of Finance and Operations, as applicable. The decision will typically be made upon publication of the third quarter grading period and communicated to families.

Student financial aid is based on the information provided by the National Committee and the student's family in the financial needs assessment forms. UWC Costa Rica reserves the right to adjust financial contributions or cancel the student's enrollment at the College if the information given is false or incomplete. If a student's spending habits at UWC Costa Rica do not align with the student's scholarship offer, UWC Costa Rica will contact National Committees for further input. The College cannot guarantee to meet the financial needs of students if the information given is incorrect or incomplete, nor can the College guarantee to meet a student's need if the financial situation of the family changes.

See also Potential Need for Withdrawal in the [Academic Program](#) section.

Family-Initiated Withdrawal from the College

From time to time, and in extenuating circumstances, a student and their family may decide that continuing their education with UWC Costa Rica is not the best option for the student. In this case, the

student is encouraged to speak with the Education Director, followed by a letter (email) from the family explaining the reason(s) for withdrawal. This withdrawal information will be shared with relevant areas, and a date for withdrawal and return travel will be agreed upon. The process to cancel the student's College-sponsored visa will begin and the student's National Committee will be informed. Access to the student UWC email account and accounts to other College platforms will be canceled as soon as withdrawal is confirmed.

Families should also be prepared to provide the name, address, phone, and fax number or email of the receiving school, if applicable, so that official records may be transferred from our College to theirs. Most receiving schools will not accept hand-carried transcripts or grade reports from a parent except for the purpose of application, which is to be followed by official documents. Please note that a leaving certificate, transfer grades, or transcript will only be issued if all tuition and fees have been paid in full. Families are reminded to review their **Educational Service Contract** regarding payment agreements and reimbursements.

As stated in the Educational Contract, payments are not reimbursable for any reason, including expulsion or withdrawal due to medical, emotional, or other issues.

Code of Conduct

Code of Conduct

The following rules and guidelines outline the expected behavior of students during their two-year journey at UWC Costa Rica. The goal of the code is to create a safe, respectful and productive learning community for all members. Over the years we have had multiple experiences with adolescents in our international boarding school setting and the following guidelines are reflective of that and are constantly reviewed.

The Code of Conduct is inspired in the practice of **restorative justice**, which is not to “punish” but rather to help a person learn and take responsibility for his or her own actions by doing something to repair the relationship with the community. They serve as examples of how students can take proactive steps to restore trust and rebuild a sense of community after a wrong has been committed. (See box on Examples of Restorative Actions)

Some offenses do not lend themselves to a restorative consequence. Thus predefined consequences shall apply as described and according to the level of the offense: **minor, moderate, or major**.

General Expectations for Student Conduct

Each student at United World College Costa Rica is expected to:

- Behave in a responsible, respectful, and safe manner, even when others may not--with everyone, everywhere, and always during the two years of enrollment.
- Promote positive interactions and harmonious relationships, even when others do not.
- Exercise self-discipline, considering the common good and rising above individual desires.
- Participate actively in all aspects of the UWC experience, including attending classes, co-curricular activities, residence/mentor/wellness meetings, and community events.
- Be prepared and bring appropriate materials and assignments to class.
- Meet standards of dress and grooming as announced, which may be altered to location or occasion. [[See Standards of Dress & Grooming below](#)]

- Follow any additional rules or guidelines communicated for specific campus settings or events (i.e. classroom, residences, library, assemblies in the amphitheater or social center, sporting tournaments, MUN, service projects, Community Action Week, etc.).
- Respect the rights of peers, College faculty and staff, board members, and volunteers.
- Respect the property of others, including College property and facilities.
- Respect campus biodiversity and natural resources.
- Respect established silence times and designated quiet study spaces on campus.
- Cooperate with and assist the College faculty and staff in maintaining safety, order, and discipline, including adherence to curfew expectations and campus leave privileges.
- Comply with waste management guidelines and prioritize waste reduction, reuse and proper sorting.
- Take responsibility for and become familiar with the Student & Family Handbook and Code of Conduct.

Sexual intimacy is not permitted at the College, or in any setting where a College activity takes place, as stipulated in the Educational Contract signed by parents/guardians.

Standards of Dress & Grooming

Students are expected to meet standards of dress and grooming as announced, which may be altered to suit the location or occasion, while ensuring they adhere to the principles of respect, responsibility, and safety with everyone, everywhere, and always. While acknowledging the influence of a tropical environment on dress choices, it is important that clothing in community spaces remains suitable, functional and respectful.

UWC Costa Rica dress standards include, but are not limited to:

- Choosing attire that promotes a positive learning atmosphere and respects the diverse cultural norms present within the international community.
- Undergarments should not be visible.

- Shorts and skirts should be of a modest length, conducive not only to comfort but also to the varied activities.
- Attire should modestly cover chests, midriffs, and backs.
- Shoes should always be worn.
- Refraining from wearing clothing items that depict behaviors contrary to the Code of Conduct, such as t-shirts promoting alcohol or featuring racist or derogatory slurs in word or graphic form.

By providing flexibility within the dress code, the College demonstrates trust in students to make good choices while enjoying the freedom to express their individuality and personal style, while keeping in mind the impact these choices may have on others.

Mobile Phones

There is ample evidence that shows cell phones are a major source of distraction in the classroom and abuse can affect mental health. At UWC Costa Rica students can carry mobile phones, but staff members can ban cell-phone use for different activities and classes. Students are expected to keep cell phones turned off when they are not being used for instructional purposes in class. The objective of regulation is to minimize distractions, maintain an environment conducive to learning and ensure student safety.

Structure

UWC Costa Rica recognizes **warnings and three levels of transgressions** with these offenses classified based on their severity and impact upon individuals or the collective community. These level descriptors are also presented in summarized form in the introduction to the [Due Process section](#), as well as the explanations for appealing a suspension or expulsion decision. Offenses referenced as examples below are presented more fully in the section **Explicit Expectations for Student Conduct** to follow.

Warning

Level 1
Minor

Level 2
Moderate

Level 3
Major

Warnings

A verbal or written warning informs the student of the need to change their behavior and/or actions that are considered a minor offense in the College's Code of Conduct and cannot recur. Supervising adults may use their discretion to give a warning based on the circumstances and impact of the action, but students should not expect getting a warning and should assume it is a minor offense to the Code of Conduct. The supervising adult may use their discretion to give a verbal warning on a first minor offense such as not wearing shoes, arriving a few minutes late to the Residence meeting, amongst others.

Level 1 (Minor Offenses)

Description: Level 1 offenses are minor infractions that demonstrate a lapse in judgment or a momentary lapse of adherence to the basic expectations of behavior. While they may not pose a significant threat to the overall order and safety of the College community, they still require attention and corrective action to maintain a respectful and responsible environment. Students are expected to be mindful of their actions and comply with instructions from College staff, follow general and explicit expectations of conduct, and accept discipline or consequences assigned by faculty or staff members.

Consequences & process: Students who commit level 1 offenses can expect to converse with the supervising adult and complete restorative actions (See Examples of Restorative Actions table) or face consequences to foster responsibility and reflection.

- These offenses are **handled in a timely manner and documented** by the supervising adult at the time (i.e. residence coordinator, mentor, teacher, educator, field trip leader or any other staff member involved).
- They must be **communicated to parents/legal guardians** as a form of consequence and to seek their support in encouraging reflection and improved future choices.
- The **accumulation of three documented minor offenses** of any kind will escalate the consequence of the third offense to that of a moderate-level offense, as well as any future infractions beyond the third offense.
- It is important to note that persistent minor misbehaviors **can escalate up to the level of expulsion.**

Level 1 offenses are not communicated to National Committees or universities. Students should be familiar with all expectations and strive to always follow them, taking responsibility and accepting consequences at any time they do not.

Level 2 (Moderate Offenses)

Description: Level 2 offenses are more serious transgressions that have a noticeable impact on the order and safety within the College community. These offenses may involve mistreatment of others or property offenses that go beyond minor infractions. They demonstrate a lack of respect for the well-being and rights of others and may disrupt the educational or residential environment. It is crucial for students to understand the significance of their actions and the potential harm they can cause. These offenses may include, but are not limited to, physical altercations, threats, acts of vandalism, theft, intentional actions to circumvent rules, and serious lapses of judgment that place themselves or others at risk. Students are expected to show greater responsibility, exercise self-control, and take appropriate actions to prevent harm to others and maintain a secure environment. The focus is on holding students accountable, promoting personal growth, and preventing future misconduct which could be escalated to the level of a major offense.

Consequences & process: Students who commit level 2 offenses can expect to face stronger interventions and consequences, including restorative actions.

- **Consequences may include** assigning service hours under the area Director's supervision, revocation of leave permissions such as day passes or overnights, exclusion from community activities (i.e. camps, off-campus service trips, residence/mentor excursions, etc.), and other loss of privileges or measures deemed appropriate (i.e. extra required check-ins or duties, confiscation of nuisance items).
- These offenses are typically addressed through a **disciplinary process** involving the supervising adult(s) who witnessed the infraction or who was in charge at the time it was reported and the area director in charge (i.e. Residential Life & Wellness, Academics, Co-Curricular). In some cases, due to the working hours of staff or other scheduling conflicts, an alternative staff member, such as the student's Residence Coordinator or mentor teacher, may take the place of the supervising adult.

- An **Advisory Committee**, which will be formed by the above-mentioned members, will meet with the student(s) involved, conduct any necessary investigation, and consider the impact upon individuals and/or the community as a whole.
- The **Committee will decide upon appropriate consequences and restorative action.**
- The infraction and associated consequences and actions will be documented.
- Upon a **second level 2 offense**, the minimum consequence will be a short-term on-campus suspension of no more than 10 calendar days.
- The area Director **will communicate these offenses to the parents/guardians and their National Committee.**
- A third level 2 moderate offense and any subsequent offenses at this level will escalate the matter to the attention of the Education Director **and be treated as a level 3 major offense.**

Moderate offenses will not be communicated to universities unless the university requires the College to report this as part of their admissions process (UWC does not voluntarily report but will truthfully respond to inquiries regarding events in the second year of enrollment).

Level 3 (Major Offenses)

Description: Level 3 offenses are the most severe violations that significantly impact the order, individual safety, and/or well-being of the entire College community and the values it upholds. These offenses represent a grave breach of the expectations of respect, responsibility, and safety, posing a serious threat to the well-being of individuals, the entire community, and/or presenting serious disruption or harm to the educational or residential environment or the reputation of the College. They may involve mistreatment of others, safety transgressions, or misuse of technology resources and the internet.

Level 3 offenses include, but are not limited to, acts such as harassment, hazing, engaging in conduct that incites violence, making false accusations related to safety, serious misconduct involving technology, and sexual misconduct or abuse (physical contact involving non-consensual touching of intimate body parts such as the mouth, vagina, anus, breasts, penis, or buttocks; intentional physical contact with another person's sexual organs, buttocks, breasts, or any other intimate area of the body, carried out for a sexual purpose or with a sexual connotation and without that person's consent).

Most infractions related to alcohol, illicit drugs, and tobacco fall within this level. This level also includes sexual misconduct and sexual intercourse, which is prohibited in the context of College life, including on campus and during any College-sponsored activity, trip, event, or program, regardless of whether it is consensual. It is crucial for students to prioritize their own safety and well-being and demonstrate respect, responsibility, and accountability in all aspects of their behavior.

Consequences & process: Students who commit level 3 offenses can expect to face severe consequences and risk their continued enrollment in the College.

- The minimum consequence is short-term, **on-campus suspension** of no more than 10 days- (The dates of the suspension will be decided by the school and are final; no changes or exceptions will be made).
- **Additional consequences** may include revocation of additional leave permissions such as day passes or overnight leaves, exclusion from community activities (i.e. camps, off-campus service trips, residence/mentor excursions, etc.), and loss of other privileges or measures deemed appropriate.
- **Depending upon the severity of the infraction and its impact** on other individuals or the community as a whole, **expulsion** proceedings may be started immediately upon the first offense, and the student may be removed from the campus setting, at the parents'/guardians expense, for the duration of the investigation and disciplinary process to ensure the safety of others and/or to protect the integrity of the investigation.
- **Long-term, off-campus suspension** may also be used in extenuating circumstances, at the discretion of the College, and with the agreement of the parents to be present to provide supervision and cover all associated costs.
- **A third offense, at this level, will immediately lead to expulsion.** The focus is on addressing the immediate risks and maintaining a safe and respectful environment for all community members.
- A **disciplinary process** led by the **Education Director**, who is supported by an **Advisory Committee** composed of the area director in charge (i.e. Residential Life & Wellness, Academics, Co-Curricular), the student's Residence Coordinator, and/or their mentor teacher, depending upon the area involving the infraction.

- The Education Director will **notify the student, their parents, and their National Committee** of the offenses being investigated and follow the prescribed timeline and due process [see the section, Due Process, for a full description].
- The Education Director & the Committee will **meet with the student(s) involved, conduct any necessary investigation, and consider the impact** upon individuals and/or the community as a whole. The College reserves the right to isolate students, remove access to technology, and/or limit their access to certain activities or areas of campus during the investigation to protect the investigative process.
- The Education Director will decide upon appropriate consequences and restorative action under the advisement of the Committee members.

Major offenses related to alcohol, drugs and/or sexual misconduct that occurred in year one, do not reset and will carry over to the second year.

The infraction and associated consequences and actions **will be documented and communicated to the parents and National Committee**. Suspensions will not be communicated to universities unless the university requires the College to report this as part of their admissions process (UWC does not voluntarily report but will truthfully respond to inquiries regarding events in the second year of enrollment). The College is ethically obligated to report all expulsions to universities but will only share the nature of the infraction if the university inquires further.

Offenses

The Code of Conduct applies in the College campus, in vehicles owned/operated/rented by the College, and at all College-related activities off campus. Any offense may be deemed severe enough to result in loss of certain privileges, need for restorative action, probationary status, campus restriction (on-campus suspension), removal from the educational setting (off-campus home suspension at family/guardian expense), or even removal from the College completion ceremony (graduation), as well as full removal from College enrollment (expulsion). This includes persistent minor, less serious misconduct not corrected after warnings, or previous restorative, or disciplinary consequences that have been issued and recorded.

Warnings are used as “teachable moments,” typically early on in the student’s College experience, and may or may not be given according to the circumstances and impact of the offense upon themselves or other community members. Students should have no expectation of receiving a warning before an infraction is addressed through the processes outlined below.

As stated in the Purpose section of the Student and Family Handbook, this document does not, nor does it intend to, cover all possible offenses. In such cases where an offense is not explicitly listed, the matter will be carefully considered, and an appropriate decision will be made. The College also reserves the right to communicate in writing with students and their parents/guardians any additional expectations, offenses, or consequences as the need may arise throughout the College year, with immediate effect from the communication.

Disregard for Authority

Students will receive the following level of offense if they:

Minor

- Fail to comply with non-safety related directives given by College personnel.
- Fail to attend medical appointments.
- Disregard gym rules.

Moderate

- Fail to return cafeteria plates and cutlery according to guidelines.
- Fail to always uphold general and explicit expectations of conduct on College-owned, operated, or rented vehicles.
- Refuse to accept discipline or consequences assigned by a faculty or staff member.
- Assist another person in committing a Code of Conduct offense (i.e. being a “lookout,” communicating when a supervisor or security are or are not present, hiding someone to avoid being caught, lying to protect a peer or hinder an investigation, etc.)
- Failure to comply with safety directives given by College personnel.

Major

- Leave College grounds or College-sponsored events without permission.
- Refuse to submit to an alcohol or drug test as requested, and or delay or avoid the testing process 15 or more minutes from the time the test is requested, and/or fail to provide a

viable sample when under suspicion of consumption or as part of a random screening or probationary requirement.

Note: *Refusal to submit a viable sample, delaying or evading the process for 15 or more minutes, will be considered an indication of a positive drug test or alcohol consumed beyond the legal limit.*

- Forge any signature, document, or approval in place of their parent or legal guardian.

Note: *This may also be considered a breach of the College contract if the parent authorizes their child to do so.*

Mistreatment of Others, Inconsiderate and/or Disruptive Behaviors

Students will receive the following level of offense if they:

Minor

- Use profanity or vulgar language or make obscene gestures to another member of the College community.
- Make excessive noise, such as, but not limited to, loud talking, shouting, playing loud music, or engaging in noisy activities that disrupt others' concentration or sleep, especially during observed silence time (this includes the gym).
- Disregard residential duties assigned to them.
- Disregard for personal boundaries and verbal consent in non-sexual contexts, including persisting in physical contact or proximity after a clear verbal or non-verbal refusal.

Moderate

- Physically fight or scuffle, even if done so playfully, but endangering the safety of others.
 - An offense rising to the level of assault (see glossary) will be elevated to the **Major** level and can lead directly to expulsion.
- Record the voice or image (photo or video) of another without the prior consent of the individual being recorded, misrepresent an individual through AI generation, or in any way that disrupts the educational environment or invades the privacy of others.
- Engage in bullying, cyberbullying, harassment, or making hit lists. (See glossary for terms)
- Sleeping in a bed or room that is not their own or sleeping in common areas.

Major

- Threaten a College student, employee, board member, or volunteer, including off-College property if the conduct causes a substantial disruption to the educational environment.

- Release or threaten to release intimate visual material of any student, regardless of age, with or without the student's consent.
- Engage in gender based-harassment, whether by word, gesture or any other conduct directed toward another person including a College student, employee, board member, or volunteer.
- Engage in serious sexual misconduct, harassment or abuse, directed toward another person (including a College student, employee, board member, or volunteer) involving non-consensual touching of intimate body parts such as the mouth, vagina, anus, breasts, penis, or buttocks; Intentional physical contact with another person's sexual organs, buttocks, breasts, or any other intimate area of the body, carried out for a sexual purpose or with a sexual connotation and without that person's consent.
- Engage in conduct that constitutes dating violence. (See glossary)
- Engage in inappropriate or indecent exposure of private body parts.
- Participate in hazing. (See glossary)
- Coerce an individual to act through use of threat of force.
- Commit extortion or blackmail.
- Engage in inappropriate physical or sexual conduct directed toward another person, including a student, staff member, board member, or volunteer.
- Engage in sexual intercourse on campus or during any College-sponsored activity, trip, event, or program, regardless of whether it is consensual.

Property & Biodiversity Offenses

Students will receive the following level of offense if they:

Minor

- Throw trash anywhere other than designated areas.
- Leave the gym untidy, move the equipment outside of the gym or leave equipment where it does not belong.

Moderate

- Damage or vandalize property owned by others.
Note: *criminal mischief charges could be filed by the owner.*
- Damage gym equipment.
- Damage biodiversity and natural resources on campus.

- Touch or feed wildlife.
- Steal from other students, staff, board members, volunteers, or the College, including taking an unattended item and not returning it to the owner or Lost and Found immediately.
- Witness damage, vandalism, or theft without making a timely report.

Major

- Deface or damage College property, including graffiti or by any other means for which the replacement and/or repair value exceeds US\$250 (two hundred fifty U.S. dollars). This includes, but is not limited to, textbooks, technology and electronic resources, furniture, or any other equipment or asset. (Note: replacement/repair costs will be charged to the student's account and criminal charges could be filed by the owner.)

Possession of Prohibited Items

Students will receive the following level of offense if they possess or use:

Minor

- Candles or incense of any kind, unless pre-approved for a specific event after proper risk assessment.
- A laser pointer, unless pre-approved for scientific or presentation purposes.
Note: must be stored with the Residence Coordinator or teacher when not in use. Misuse may rise to the level of a **Moderate** offense.
- Any item of room decor or clothing that depicts alcohol, tobacco, smoking/vaping, or drug-related messages or graphics.

Moderate

- Fireworks of any kind, smoke or stink bombs, or any other pyrotechnic device when it is not part of a pre-approved event and undergone proper risk-assessment.
- Razor blades (other than installed in a shaving razor for personal hygiene), box cutter, chain, or any other object used in a way that threatens or inflicts bodily injury to another person.
- A “look-alike” weapon that is intended to be used as a weapon or could reasonably be perceived as a weapon.
Note: students should seek permission in advance before bringing these sorts of items on campus and leave them with the resident coordinator or teacher when not in use. Example: toy guns for drama class or martial arts equipment.

- A location-restricted knife (i.e. a kitchen knife or scientific scalpel being used outside of the area and for ways other than that which was intended).
- A club or item of sufficient size and weight to be wielded as a club (i.e. baseball bat).
- Knuckles, brass or otherwise.
- A pocketknife or any other small knife whose blade extends beyond three inches.
- Pornographic material.
- Smoking tobacco or other legal products in Costa Rica which include vaping, cigarettes, e-cigarettes, and any component, part, or accessory for an e-cigarette device, with or without tobacco.
- Matches or lighters.

Major

- Alcohol*.
- A firearm of any kind, including an air gun, BB or pellet gun.
- A firearm silencer or suppressor.
- Ammunition of any kind.
- A stun gun.
- A hand instrument designed to cut or stab another by being thrust or thrown.
- Any drug or substance deemed illegal within the host country of Costa Rica* (this includes marijuana).
- Prescription drugs not prescribed to the possessor*

Note: *any unused personal prescription drugs should be given to the medical team in Poas for proper storage or disposal.*

*See Alcohol and Illegal, Prescription, or Over-the-Counter Drugs below for further information.

Prohibited Telecommunications or Other Electronic Devices

Students will receive the following level of offense if they possess, use or install:

Minor

- *Note: All infractions related to prohibited telecommunication and electronic devices are considered at the moderate level or above*

Moderate

- Drones.
- Note:** *these may be stored with the RC for personal use away from College grounds and*

unrelated to College events. It is the student's responsibility to be familiar with local laws for use off-campus.

Major

- Video- or voice-recording devices other than what exists on personal phones, tablets, and/or laptops (see bullet under Mistreatment of Others above related to recording others or generating AI likenesses in image or sound).

Alcohol and Illegal, Prescription, or Over-the-Counter Drugs

Students will receive the following level of offense if they:

Minor

- Fail to list prescription drugs on their medical admissions form or inform the College's medical team of any changes in dosage or newly prescribed drugs.

Moderate

- Accept over the counter, non-prescription medication from anyone other than the College medical personnel or their designates at the College clinic as authorized.

Major

- Possess, consume, give, or sell alcohol on the College campus, regardless of age.
- If under age 18, possess, consume, give, or sell alcohol while on or off the College campus.
- If under age 18, be under the influence of alcohol (any percent Blood Alcohol Content as measured on the College's breathalyzer machine).
- If age 18 or over, give or sell alcohol to anyone under the age of 18 while on or off the College campus.
- If age 18 years or older, exceed the legal limit of alcohol, based on the following measures: (a) Higher than zero point fifty grams (0.50 g) per liter of blood. This range applies if the measurement test is blood; (b) Higher than zero point twenty-five milligrams (0.25 mg) in exhaled air. This range applies if the measurement test is air.
- Possess, use, give, or sell an illegal drug or non-prescribed medication on or off the College campus.
- Possess or sell seeds or pieces of marijuana in less than a usable amount.
- Possess, use, give, or sell paraphernalia related to any prohibited substance. (See glossary for "paraphernalia.")

- Possess, use, abuse, or sell look-alike drugs, or attempt to pass items off as drugs or contraband.
- Abuse the student's own prescription drug or any type of pill or medication, give a prescription drug to another student, or possess or be under the influence of another person's prescription drug on College property or a College-related event. (See glossary for "abuse.")
Note: See *Disregard for Authority - Major Infractions* above regarding timeliness of testing upon request, submitting to test requests, and providing a viable sample.
- Abuse over-the-counter drugs.
- Be under the influence of prescription or over-the-counter drugs that cause impairment to the body or mind. (See glossary for "under the influence.")
- Have or take prescription drugs or over-the-counter drugs other than as prescribed by a physician or recommended and/or provided by the College's medical team.
Note: a student may be asked to provide proof of prescription.
- Possess, use, or sell drugs or supplements meant to obscure results of chemical drug tests.

Misuse of Technology Resources and the Internet

Students will receive the following level of offense if they:

Minor

- **Note:** All infractions related to the misuse of technology resources, or the internet are considered at the moderate level or above.

Moderate

- Misuse or take College-owned audiovisual equipment without express authorization and instruction for its use and care.
- Violate policies, rules, or agreements of acceptable use signed by the student or the student's parent regarding the use of technology resources.
Note: some violations which involve technology, as listed explicitly in other sections, may rise to the level of a **Major** offense.
- Use AI predictive/generative programs to misrepresent others (see also offenses related to Academic Integrity and properly citing the use of AI tools).

Major

- Attempt to access or circumvent passwords or other security-related information of the College, students, or staff members, or upload or create computer viruses, including off

College property if the conduct causes a substantial disruption to the educational environment.

- Attempt to alter, destroy, or disable College technology resources including, but not limited to, cameras, computers and related equipment, College data, the data of others, or other networks connected to the College's systems, including off-College property if the conduct causes a substantial disruption to the educational environment.
- Send, post, deliver, or possess electronic messages that are abusive, obscene, sexually oriented, threatening, harassing, damaging to another's reputation, or illegal, including cyberbullying and "sexting," either on or off College property, if the conduct causes a substantial disruption to the educational environment or infringes on the rights of another student at the College.
- Use the internet or other electronic communication to engage in or encourage illegal behavior or threaten College safety, including off-College property if the conduct causes a substantial disruption to the educational environment or infringes on the rights of another student at the College.

Safety Transgressions

Students will receive the following level of offense if they:

Minor

- Make noise after 10:00pm (when silence time begins).
- Are inside any room other than the one assigned to them after 11:00pm. In case this conduct is verified, all the students in the room get an infraction.
- Possess published or electronic material that is designed to promote or encourage illegal behavior or that could threaten College safety.
Note: *failure to account for traffic or bus schedules will not be an approved excuse.*
- Neglect to participate in daily on-campus check-ins.
 - Missing 2 check ins in a week or 4 check ins in a month count as a minor infraction.
- Fail to wear shoes around campus.
- Fail to immediately report to the staff member on duty when an off-campus leave accountability partner separates from the group, by themselves or with others not from the UWC community.

Moderate

- Neglect to participate in off-campus check-ins as assigned while on College-sponsored activities.

- Are in a room that is not their own or hosting non roommate students in the room after 10:00pm with a locked or otherwise blocked door which would prevent immediate oversight and monitoring after knocking to enter.
- Sleeping in a bed or room that is not their own or sleeping in common areas.
- Engage in any conduct that College officials might reasonably believe will substantially disrupt the College program and/or incite violence.
Note: *if substantial disruption or violence results, the infraction may be elevated to a **Major** level.*
- Throw objects recklessly or with disregard that could cause bodily injury or property damage.
Note: *causing damage can move the infraction from the **Moderate** to **Major** level.*
- Climb on rooftops, school buses or other surfaces not designed to have people on them.
- Discharge a fire extinguisher or set off any sort of alarm without valid cause.
- Organize group activities or gatherings without securing adequate supervision or seeking approval from College officials according to established expectations and protocols, including risk-assessment.
- Make false statements regarding the whereabouts of themselves or their peers when student safety is considered at-risk (i.e. missing a check-in, not returning to campus on time, when self-harm may be suspected, etc.).
- Return to campus after the authorized hour (over 30 minutes late) and without a previously communicated or approved excuse (Note: failure to account for traffic or bus schedules will not be an approved excuse).
- Separate with off-campus leave accountability partner(s) during the time off campus.
- Use online dating apps, social media, or other electronic means to arrange to meet anyone not associated with the UWC community.
Note: *students must not use the parental leave permission system to leave campus with anyone not associated with the UWC community.*
- Engaging in collusion, reckless involvement, or willful exposure in matters pertaining to any major infraction.

Major

- Engage in verbal (oral or written) exchanges that threaten the safety of another student, a College employee, board member, volunteer, or College property.
- Make false accusations or perpetrate hoaxes regarding College safety.
Note: *criminal charges could be filed, depending upon the severity.*

Academic Integrity

Students will receive the following level of offense if they engage in academic dishonesty, such as:

Minor

- **Note:** All infractions related to academic integrity are considered at the moderate level or above.

Moderate

- Cheating or copying the work or another student, with or without their permission.
- Collusion, which means the sharing of ideas or pieces of work or completing work with a partner or group when not authorized by the teacher as part of group work.
- Plagiarism which is the use of another's work or ideas without giving credit to the creator, intentionally or unintentionally (this includes referencing the student's own previous published work for other courses or academic purposes).
- Any attempt to manipulate a work submission so that a plagiarism-checking program would fail to identify plagiarism.
- The use of any artificial intelligence (AI) predictive or generative application or program to submit work as their own without proper citation.
- The use of a translation application for submitting work in a language in which it was not originally written, thereby presenting a higher level of proficiency than evidence of past work would suggest.

Note: this does not negate a student's level of understanding of content or concepts but is a misrepresentation of ability to communicate that understanding in the required language.

Major

- Unauthorized communication between students or the communication with or use of any other outside resources during an examination.
- Any moderate offense in this category of infraction when involving a mandatory component for internal or external moderation by the IB.

Attendance

Students will receive the following level of offense if they:

Minor

- Fail to attend mandatory meetings or community events without an authorized absence.
- Fail to regularly attend CAS and Co-curricular events they have committed to.

- Attempt to circumvent attendance-taking measures for any mandatory meetings or events.

Note:

- 3 minors will turn into a moderate, and 3 moderates into a major offense.
- See Attendance Policy section to learn how excessive absences may impact academic credit, IB Diploma and the granting of the UWC Costa Rica Certificate of Completion.

Examples of Restorative Actions

A restorative action allows students to take proactive steps to restore trust and rebuild a sense of community after a wrong has been committed. The following list is not exhaustive, nor should it be considered a mere "menu" of options. Instead, it is intended to inspire students by offering potential pathways to engage in constructive actions that repair and strengthen damaged relationships. By embracing these restorative actions, students have the opportunity to demonstrate their commitment to personal growth and contribute to the collective well-being of the College community.

1. Participating in dialogues to resolve conflicts.
2. Assisting in campus improvement projects or maintenance activities.
3. Taking on a leadership role in organizing workshops or seminars on responsible behavior (Note: situations of perceived hypocrisy will be avoided, with offenders participating in activities on identified topics of need, but not, for instance, lecturing about the dangers of smoking after having been caught smoking).
4. Collaborating with peers to create student-led campaigns promoting positive values.
5. Organizing team-building exercises or workshops to foster cooperation.
6. Supporting peer mentoring programs to improve attendance and preparedness.
7. Participating in peer tutoring programs to provide academic assistance.
8. Taking responsibility for repairing any property damage caused by one's actions.
9. Assisting in developing and implementing strategies for conflict transformation and/or resolution.

10. Investigating and presenting the dangers of certain behaviors to raise awareness.
11. Supporting wellness program activities and initiatives.
12. Engaging in dialogue with affected individuals to repair relationships.
13. Collaborating with student organizations to address conflicts related to rights and property.
14. Reflecting on the impact of one's actions and seeking understanding from affected individuals.
15. Collaborating with the College administration to improve policies and practices for a more equitable community.

Note: Restorative actions cannot be repeated by the same student during the 2 years and should be related to the infraction committed.

Host Country Laws & Disciplinary Processes

UWC Costa Rica strives to maintain a safe and respectful learning environment that upholds the values of responsibility, respect, and the law.

Adherence to Host Country Laws

UWC Costa Rica holds students to the highest standards of conduct, which includes respecting and abiding by the laws of our host country. Any student who breaks the law in Costa Rica is subject to the jurisdiction of local laws and the subsequent legal consequences. Students age 18 and above have the right to choose to pursue legal action regardless of the College's internal processes. Students under the age of 18, in consultation with their families/guardians, may also choose to pursue legal action beyond the College's internal process.

When the College has reasonable suspicion that a student under the age of 18 has been the victim of sexual assault, the College is legally obligated to file a report, with or without the parent's/legal guardian's and student's consent or cooperation.

Cooperation with Local Law Enforcement

If a student becomes involved in legal matters, UWC Costa Rica will fully cooperate with local law enforcement agencies during their investigation process. This cooperation includes providing relevant information and assistance as required by law, and may also include, for instance, the provision of College video camera recordings, results of drug tests or breathalyzer tests collected on campus, making students available for interview, or assisting with translation in the collection of witness statements. Where a staff member is allowed to be present to provide support, the College will endeavor to do so.

Age of Majority and Right to File Charges

In Costa Rica, those over 18 years of age can directly file complaints with the authorities when they consider themselves victims of conduct that could be classified as criminal. In cases of sexual crimes, if the person over 18 years of age does not wish to file said complaint, neither the College nor their parents can do so on their behalf. However, when the alleged victim is a minor, his parents, if Costa Rican citizens or residents, must file a complaint with the authorities, and, if the victim is a student whose visa is sponsored by the College (as all of our international students' are), the College also has the obligation to file the complaint on their behalf, **even when the minor victim does not agree**. This is in pursuit of the protection of the interests of the minor.

The Educational Contract to attend UWC Costa Rica is signed by the parents or legal guardians, and consequently, in all other matters, regardless of the student's age, the parent/guardian will be informed, such as, but not limited to, grades, disciplinary matters, College communications, and the like. The College does not currently accept the applications of emancipated minors.

Legal Counsel and Financial Responsibility

It is important to note that UWC Costa Rica does not provide legal counsel for students. In the event a student requires legal representation, it is the responsibility of the parents or guardians to secure and bear the costs of any legal defense. Local embassies or consulates often maintain lists of local representation and their contact information.

Notification to Parents/Guardians

If a student is questioned by the police or taken into custody, UWC Costa Rica will make every effort to personally notify the parents or guardians within 4 hours of the interaction. Our primary mode of

communication will be through phone calls in English or Spanish. If we are unable to reach parents or guardians after several attempts, or when we are aware of an existing language barrier, the College will send an email to ensure they are promptly informed.

Separate Internal Investigation and Disciplinary Process

UWC Costa Rica reserves the right to conduct a separate internal investigation into any incident involving a student's potential violation of our College's code of conduct or policies. This internal investigation is independent of any legal proceedings or outcomes determined by local law enforcement.

Disciplinary Outcomes

Following our internal investigation, UWC Costa Rica will initiate its own disciplinary process to determine appropriate outcomes. The disciplinary actions taken by the College are separate from any legal consequences imposed by local authorities. The College's disciplinary process aims to address the behavior, promote accountability, and uphold the principles of our community.

Support in Disciplinary Processes

UWC Costa Rica recognizes that students may require support during disciplinary processes, as offenses can sometimes stem from poor decisions made under stress or without realizing the potential impact or consequences. The College community is committed to providing various forms of support to students as described below. It is important to note that students are expected to accept responsibility for their actions and the consequences that follow. However, seeking assistance and guidance can help students reflect on their behavior and prevent future infractions.

Amnesty & Leniency

In cases such as alcohol, drugs or smoking, students may request amnesty or leniency for their actions prior to any report or being caught.

- **Amnesty:** A compassionate approach that entails granting forgiveness and exemption from disciplinary consequences for voluntarily disclosed offenses. Students have the opportunity to request amnesty by courageously admitting their wrongdoing before it is discovered, learn from their mistakes, make amends, and reintegrate into the College community with a renewed commitment to positive conduct.

- **Leniency:** The quality or act of showing mercy, tolerance, or a reduced severity in imposing consequences. In our College context, leniency refers to the process of requesting a less severe consequence or punishment by presenting valid and well-explained mitigating circumstances.

Peers requesting Amnesty or Leniency: In situations where one or more peers have serious concerns related to the personal choices or behaviors of a student and the impact of those behaviors upon one or more members of the community, these peers may reach out to the area director or the Education Director to report their concerns and provide any supporting evidence while requesting a one-time amnesty or leniency for the student to begin a process of conversation, counseling, and appropriate restorative actions.

No student may request amnesty or leniency, or have it requested on their behalf, more than once during their enrollment at the College, over the two years.

The decision rests with the area director in charge for moderate offenses and the Education Director for major offenses. The College makes no promise of accepting the request but will, in good faith, give every consideration to the request when there is a belief that in doing so, the student will use the opportunity to be reflective, seek help as indicated, and not repeat such behavior(s). In both situations of amnesty and leniency, the College may require that the student participate in counseling sessions with an internal wellness counselor or psychologist, or an external provider. In cases related to alcohol or illicit drug use, the College may also require routine testing to ensure usage has stopped.

Other Supportive Measures

- **Psychological, Psychiatric, and Medical Assistance:** In exceptional cases where a student may require psychological, psychiatric, or medical assistance, the College will endeavor to ensure the student's well-being and make a referral to the respective specialist(s), either on or off-campus. Disciplinary decisions will be made, attempting to balance what is in the best interest of the student's health and safety with the well-being, safety, and order of the community. If it is deemed appropriate to place a student on medical leave, the disciplinary process may be put on briefly paused to allow the student to reach home and then be completed virtually, but the process will not be suspended indefinitely or wait until the

student's return from leave. Consequences, on the other hand, may be paused until the student is deemed fit enough to return.

Note: If external counseling services are deemed necessary, the parents or guardians will be responsible for any costs not covered by the existing insurance policy. Temporary or permanent return home may be required for the student to receive appropriate care.

- **Advocates:** To ensure students feel well-supported during formal level 2 moderate and level 3 major disciplinary meetings, parents/guardians are always invited to attend. For level 3 (major disciplinary infractions), parents/guardians may also choose to engage the services of a legal advocate. At any level of infraction, and in the absence of a parent and/or lawyer, the student may seek the support of a trusted student or adult to be present in the meeting as their advocate. Students in leadership roles, such as residence assistants and student council members, are often called upon to fill this role, but the student may choose any student so long as they are not personally involved in the infraction or its investigation. Confidentiality is of utmost importance, and anyone who agrees to serve as an advocate must understand their responsibility for maintaining complete confidentiality in every case.
- **Residence Assistants (RAs):** Our community recognizes the importance of **peer support**, and we have established a team of **Residence Assistants** composed of experienced second-year students. These compassionate individuals undergo ongoing training and have been elected by their peers to fulfill this role. They are committed to supporting their classmates through personal challenges, offering advice, and ensuring that no one feels isolated or alone. Residence Assistants can serve as a voice of reason and calm during stressful situations, assisting their peers in reconnecting with the community and making amends after the disciplinary process.
- **Staff:** In our commitment to the well-being and growth of our students, we encourage them to seek assistance and support from various resources throughout the disciplinary process. Students can turn to a **wellness counselor**, their **residence coordinator**, or their **mentor teacher** at any stage of the process. These dedicated individuals are equipped to provide guidance, clarifying the code of conduct and its consequences and processes. They serve as empathetic partners, engaging students in guided reflection and decision-making.

We understand that each student-parent relationship is unique, and some students may experience heightened levels of anxiety when it comes to involving their parents in an ongoing

disciplinary process or disclosing the outcome. In addition to the previously mentioned adults and student support systems, our dedicated educational team directors and coordinators (Academic, Residential Life & Wellness, Co-Curricular, Student Affairs, Sustainability) and Education Director are readily available to provide guidance and assistance. They are committed to helping students navigate the process of informing their parents, taking responsibility for their actions, addressing concerns or disappointments, and emphasizing positive outcomes and opportunities for personal growth.

By offering these comprehensive support services, we strive to cultivate a safe and inclusive environment where students can learn from their mistakes, undergo personal and academic growth, and make positive choices in the future.

Due Process for Expulsion or Suspension

The following are the procedures to be followed when students are involved in a disciplinary process related to expulsion or suspension:

1. **Report:** Offense verbally reported to, or witnessed by, staff member and then a written report is sent to the area director or Education Director, as applicable.
2. **Inquiry:** Initial inquiry into the incident is initiated by area director or Education Director as applicable. This includes:
 - Interviews with the accuser and potential witnesses as needed.
 - Additional actions such as video review, as necessary for investigation.
3. **Notification:** If confirmed, that infraction(s) reach an expellable or suspendable level, the area director or Education Director will proceed to notify the student of a need for disciplinary meeting.
 - **Evidence:** Facts, all available evidence, and possible consequences shall be provided in said communication.
 - **Defense arguments:** The student has **3 business days** from receiving the notification to submit defense arguments and evidence to allow for any follow-up investigation.

- o **Alternative Response:** After receiving notification, instead of writing a defense argument, the student may choose to accept responsibility for the infraction(s) and request to move forward with scheduling the disciplinary meeting as soon as possible. Note that in choosing this alternative response and accepting responsibility, the student relinquishes all rights to future appeals/due process regarding the matter.
 - **Meeting:** To be scheduled no less than **5 business days after notice**.
 - **Support:** Student is given **3 business days** to indicate if they will be accompanied by parents/guardian, legal counsel, or an advocate of their choosing [see Support in Disciplinary Process section above]
 - **Parties involved:** Notification is copied to the student, parents, and the National Committee. UWC staff members involved can include Residence Coordinators, teachers, or mentors, the Program Director, and the Education Director, as applicable, who will comprise an Advisory Committee.
4. **Disciplinary meeting:** Held to hear the accused student's version and ask clarifying questions, if the student is willing to respond. A student's silence will not be considered as an indication of being responsible for the alleged fault.
- Students may have a lawyer, family member or student advocate present.
 - The meeting may be totally or partially virtual and will be recorded.
 - Students have the right to make a deposition, giving their version of events, and may choose to answer questions if they wish.
 - Decision to be made by the UWC Advisory Committee members and Education Director.
5. **Notification of decision:** Sent by email to student, parents, National Committee and all involved UWC staff members.
6. **Revocation/Reconsideration/Appeal:** There is an opportunity for revocation or reconsideration, or to move straight to appeal.

- **Time Frame:** Student, family, and National Committee have **3 business days** to file a request in writing for reconsideration or revocation or to file the appeal.
 - Application may include new evidence or objections.
 - If no request is made, the decision remains final.
7. **Advisory Committee meets:** To discuss any filed request and the relevance of any new evidence or objections.
- Held by the committee within 10 business days of notification of request.
 - Decision reached and communicated within 10 business days of the committee meeting.
8. **Appeal to Head of College:** If a student disagrees with the decision of the Education Director and the Advisory Committee, they can write an appeal to the Head of College within 3 business days.
- New evidence and defense arguments may be included.
9. **Final Decision:** Head of College has 15 business days to review and respond to appeal with the final decision, and consequences will be immediately put into place.
- The decision of the Head is final and may not be further appealed.

Timing

Proceedings may be postponed or temporarily delayed due to unforeseen circumstances, such as previously approved staff vacation days or unanticipated sick leave. The program director or Education Director is also granted the autonomy to delay a process for such reasons as, but not limited to, special campus events, projects, or exam schedules where it may be challenging to convene a meeting with all parties present. There is no implied promise of delay for these reasons. When referring to “business days”, student holidays and national holidays will not be included.

A Note on Dishonesty

Dishonesty is a direct violation of UWC's core values of personal responsibility and integrity, as well as mutual responsibility and respect. It undermines trust, compromises relationships, and hampers

personal growth within the College community. Lying to protect someone may seem compassionate in the short term, but it ultimately prevents their long-term growth by shielding them from the consequences of their actions and depriving them of learning opportunities. Moreover, it perpetuates a culture of dishonesty, eroding the values of integrity and mutual responsibility that are crucial for a nurturing and respectful community.

Any student who is dishonest regarding their involvement, or someone else's, in an incident under investigation will be **subject to separate consequences at the moderate to major level**, depending upon the severity of the incident and its impact on the community.

Student Leadership

Student Leadership

At UWC Costa Rica we believe in granting students opportunities to develop leadership skills and become engaged members of the College's community. Our student leaders have crucial roles representing the voices of the students, serving as role models and working with the College's administration to foment a safe and productive College wide environment for them to thrive.

The College's Student Affairs Coordinator closely collaborates with the educational program directors and the student leaders to maintain fluent communication, trust and growth opportunities. The following are some current student leadership roles, but they do not account for all of the leadership positions at the College.

Who can apply for Student Leadership positions?

Student leadership positions are open to all students that show responsibility, commitment, initiative, and a genuine interest in contributing positively to the UWC Costa Rica community. Student leaders are expected to be in good standing with the College and act as positive role models for their peers.

Because student leaders represent the values of the community, students who have committed major violations of the Code of Conduct, including incidents related to alcohol or drugs, harassment, discrimination, sexual misconduct, or significant property damage, may not be eligible for leadership positions. Students may also be removed from their role if they commit a major infraction while serving as a student leader.

Student Council

The Student Council (StuCo) at UWC Costa Rica plays an important role in representing the voices of the student body to the College's Management Team (MT). This body ensures that students have a direct channel for their collective and individual concerns, fostering a culture of inclusion, collaboration, and proactive involvement in campus life.

Purpose: The primary purpose of the Student Council is to act as the representative body for students, voicing their needs, concerns, and ideas to the College's Management Team. The Council also plays a role in the strategic planning of the College by being part of the Strategic Plan Oversight Committee, where they collaborate with the Board of Trustees and staff.

Election Process: Second-year representatives are elected in early April of their first year to ensure they can return early in August to support first-year orientation. First-year representatives are elected at the end of September, allowing time for the cohort to get to know one another. Once the StuCo members are elected, the internal selection of Bridge Representatives and Floating Members (as explained below) will occur.

Structure: The Student Council is composed of 14-18 members that are:

- **Bridge Representatives:** One first-year and one second-year representative will serve on each of the established StuCo Bridges. Each generation can choose which bridges they want to be active in each year. StuCo can choose to add or remove bridges in coordination with the StuCo Advisors and Education Director.
- **Floating Members:** Two members will act as floating members to support the bridges with ongoing projects and tasks and step into a bridge role if required.

StuCo Administration: Bridges

StuCo Bridges help connect students with different areas of school life. Each bridge works closely with staff members, student leaders, and the wider community to represent student voices, improve communication, and support initiatives that strengthen the student experience at UWC Costa Rica.

List of Bridges

Chair(s)	The Chair(s) helps guide the overall work of the Student Council. Their role includes facilitating meetings, following up with members to ensure accountability, supporting collaboration across bridge areas, and maintaining communication with the Director of Education/Deputy Head.
International	The International Bridge connects with Student Councils from other UWC schools to encourage collaboration across the movement. This role supports projects, campaigns, and conversations that promote global engagement and strengthen connections between campuses.
Co-Curricular	The Co-Curricular Bridge works with the Co-Curricular Director to support the CAS program and help organize Community Action Week and other Co-curricular programs and initiatives. They also collaborate on different activities and events that take place throughout the year.

Sustainability and Campus Transition	The Sustainability and Campus Transition Bridge works with the Sustainability Coordinator to support sustainability initiatives and encourage environmentally responsible practices across campus. Starting in the 2026–27 academic year, this bridge will also support the school’s transition to the new campus by working alongside the Transition Coordinator to help keep students informed and involved throughout the process.
Academic	The Academic Bridge works closely with students, teachers, and the Academic Director to support healthy communication around academic life. This role helps gather student feedback related to workload, assessments, and scheduling, while also advocating for student well-being in academic spaces.
Residential	The Residential Bridge collaborates with the Residential Life & Wellness team to support community living and student well-being. This includes helping address student concerns related to residences, the cafeteria, shared spaces such as Poás and the gym, and supporting residential activities and community-building initiatives throughout the year. This bridge is a separate role from the Wellness Ambassadors.
Finance and Operations	The Finance and Operations Bridge works with the Director of Finance and Operations to help improve communication between students and operational areas of the College. This may include topics related to campus services, facilities, transportation, dining, and other day-to-day aspects of campus life.
Communication and Development	The Communication and Development Bridge supports communication and community engagement across our campus. Responsibilities may include helping create promotional materials, supporting student leadership initiatives, promoting events and activities, and collaborating on projects related to alum engagement, graduation, among others.

Eligibility and Removal from Role: Any first-year or second year student may run for election only if they do not have a major/level 3 offense to the Code of Conduct.

Elected members who receive a major/level 3 offense must submit their resignation to the Education Director/Deputy Head within 7 days of the confirmed infraction. Additionally, members may be placed

on probation or removed by the Education Director/Deputy Head, under advisement of the adult sponsor or the co-leaders for:

- Lack of attendance or task completion.
- Behavior that is unethical or unbecoming of a student leader, deemed in opposition to the College's values.

Oversight and Budget: The Student Affairs Coordinator and Faculty liaison(s) oversee and advise the Student Council operations. The Residential Life & Wellness Director oversees the Student Council's budget. The budget supports student-led activities and can provide funds for student family/affinity groups to host dinners or events.

Residence Assistants (RA's)

Purpose and Expectations: The RA program serves as a platform for developing leadership skills among students elected by their peers in their residences. These individuals function as connectors, communicators, and leaders within their residence halls, fostering a sense of community and promoting safe spaces for growth and collaboration. In addition to their primary duties, RAs are expected to serve as role models both on and off campus, support the safety and well-being of all community members, and communicate effectively with staff regarding any concerning situations. Confidentiality is crucial, with RAs expected to prioritize student well-being over potential consequences when sharing sensitive information.

Structure and Responsibilities: Throughout the academic year, RAs fulfill various responsibilities to facilitate a positive and supportive atmosphere within their residences. While each RA reports directly to the Residence Coordinator, there is also a Residence Coordinator designated as **RA Coordinator** who works with all RAs to provide additional coaching, mentoring, and problem-solving skills to develop greater leadership capacity within the team of RAs.

RA duties include tasks such as, but not limited to:

- Meeting with the RC regularly and helping plan and facilitate residence meetings.
- Collaborating in organizing trips, activities, and events for the residents.
- Facilitating a positive, safe, supportive atmosphere in the residence and amongst the student body as a whole.

- Welcoming first-year students to the residence, assisting with orientation and transition activities throughout the year, and supporting them to adapt to the UWC Costa Rica way of life.
- Identifying and advising students who are struggling, helping them problem-solve, and supporting them in reaching out to adult caregivers who can help (medical, emotional/wellness, academic/mentor, and others).
- Knowing the community expectations and procedures, answering questions and advising when necessary.
- Supporting campus leaders by assisting and guiding students during emergency procedures, including evacuations, drills, and first aid situations, serving as first responders until an adult staff member arrives.
- Maintaining and modeling good attendance, behavior, and academic standing, while consistently acting in alignment with UWC values of empathy, reciprocity, and responsibility, and encouraging the same in others.
- Maintaining a positive attitude and high level of community engagement (such as community meetings and events or wellness activities); encouraging the same in others.
- Fully participating in all required training, workshops, and development sessions throughout the academic year to help fulfill the above duties.
- Supporting RCs in complying with proper waste management guidelines (Recycling and Composting) and care for residence and College spaces.
- Completing the RA evaluation process together with the Residence Coordinator in January of the second semester.

Selection Process: To be eligible for the RA position, students in the final term of their first year must participate in mandatory training sessions, complete an application, and undergo an interview with the RA Coordinator and current RAs, using a rubric. Applicants will give a short speech to their peers explaining why they want to be RAs. The election process involves voting by first-year peers and current RAs within their residence and the Residence Coordinator, with candidates needing to secure a majority of votes to be elected. A majority (at least one vote more than half the number of eligible voters) vote is required as the elected leaders will require the trust and support of resident members. Depending upon the number of candidates within a residence, several votes may be required until the

required number of positions have been filled. Three RAs per residence are selected so that responsibilities are better shared and a greater life balance for those in the role are ensured.

Eligibility and Removal: Students are eligible to apply for the RA position during the final term of their first year, provided they meet all requirements of the selection process. However, students who have received infractions related to alcohol or drugs, sexual misconduct, harassment, discrimination, property damage, or any other major violation of the Code of Conduct during their first year are not eligible to become RAs. Candidates may also be removed from the selection process or from the role at any time if they commit a major violation of the Code of Conduct.

RA Evaluation: The evaluation process aims to identify the strengths and areas for growth demonstrated by the RA throughout their role. It also supports decision-making in cases where performance is consistently below expectations and removal from the position may need to be considered. This evaluation will take place early in the RA's fourth semester.

Wellness Ambassadors

Purpose and Expectations: Wellness Ambassadors (WAs) at UWC Costa Rica play a vital role in promoting holistic well-being within our community.

Structure and Responsibilities: Wellness Ambassadors (WAs) have a multifaceted role within our community. They complete tasks such as, but not limited to:

- Channeling observed wellness needs or trends within the community to support impactful group activities and prevention initiatives.
- Collaborating closely with the wellness team to facilitate topics, activities, and workshops to foster social-emotional learning, mindfulness, mental health awareness, and student well-being.
- Supporting the planning and execution of recreational and wellness activities, fostering enthusiastic and engaged participation amongst students and staff.
- Working with Residential Life adult leaders during afternoon spaces and residence meetings to promote general well-being on campus.
- Engaging in open communication and feedback sessions to assess performance and practices.

Selection Process: To be considered for the position of Wellness Ambassador, students must demonstrate active participation in and commitment to promoting well-being within the community. The selection process includes the submission of an application and participation in a selection workshop facilitated by the Wellness Ambassadors and the Wellness Coordinator. Candidates are selected based on their motivation, ability to plan and organize activities, leadership potential, and capacity to fulfill the responsibilities of the role, including active participation in training sessions.

Eligibility and Removal: Students are eligible for the Wellness Ambassador position in their final term of the first year, as long as they fulfill all requirements of the selection process. If a student who wishes to participate in the process has had any major infractions of the Code of Conduct during their first year, the student must successfully complete their restorative action. Individuals may be removed from the process or role at any point if they commit a major infraction on the Code of Conduct or engage in behavior deemed to be in opposition to UWC values, such as, but not limited to, promoting hate speech or intolerance towards others based upon race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, etc.; repeatedly fail to fulfill their responsibilities; do not complete an assigned restorative action; are not able to justify their absences from required meetings or sessions; or fall behind academically and must take time to prioritize coursework and focus on the successful completion of their IB Diploma. Removal is based on a case-by-case evaluation by the Wellness Coordinator, with the approval of the Residential Life Director, and may involve input from relevant stakeholders.

Student Publications

UWC Costa Rica encourages student initiatives and creativity, including producing student-run publications. These endeavors provide students with a platform to express their thoughts, share insights, and engage with the community. However, to ensure that these publications align with the values and mission of the College, and to comply with legal standards of Costa Rican law, the following guidelines have been established.

Guidelines for Student Publications

Official Platforms: All student publications must be published through College-approved platforms and under the guidance of a supervising adult. Students are not permitted to publish their individual or collective works on external websites or social media platforms that are not controlled by the College if UWC Costa Rica is identified in any way.

Editorial Oversight: Student publications will be subject to review first by the supervising adult and then by the College. This will typically be done by the Development Area's communications staff but may also involve any director(s) of the Educational Team and/or the Education Director. While students are encouraged to set rigorous editing and oversight guidelines and work with teacher mentors, the College retains the right to make final edits or remove submitted articles. This right will be exercised only for well-founded reasons, such as:

- Content deemed contrary to UWC values (e.g., nondiscrimination, non-violence, honesty, respect)
- Material that could harm the College's reputation
- Articles that may disrupt the educational process
- Content that contradicts best practices in child safeguarding

Communication of Edits: Any edits made by the College will be communicated to the student author. If the student does not agree with the edits, the article will not be published. This ensures respect for students' freedom of expression and copyright.

Compliance with Values and Conduct: All content must respect the values of UWC Costa Rica. Publications should not include any form of discrimination, violence, or disrespect. Students and their parents agree to abide by these values upon signing the educational contract.

Accountability: If students publish without consent or post content that disrupts the educational process, lacks proper fact-checking, or slanders another individual, they will be held accountable under the Code of Conduct. This ensures that all publications maintain a standard that reflects the integrity and values of UWC Costa Rica.

By adhering to these guidelines, UWC Costa Rica aims to support student expression while ensuring that publications are responsible, respectful, and in line with the College's mission to foster a united and peaceful community.

General Services

Campus Food Services & Guidelines

The College understands that nourishing meals are a fundamental part of well-being and academic success. This section provides an overview of food service offerings, allergy management, food delivery, and guidelines for the use of all food and drink utensils and waste. Cooperation in adhering to these food service guidelines is greatly appreciated, as it helps the College maintain a healthy and inclusive environment for all members of the College community.

Meal Service Times and Options

Three main meals and two snacks are provided each day to ensure that students have access to delicious and nutritious food throughout their time on campus. The typical meal schedules are as follows:

Breakfast:	6:45-8:00 a.m. on weekdays 8:00-9:00 a.m. on weekends
Morning snack:	10:00-10:30 a.m. daily
Lunch:	12:00-2:00 p.m. daily
Afternoon snack:	4:00-4:30 p.m. daily
Dinner:	6:00-7:00 p.m. daily

From time to time, special meal schedules are created based upon campus events and activities. These are communicated to students in advance. Food services staff also cater boxed lunches, snacks, and other meal services when outings are scheduled.

The Cafeteria offers meal options to accommodate diverse dietary preferences and needs. Typically, there are vegetarian/vegan options for every meal service. The Cafeteria Staff strives to provide balanced and tasty choices to keep students energized and satisfied. At the end of each meal service, if food remains, students may go back through the line for an additional portion. Currently, extra meal

service for a fee is not offered, but students have the option to cook for themselves in residences, go off campus during approved leave time, or order food delivery (see below) when they wish to eat other things. A limited provision of cooking utensils and receptacles are provided in each residence, and then students typically purchase or bring with them any additional items needed to make their favorite meals in residences.

Food Waste

All food waste from the kitchen and cafeteria meals goes to a local pig farm as part of our commitment to sustainable food systems. There is also a compost bin by the Cafeteria for organic waste from snacks. It is also encouraged that students only ask for the food they will eat to diminish food waste as much as possible. In addition, each residence has its own composting bin and “composting champion(s)” to handle food waste in their own residence.

Allergies, Diet Restrictions, or Needs

Food allergies and dietary restrictions are taken very seriously. To ensure the safety and well-being of all students, students and families are expected to follow these guidelines:

- Allergies must be reported to the College Nurses/Health Team and Residential Coordinators (RCs) during the initial health assessment. This information is crucial for cafeteria staff to prepare safe and suitable meals.
- Medical information provided on the health assessment form is shared with relevant teams, including the cafeteria, to ensure proper food management for students with food intolerances or allergies.
- While the cafeteria team does its best to accommodate allergies and dietary restrictions, it is the responsibility of students to inquire about the ingredients when in doubt. The cafeteria staff will be happy to assist with ingredient information.
- When a student is unwell and requires a special meal due to their condition, the medical team will request a modified meal, and students are expected to adhere to their recommendations.
- In cases when a student is in the Poas medical area, our medical team can request the cafeteria to deliver specific meals as needed to ensure students receive appropriate nourishment.

Currently the College is unable to provide halal or kosher meal options.

Responsibility to Return Plates and Utensils

Students are encouraged to be responsible stewards of their dining experience. After each meal, it is essential for students to return their used plates and utensils to the Cafeteria in a timely manner. This practice allows for proper sanitation before the next meal service, ensuring a clean and hygienic dining environment for everyone. It also reflects care and consideration for our cleaning team.

Drinking Containers

To promote sustainability and personal responsibility, each student is provided with a College-issued drinking mug. However, students are also welcome to use their own personal drink receptacles if they prefer. It is the student's responsibility to keep their drink containers clean and well-maintained. Regular washing is essential to prevent the spread of germs and maintain a safe dining experience.

Ordering Food Delivery or Groceries

Students have the option to order food delivery or groceries, but it is important to note that the College does not offer meal credits or reimbursements for such expenses. To safeguard the campus environment and wildlife, as well as avoid cases of food spoilage and related illnesses, the College has established specific guidelines for these deliveries. Students are responsible for promptly collecting their orders at the campus gate upon arrival and disposing of related waste in the proper waste disposal bin (general garbage, recycling or compost bin), and any deliveries left unattended for **more than three hours** will be disposed of by security guards. No reimbursement will be provided for discarded items.

Campus Gym

The College gym is available to all members of the UWC Costa Rica community and is intended to support physical exercise, fitness, and well-being. To help maintain a safe, respectful, and welcoming environment, all users are expected to uphold the following guidelines:

1. Return weights and equipment to their designated places after use.
2. Avoid dropping dumbbells, plates, or other equipment on the floor.

3. Keep the gym clean and tidy at all times.
4. Respect the shared nature of the space by avoiding excessive noise or loud music. Please note that campus quiet hours begin at 10:00 p.m.
5. Do not bring food or open drink containers into the gym.
6. Wear appropriate fitness attire, including shoes and proper chest coverings.
7. Be respectful and courteous to others using the space.
8. Respect the designated Semilles/women's training hour from Monday to Friday, 4:00–5:00 p.m.
9. The gym may only be used for sports, fitness, and wellness-related activities. Initiations or any other non-sports-related activities are not permitted.
10. Students are expected to follow the instructions of faculty or staff members when asked to correct unsafe or inappropriate behavior.

Students are responsible for managing their own exercise routines and using equipment safely and appropriately. The gym does not have adult supervision, and users are expected to act responsibly at all times. The College is not responsible for injuries resulting from negligence, misuse of equipment, or lack of proper knowledge or training by the student.

It is important to note that failure to follow these expectations may result in disciplinary action in accordance with the College's Code of Conduct. Students may also be held financially responsible for the loss, theft, or damage of gym equipment caused by misuse, negligence, or unauthorized removal from the gym area. Damaging gym equipment due to negligence may result in students being charged the cost of repair or replacement. Gym equipment may not be removed from the designated gym space without prior authorization.

For safety and accountability purposes, the gym area is monitored by security cameras without audio recording.

College Transportation: Provision and Use

Utilizing College transportation is a privilege provided to students at UWC Costa Rica. Students are expected to maintain respectful and courteous behavior, demonstrate punctuality, cooperate with

transportation staff, and care for the environment while using College transportation. Additionally, students are responsible for their own safety, promptly reporting any issues or concerns and complying with all College policies and Costa Rican laws during transportation. By adhering to these guidelines, students contribute to a positive and safe transportation experience for themselves and their peers. The Code of Conduct addresses disciplinary infractions and consequences related to transportation.

Airport Shuttles

The College provides transportation services during officially assigned dates for student arrivals and departures. Students traveling outside of official travel dates are responsible for:

- Arranging their own transportation to and from the airport or bus terminal (via taxi, Uber, or one of many shuttle businesses that exist and can be reserved online in advance).
- Submitting their permission to leave campus, reserving their spots, and allocating pick-up and departure times accordingly.

Immigration Office Travel and Visa Information

The following guidelines are meant to prepare students and their families for their journey to and from campus, including obtaining necessary visas and managing travel documentation.

College Support and Responsibilities

- **Visa Application Support:** The College will accompany students in any process outside campus related to the Costa Rican student visa application, such as fingerprinting, consular registration, and the DIMEX (Residency Card) process. The College applies for the entry visa (if applicable) and the student visa according to the terms provided by Migración Costa Rica Office. However, it is important to note that the approval process is beyond the College's control and can take up to several months or longer, depending upon the student's passport and that country's diplomatic relationship with Costa Rica. The immigration team will keep students and families informed of progress when a process is delayed, especially if it may impact their ability to leave the country during longer travel periods.
- **Immigration Office Hours:** The College's immigration office is open Monday to Friday from 7:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. and is located in the central administrative area referred to as "Arenal."

- **Document Handling:** The College's immigration staff will return passports and documents (if applicable) to students during working hours the week before the holidays.
- **Passports Safekeeping:** The College's immigration office offers safekeeping for passports if students wish to save them there. An additional option exists for students to store their passports in their RC's home safe. The College strongly advised that students take advantage of safekeeping options and will not be responsible for passports not under its control or delays in travel due to lost passports.

Visas and Passports

- **Transit Visas:** Transit visas for travel to or from UWC Costa Rica are the student's responsibility. The College may support finding related information and only accompany students that are minors if it is an emergency, or if there are no other available routes to fly.
- **Application Timeline:** Students must apply for transit visas at least three months before the departure date.
- **Passports:** Requests or renewals of passports are the responsibility of students and their families. Keep in mind that most countries require an expiration date which is always at least six months in the future, so plan renewal processes accordingly.
- **Parental and Relatives' Entry Visas:** Costa Rican Migration Authority does not allow the College to apply for entry visas for parents and relatives. Those who wish to visit students in Costa Rica must manage their own visa processes as applicable.
- **University Visas:** Any visas required to attend universities are the responsibility of students and their families.

Deadlines and Emergencies

- **Paperwork Submission:** If students do not submit immigration paperwork by the deadline informed by the College, they must provide it no later than mid-August. Otherwise, this could seriously delay the student visa and impact their ability to travel.
- **Minor Student Emergencies:** When a minor student must leave Costa Rica for unexpected reasons (e.g., family, medical), the Residential Life and Wellness team will inform the College's immigration office at least two working days in advance to process the minor exit permit if

needed. In emergencies, the College's immigration office will provide as much support as possible.

- **Preferred Scheduling:** When possible and according to the established official travel dates on the institutional calendar, students and their families are encouraged to schedule departures during regular weekdays because government/private offices and embassies are typically closed on weekends if there are any issues with travel documents.

Student Travel and Visa Cancellation at Graduation

- **Travel Plans Notification:** Students must inform the College of their travel plans to leave Costa Rica during holidays. The Residential Life team organizes the collection of this information and approves leave requests. We ask families/guardians to please provide the College the December break plans at the beginning of November each year.
- **First-Year Students:** Must depart from campus and Costa Rica during the official departure dates at the end of the College year. If they remain in the country, the immigration team will not be responsible for any issues that occur and may jeopardize their visa status.
- **Scholarship Students:** Students with full scholarships must leave during the official departure dates. Depending on the scholarship conditions, the Admissions team assists with travel arrangements.
- **Second-Year Student Visa (DIMEX):** Residency in Costa Rica must be canceled within two weeks after graduation, and students must depart the country before this date to have a valid exit. Families should keep this in mind if they, or the student, wish to travel to Costa Rica after graduation. Students are reminded that their visa remains College-sponsored and should not engage in any activities that would reflect negatively upon the College and their ability to gain approval for future students' visas.

Importance of Document Consistency: No Name Changes

There can be many reasons why a young adult may desire to officially change their name; these are dependent upon family support and the legal age in the country(ies) issuing their birth certificate and passport(s). For instance, a student may wish to take on the surname of an adoptive parent, or someone deciding their gender or non-binary designation may wish to change their given name to one that they believe to be more fitting. However, in all of these situations, the College strongly advises

against making these decisions during their time of enrollment and away from their home countries due to the complexities of the process. Most importantly, students and their families need to consider the impact this could have on their university application and visa process in the immediate future.

Maintaining Consistency in Personal Documents

For the smooth processing of university applications and visa approvals, it is crucial that the names and birthdates on the following documents match perfectly:

- Birth Certificate
- Passport
- College Records (IB exam registration and results, UWC transcript)

Potential Impacts of Name Changes

Name changes can lead to complications and delays, particularly in the following areas:

- **University Admissions:** Universities require consistent identification documents. Discrepancies can result in delays or application rejections.
- **Visa Approvals:** Visa authorities verify identity across multiple documents. Inconsistent names or birth dates can cause significant delays or denials.

Guidelines for Students and Families

- **No Changes After Year 1:** Name changes are not recommended after the first year of enrollment. This ensures all documents can be updated and processed in a timely manner. From the beginning of Year 2, students will be enrolled in the IB online system, and the information given there should match the passport and birth certificate exactly as well as university applications to ensure the smoothest possible process.
- **Legal Procedures:** Understand and complete all necessary legal procedures for a name change in both your home country and Costa Rica (DIMEX) before the end of the first year.
- **Update All Documents:** Ensure that all identification documents, including passports and birth certificates, reflect the name change. Coordinate with the UWC Costa Rica administration to update all College records, but only after official government-issued documents have been

provided from the home country. Please be advised that the College's immigration office will not request a name change in the residency card to the Migración Costa Rica Office.

Security on Campus

A local company with a long-standing relationship with the College provides 24/7 security coverage on campus. All personnel dispatched to UWC Costa Rica have undergone rigorous background checks and training to ensure their suitability for working with us. At least two guards are always on duty, with one monitoring the gate and campus access while the other(s) monitors campus activities and perimeter security by walking around. Many of our guards have been with the College for a significant number of years and enjoy interacting with students building a rapport while being very knowledgeable of campus procedures and expectations for student behavior.

The guards only monitor public spaces on campus through their walkabouts and surveillance system. They will only enter residences or private areas if there is an emergency or immediate threat to safety. Guards are authorized to conduct searches of personal property for prohibited items at the gate or in public spaces on campus. These may be random checks or intentional based on witnessed behaviors. If a guard observes suspicious behavior or finds prohibited items, they report it to the staff member(s) and/or the administrator on duty to respond and follow up with the students. The guards are also trained to react and assist with emergency drills and severe weather response.

Cameras: We have installed security cameras throughout the campus and on College transportation vehicles. Cameras are not installed in areas where students and staff have a reasonable expectation of privacy, such as in bathrooms, student rooms, offices or classrooms. The objective of the security cameras is to keep our students and staff safe. At UWC Costa Rica we do not monitor our students 24/7, and we only review the videos when safeguarding or disciplinary situations emerge that merit it. A limited number of security and administrative staff members have access to the video footage.

Staff and students are prohibited from unauthorized use, tampering with or interfering with video recordings and/or video camera equipment.

Security Deposit

A Security Deposit fee of \$500 USD will be required as a one-time-only fee to cover any damages that may occur. The College may approve some discretionary expenses to be deducted from the deposit individually. The Financial Office will provide a statement at the end of the first year, summarizing all costs, and an invoice for the second year to cover the remaining fee.

Communication

Communication

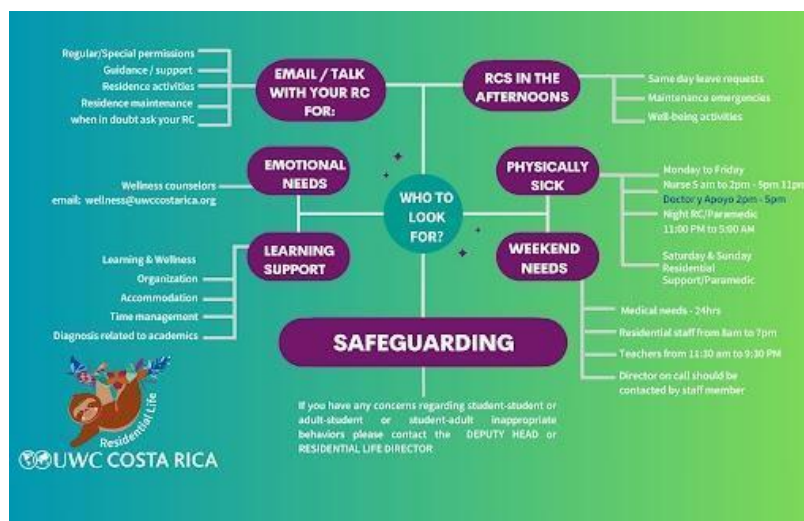
Communication at UWC Costa Rica relies on a variety of channels including email, newsletters, blogs, WhatsApp groups, “Cafecitos” (coffee time), and a community Intranet. Below are some guidelines on how to communicate between the different stakeholders.

Students & Staff

To ensure timely and efficient communication between students and staff, the College uses Google/G-Suite as the official communication method among the UWC Costa Rica community. The College email, chat, website, intranet, official social media platforms, community and in-person meetings are the official ways of communication between students and staff. Students are expected to **check their email daily** and receive official notifications and information by this means.

The College uses G-Suite, the official communication method among the UWC Costa Rica community.

Students always have someone available to talk with in times of emotional or academic need, illness, crisis or emergency situations. Images such as the one below, describing the most typical reasons why a student may want to reach out can be found posted prominently in public spaces around campus and centrally located in all residences.



Families/Guardians with Students

At UWC Costa Rica, we deeply value the connection between students and their families. Staying connected with loved ones while pursuing an educational journey at UWC Costa Rica is important. Families, guardians and friends are strongly advised to communicate through phone calls, online messages, or video chats, to maintain contact with students. The College does not endorse Social Media groups set up by students or family members as official methods of communication.

Challenges with Packages: College staff cannot help with collecting mailed packages (see Customs Clearance below). Due to the complexities and challenges associated with international shipping and Costa Rican custom procedures, the College cannot collect, store, or process mailed packages on behalf of the students. For this reason, we ask all families to please refrain from sending packages unless it concerns official documentation.

Consequently, for special occasions such as birthdays or celebrations, families may arrange for treats or surprises to be delivered to campus from local providers. This ensures timely delivery and avoids the complexities associated with international shipments and customs clearance.

College Address for Mailing Official Documentation: Use the following address format for sending official documentation to our College:

[STUDENT NAME]
Colegio del Mundo Unido Costa Rica
400 metros norte de la esquina noreste de la iglesia Católica
Santa Ana, San José, Costa Rica 10901
Apartado Postal (P.O. Box): 678-6150
Phone number: +506 2282-5609

Costa Rica Customs Clearance (for your awareness)

When sending packages internationally, it is crucial to consider customs procedures and taxes imposed by the Costa Rican authorities. If a package is held at customs, the recipient will get a notification and must personally visit the customs office, to proceed with customs clearance. A student would be responsible for arranging their own transportation, securing a travel partner(s) and the appropriate leave request, as well as covering all of the costs.

This process usually involves waiting for an agent to open the package, reviewing its contents, and paying any applicable taxes or fees, which must be done in cash. Additionally, if the package contains restricted items such as food, medication, make-up and skin care, or used clothing, the student will

most likely be required to obtain permits from the Ministry of Health or other agencies, further complicating the process.

If the student is a minor (under 18 years of age), they cannot retrieve the package alone and must be accompanied by their legal guardian or a designated College representative, necessitating additional legal procedures and expenses. **The College is unable to support this process since it would require the Head or Deputy Head of the College to accompany the student.**

Considering the potential expenses and complexities involved in customs clearance, as well as the potential loss of the item, and both its monetary and emotional value, families/guardians are advised to carefully weigh their options and explore alternative solutions whenever possible. Communication between student, family, and the Residence Coordinator can help identify the best course of action to ensure a smooth and hassle-free process.

Families/Guardians with Staff

The College website, newsletters, social media platforms, College email, and broadcast WhatsApp groups (for families only) are the official ways of communication between families/guardians and our staff.

Residence Coordinators will reach out to parents/guardians at the beginning of the school year to make themselves available. Furthermore, you can find the names and emails of our Management Team in the [UWC Costa Rica webpage](#) and below.

For general information, please write to: info@uwccostarica.org or call +506 2282-5609.

UWC Costa Rica Management Team

Mauricio Viales Head of College He/Him mauricio.viales@uwccostarica.org	Katy de la Garza Education Director/ Deputy Head /DSL She/Her katy.delagarza@uwccostarica.org
Annette Grew Admissions Director She/Her	Leila Mata Residential Life & Wellness Director She/Her

annette.grew@uwccostarica.org	leila.mata@uwccostarica.org
Marcela Ali Finance & Operations Director She/Her marcela.ali@uwccostarica.org	Luis Abarca Co-Curricular Director He/Him luis.abarca@uwccostarica.org
Jose Pablo Rojas-Brewer Development Director He/Him josepablo.rojas@uwccostarica.org	Paula Morán Academic Director She/Her paula.moran@uwccostarica.org
Vanessa Céspedes Human Resources Director She/Her vanessa.cespedes@uwccostarica.org	

Glossary of Terms

The Glossary section serves as a valuable resource, providing definitions and explanations of words, terms, and educational jargon used throughout the Student and Family handbook. It aims to enhance effective communication amongst all members of our College community.

Artificial intelligence (AI): predictive or generative application or program. Software or tools that use AI to generate or predict outcomes [See also Plagiarism.]

Amnesty: A compassionate approach that entails granting forgiveness and exemption from disciplinary consequences for voluntarily disclosed offenses. Students have the opportunity to request amnesty by courageously admitting their wrongdoing before it is discovered, learn from their mistakes, make amends, and reintegrate into the College community with a renewed commitment to positive conduct.

Assault: An offense rising to the level of physical fight or scuffle that endangers the safety of others.

Bullying: A form of aggressive behavior characterized by a repetitive nature, power dynamic differential or imbalance, and aggression with the intent to harm. It involves persistent targeting of an individual or group, creating a sense of helplessness and vulnerability. Bullying can be physical or emotional, short- or long-term.

Capacity: The ability of an individual to provide informed and voluntary consent for sexual activity. It is the presence of cognitive and emotional faculties necessary to understand the nature of the activity and its potential consequences and make a free and conscious decision to engage in or continue the activity.

Cheating: Copying or obtaining the work of another student without authorization.

Citation: The act of providing accurate and specific information about the sources used in academic work to give credit to the original authors and allow readers to locate the sources for further reference. Citations typically include essential details such as the author's name, the title of the work, publication information, and page numbers. Different academic disciplines and institutions may follow specific citation styles, such as MLA (Modern Language Association), APA (American Psychological Association), Chicago, or Harvard, among others.

Coercion: Forcing or pressuring someone to act against their will through threats or force.

Collusion: Encompasses dishonesty as well as referring to the act of collaborating or conspiring with others to break the Code of Conduct, circumvent explicit rules, or undermine community values within the College setting.

Consent: Voluntary, informed, and mutual agreement given by all parties involved in a sexual activity. Consent must be explicitly affirmative and can be withdrawn at any time. It can only be given by a person who has the capacity to do so (i.e. not under the influence of alcohol or mind-altering substances) and has not been coerced. Additional points to understand consent:

- Consent can be communicated through words or actions, but verbal consent is often the clearest.
- Giving consent to one form of sexual activity does not imply consent to any other activity or future encounters.
- Silence alone cannot be considered as consent; active permission is required.
- Past sexual encounters or prior consent with the same partner(s) do not guarantee consent for future acts.
- Consent given at any point during an encounter can be withdrawn at any time.
- Consent must be obtained each time partners engage in sexual activity.
- It is important to note that "No" always means "No," and "Yes" may not always indicate consent if it is given under coercion or when the person does not have the capacity to provide consent.

Cyberbullying: Engaging in bullying behavior using electronic communication or social media platforms.

Dating violence: Engaging in abusive behavior within a romantic or dating relationship.

Deface: To intentionally vandalize or mar the appearance of something, such as graffiti on College property.

Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL): The individual overseeing the implementation and enforcement of the College's safeguarding policies and procedures.

Disregard for Authority: Failure to comply with directives given by College personnel.

Exploitation: The act or practice of unfairly taking advantage of someone for personal gain or benefit, often through manipulation, coercion, or without their informed consent. It encompasses both the specific context of sexual purposes without consent, as well as a broader understanding of treating individuals unfairly to benefit from their work or labor.

Extortion: Obtaining something, such as money or favors, through threats or blackmail.

Harassment: Pattern of unwanted, aggressive, or offensive behavior that persistently bothers, threatens, or demeans an individual (of both sexual and non-sexual nature).

Hit lists: Lists compiled with the intent to harm or target individuals.

Hazing: Engaging in activities that humiliate, endanger, or subject individuals to physical or mental harm as a condition of joining a group or organization.

Inappropriate conduct: Engaging in behavior that is not suitable or acceptable, including verbal, physical, or sexual conduct.

Hoaxes: False or misleading statements or claims intended to deceive or cause panic.

Inappropriate Intimacy: Engaging in sexual activities that are deemed unacceptable or not in accordance with the established norms, whether on campus, during College-sponsored activities, or off-campus.

Indecent Exposure: The act of intentionally exposing one's private body parts to another person, regardless of location or whether the exposure was consensual or requested. It involves revealing intimate areas of the body in a manner that is deemed socially inappropriate and offensive.

Isolation: Separating an alleged perpetrator from the community during the time of investigation and disciplinary proceedings to ensure the safety and well-being of all members.

Legal Actions: Pursuing legal avenues, such as filing a report or pressing charges, in response to sexual misconduct.

Leniency: The quality or act of showing mercy, tolerance, or a reduced severity in imposing consequences. In our College context, leniency refers to the process of requesting a less severe consequence or punishment by presenting valid and well-explained mitigating circumstances.

Obscene gestures: Offensive hand or body movements that are sexually explicit or vulgar.

Paraphernalia: Objects or equipment associated with the use or consumption of drugs or substances.

Plagiarism: The act of using someone else's work, ideas, or intellectual property without giving appropriate credit or acknowledgment. This includes but is not limited to copying and presenting another person's written content, research findings, artwork, or any other form of creative expression as one's own. It is important to note that plagiarism also encompasses the use of artificial intelligence (AI) or chatbots to generate or complete academic work without properly crediting their use. Even if an AI program generates the content, it is still necessary to provide proper attribution to acknowledge the contribution of the AI tool in the final work.

Possession: Having control or ownership of an item or substance. It includes physical possession, where the item is in direct physical contact or within one's immediate control, and constructive possession, where the item is not physically present but is under one's control or in a location accessible to them.

Property offenses: Violations related to damaging or stealing property owned by others or the institution.

Rape: The act of non-consensual sexual intercourse (vaginal or anal) or penetration with any body part or foreign object.

Rape Culture: A cultural environment that normalizes and perpetuates attitudes, behaviors, and beliefs that support or condone sexual violence.

Reckless Involvement: The act of placing oneself in a situation where the code of conduct is being broken without taking reasonable steps to ascertain or assume the responsibility of knowing the potential risks or violations involved. It involves participating in activities, events, or situations without exercising due diligence or awareness of the possible breaches of the code.

Respectful: treating others with consideration, courtesy, and dignity. Being respectful involves recognizing and valuing the rights, opinions, and boundaries of individuals, fostering an inclusive and supportive environment within the College community.

Responsible: taking ownership of one's actions, obligations, and duties within the College community. Being responsible means being accountable for one's behavior and choices, considering

the consequences they may have on oneself and others. Here are some examples of what being responsible might look, sound, or feel like in the College setting:

- Completing assignments and tasks on time.
- Attending classes regularly and being prepared for them.
- Following College rules, policies, and guidelines.
- Taking care of personal belongings as well as shared College resources.
- Honoring commitments and obligations, such as participating in extracurricular activities or fulfilling leadership roles.
- Accepting the consequences of one's actions and making amends when necessary.

Retaliation: Any negative or harmful action, including threats (verbal or written), coercion, or violence, taken against an individual as a direct result of their involvement in a complaint, participation in an investigation, or contribution to the resolution of a complaint regarding discrimination or sexual misconduct.

Safe: Creating and maintaining a secure and conducive environment for oneself and others, both physically and emotionally. “Being safe” and acting with safety in mind involves promoting well-being, preventing harm, and reporting any concerns or potential risks. Here are some examples of what being safe might look, sound, or feel like in the College setting:

Sexting: Sending sexually explicit messages or images electronically, particularly via text messages.

Sexual Activity: Any form of physical or sexual interaction between individuals. In the context of our College boarding setting, acceptable acts of sexual activity may include consensual activities such as kissing, holding hands, or engaging in other non-coercive, mutually agreed-upon expressions of affection or intimacy. It is important to note that consent and respect for boundaries remain paramount in all sexual interactions. Understanding and practicing affirmative consent, where all parties involved actively and willingly participate, is crucial to maintaining a safe and respectful environment for everyone on campus. It is equally important to recognize that sexual intercourse and sexual contact, as defined below, are expressly prohibited on campus, regardless of consent.

Sexual Abuse: Engaging in any form of non-consensual sexual activity or conduct.

Sexual Assault/Misconduct: Any non-consensual or unwanted sexual act or behavior that violates an individual's autonomy, boundaries, and rights. This includes oral sex, no matter how slight the penetration or contact. Rape, as defined above, is considered the most serious form of sexual assault. Sexual misconduct also includes the consensual act of paying, promising to pay, or granting favors in exchange for economic or some other form of advantage for engaging in any form of sexual intimacy.

Sexual Contact: Physical contact of a sexual nature which may include, but is not limited to:

- Intentional contact with the breasts, buttocks, groin, genitals or mouth.
- Touching another with any of these body parts.
- Making another touch you or themselves with or on any of these body parts.
- Any intentional bodily contact in a sexual manner that doesn't involve contact with/of breasts, buttocks, groin, genitals, mouth, or another orifice.

Sexual Intercourse: Any form of sexual activity involving penetration, including vaginal, anal, or oral. Sexual intercourse is strictly prohibited on our campus, regardless of consent.

Silence time: Designated periods when students are expected to maintain silence in their rooms and/or public spaces so as not to disturb students who are sleeping or studying.

Stalking: Persistent and unwanted attention or harassment, often involving intrusive behavior, towards an individual based on factors such as their personal characteristics, relationships, activities, or affiliations.

Violence: The intentional use of force, coercion, or intimidation with the intent to cause physical harm, injury, or damage to another individual. It encompasses a range of aggressive behaviors that may result in harm, injury, or fear.

Willful Exposure: The deliberate choice to knowingly participate in activities or situations that violate the established standards, rules, or values outlined in the code. It involves actively and consciously engaging in events, gatherings, or circumstances where misconduct, illegal activities, or behaviors that contravene the code of conduct are taking place.

Citation

This document cites sources listed as footnotes, including the Juvenile Justice Panel, the International Baccalaureate, and UWC International. ChatGPT was used to support editing with consistency in tone and language.